HOOVER INSTITUTION | Stanford University

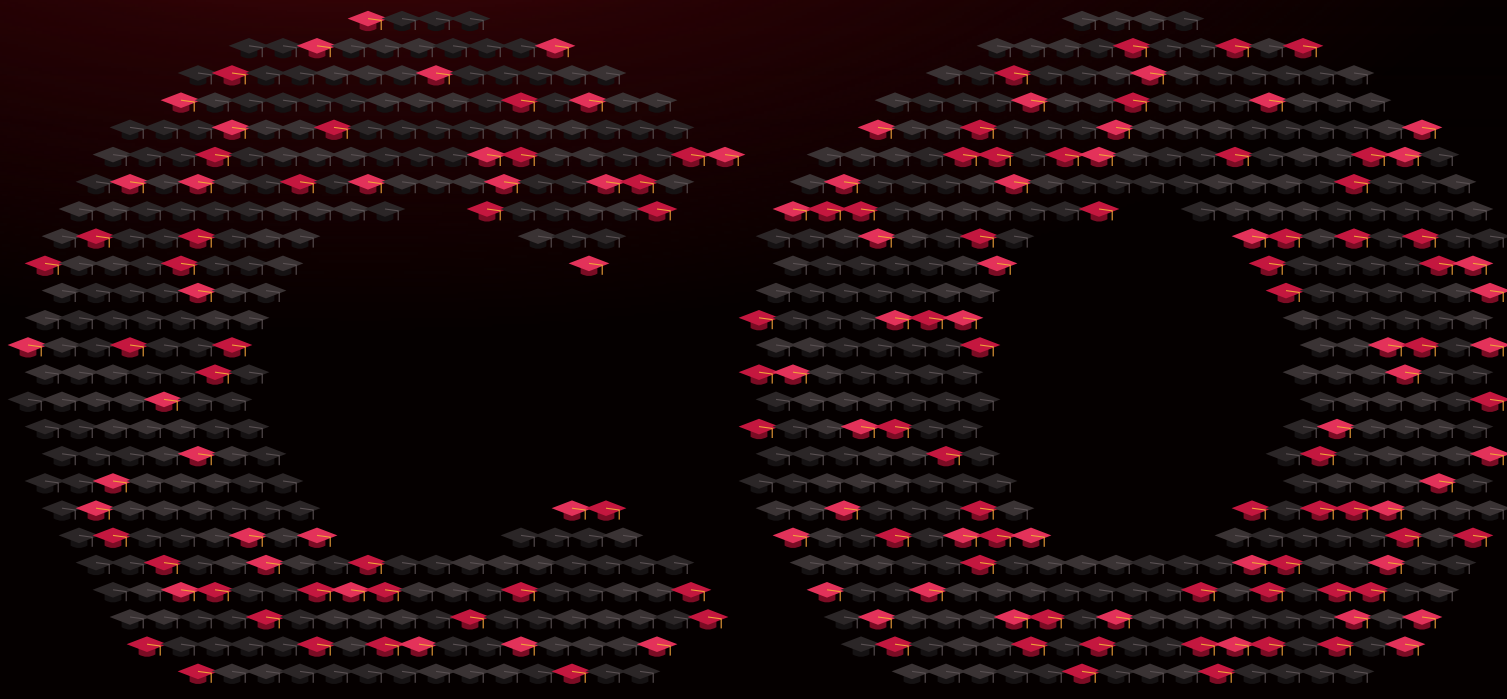
HAI Stanford University Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence

NOVEMBER 2026

The 2026 Colorado Talent Profile

Emerson Johnston
Amy Zegart

The bright caps, **24 in every 100**, mark the international share of Colorado's STEM master's degrees.



This page intentionally left blank.

HOOVER INSTITUTION | Stanford University

Stanford University
Human-Centered
Artificial Intelligence

The 2026 Colorado Talent Profile

By Emerson Johnston and Amy Zegart

NOVEMBER 2026

A publication jointly produced by the Hoover Institution and the Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence at Stanford University.

Table of Contents

OVERVIEW

At a Glance 6

SECTIONS

Section 1 International Dependence 8
Section 2 STEM Degrees 20
Section 3 Where Students Come From 26
Section 4 K-12 Preparation 34
Section 5 Graduate Research 36
Section 6 Do Graduates Stay? 38
Section 7 Research Funding 40
Section 8 H-1B Jobs and Green Cards 42
Section 9 STEM Workforce 46
Section 10 Patents 48
Section 11 Competitors 50
Section 12 Fields of Study 52
Section 13 Students and Money 62
Section 14 Student Outcomes 70
Section 15 Faculty 74
Section 16 Institutions 78

BACK MATTER

About these Data 82
By the Numbers 84
Sources 93

Authors

Emerson Victoria Johnston is a research assistant with the Hoover Institution's Technology Policy Accelerator. A Knight-Hennessy Scholar, she holds a master's in international policy from Stanford University, and is on leave from its master's program in the history of science, technology, environment, and medicine.

Dr. Amy Zegart is the Morris Arnold and Nona Jean Cox Senior Fellow at the Hoover Institution, director of Hoover's Technology Policy Accelerator, and a senior fellow and associate director at Stanford University's Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence.

Data come from the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS), the Department of Homeland Security's SEVIS by the Numbers, the National Assessment of Educational Progress, NSF's Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates and Survey of Earned Doctorates, the Department of Labor's Office of Foreign Labor Certification, the USCIS H-1B Employer Data Hub, the Census Bureau's American Community Survey and USPTO patent data via PatentsView, processed in Python; every figure and table is generated from those sources, and each one names its source.

About This Profile

This profile is a companion to *The 2026 US Talent Report: Benchmarking America's STEM Pipeline Amid the Great Talent Competition*. It applies the report's measures to Colorado: the students the state develops at home, those it draws from abroad, and how both compare with the nation and with the states closest to it in size.

Degrees, enrollment, prices, outcomes and faculty come from IPEDS, the federal census of U.S. colleges and universities, harmonized across 1980–2025. Countries of citizenship come from SEVIS by the Numbers, the Department of Homeland Security's monthly count of active F-1 and M-1 students. Each figure names its source. Peer states are the four closest in total fall enrollment.

How to Cite this Profile

Emerson V. Johnston and Amy Zegart, “The 2026 Colorado Talent Profile,” Technology Policy Accelerator, Hoover Institution, and the Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence, Stanford University, Stanford, CA, November 2026.

Public Data and Tools

The data behind every chart come from the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS), published by the National Center for Education Statistics, and from SEVIS by the Numbers, published by the Department of Homeland Security's Student and Exchange Visitor Program. An interactive version of this profile accompanies the report.

To share any charts and figures, proper attribution is required. This profile is licensed under Attribution-NoDerivatives 4.0 International (CC BY-ND 4.0). Please cite as: The 2026 Colorado Talent Profile.

AT A GLANCE

What Colorado's numbers say

1. **International students earn 24% of Colorado's STEM master's degrees,** 28.3 points below the U.S. (52%) in 2025, ranking 43rd of 51 on dependence. The share is 21% for STEM research doctorates (U.S. 43%) and 3.2% for STEM bachelor's (U.S. 6.6%).
2. **Colorado awarded 995 STEM master's degrees to international students in 2025,** 0.9% of the U.S. total and 26th of 51 among states. Since 2015 the count changed +76%, against 2.2× nationally.
3. **The heaviest dependence is in computer & info sciences,** where international students earned 35% of master's degrees (1.39K degrees; U.S. 65%). No STEM field with at least 50 master's graduates are majority-international.
4. **Among states of similar size,** Colorado ranks 5th of 5 on the international share of STEM master's: Colorado 24%, Maryland 31%, New Jersey 49%, Missouri 83%, Minnesota 51%.
5. **70% of Colorado's first-time students in fall 2024 were state residents** and 0.9% came from abroad. More students arrived from other states (13.7K) than residents left (13.5K), a net gain of 229; the top destination for those leaving was Arizona.

24%

of the STEM master's degrees Colorado awards go to international students (U.S. 52%).

SCORECARD

Nine numbers against the nation

371K #18
Students enrolled, 2024
U.S. **19.7M** · +5.3% since 2015

995 #26
International STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **117K** · +76% since 2015

24% #43
International share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · +3.3 pp since 2015

9.3% #37
International share of grad students, 2024
U.S. **17%** · +2.1 pp since 2015

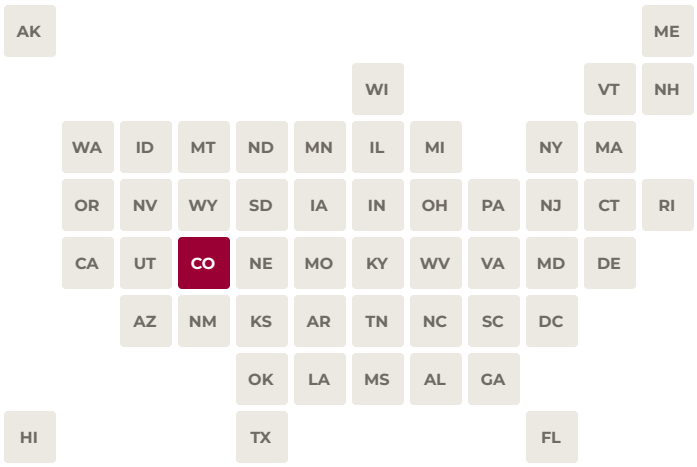
30% #6
STEM share of bachelor's, 2025
U.S. **24%** · +7.4 pp since 2015

60% #31
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · +4.0 pp since 2015

$1.51K #51
Appropriations per student, 2024
U.S. **$11.4K** · +67% since 2015

70% #30
First-time students from in state, 2024
U.S. **–** · −2.5 pp since 2016

$98K #21
Average faculty salary, 2024
U.S. **$106K** · −8.6% since 2016

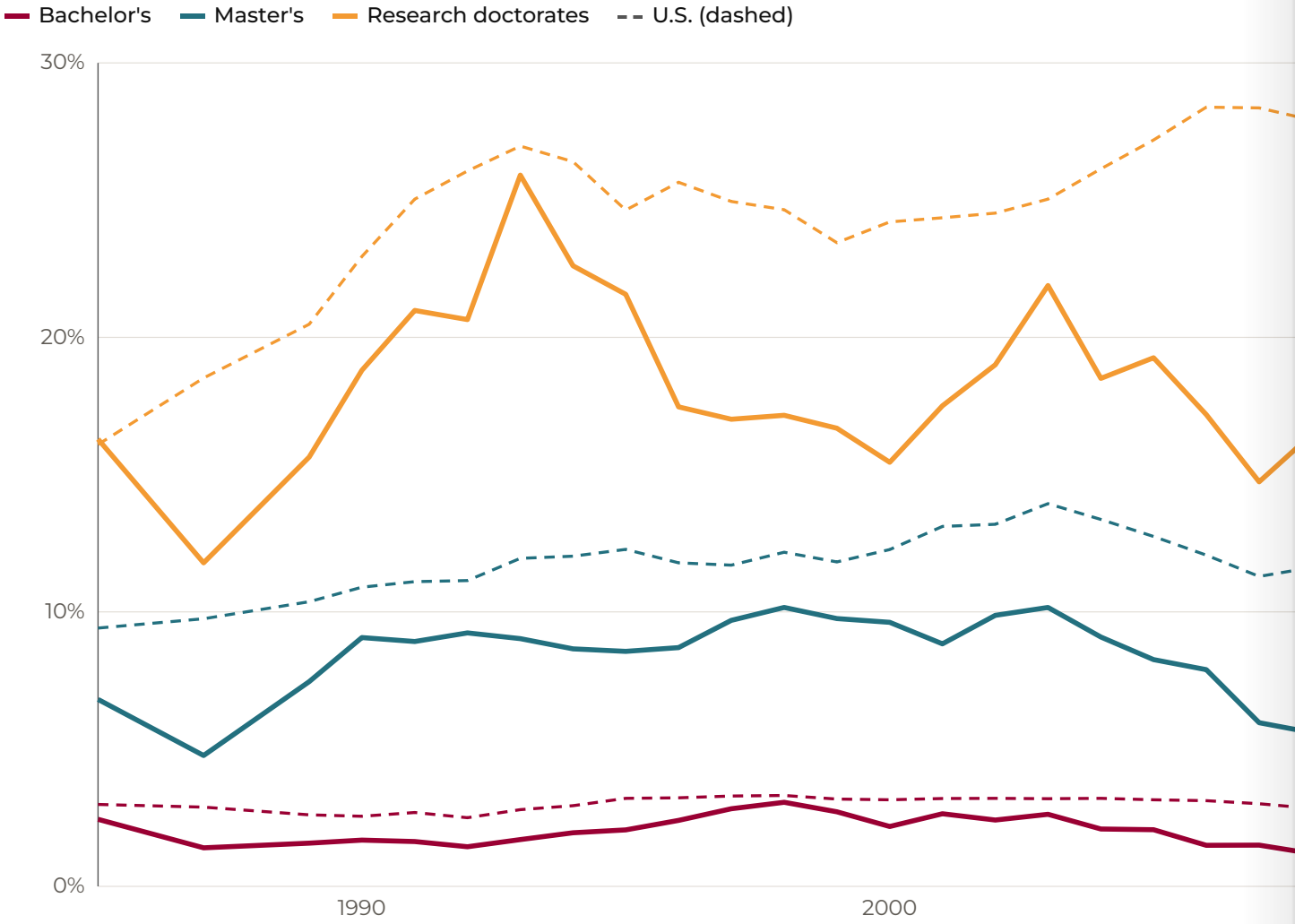


Badges give Colorado's rank among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). Changes are since 2015.

SECTION 1

International Dependence

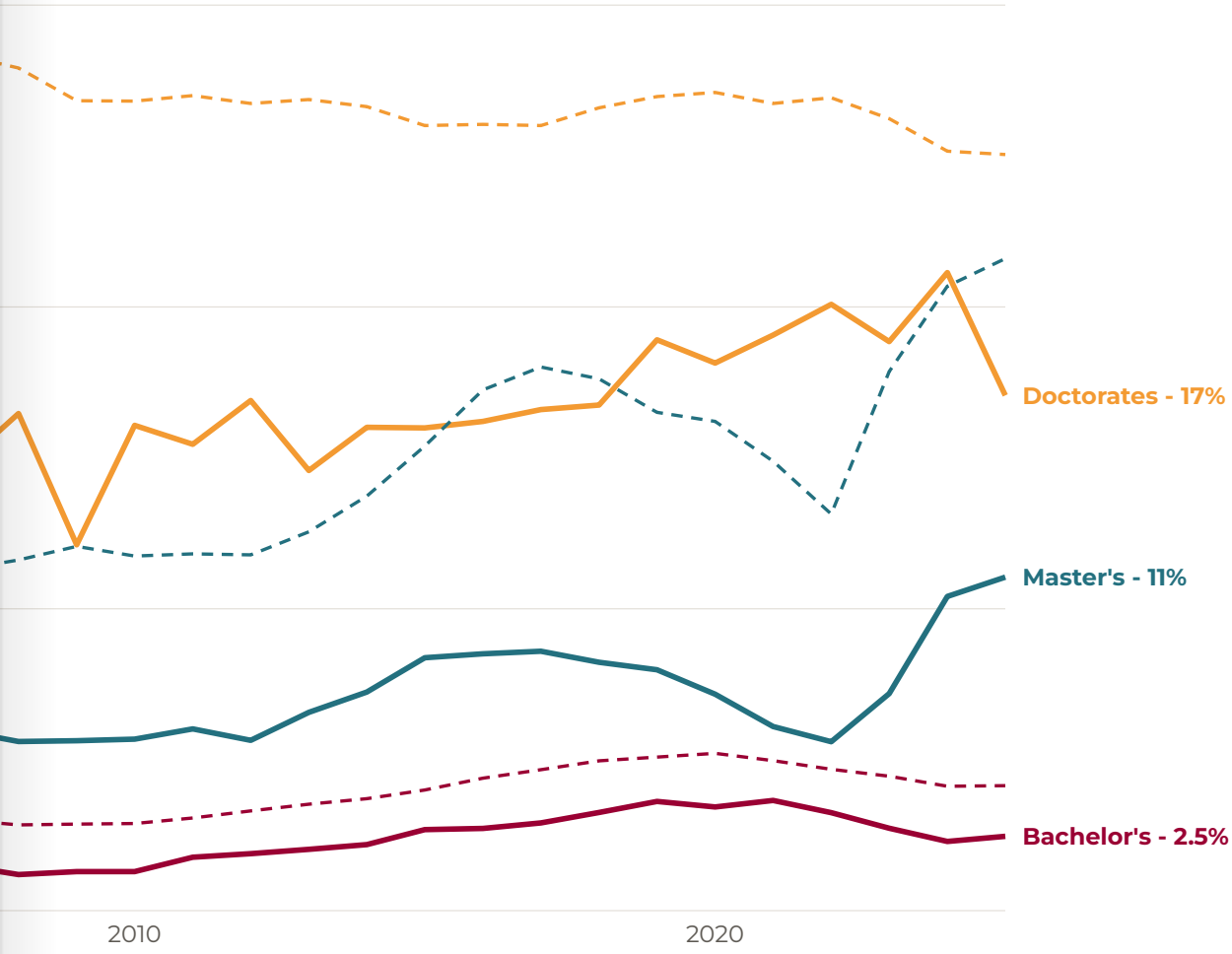
Figure 1 What Share of Colorado's Degrees Go to International Students?



International share of degrees awarded, all fields; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions, 1985–2025

International students make up 9.3% of Colorado's graduate enrollment and 2.0% of its undergraduates. Dependence climbs with each degree: 2.5% of bachelor's, 11% of master's and 17% of research doctorates go to international students.

In STEM the shares are higher still: 3.2% of STEM bachelor's, 24% of STEM master's and 21% of STEM doctorates. The state awards 0.9% of all U.S. international STEM master's, 26th of 51.



5.

9.3%

Int. share of grad students, 2024

U.S. **17%** · **37th** of 51 · +2.1 pp since 2015

11%

Int. share of all master's, 2025

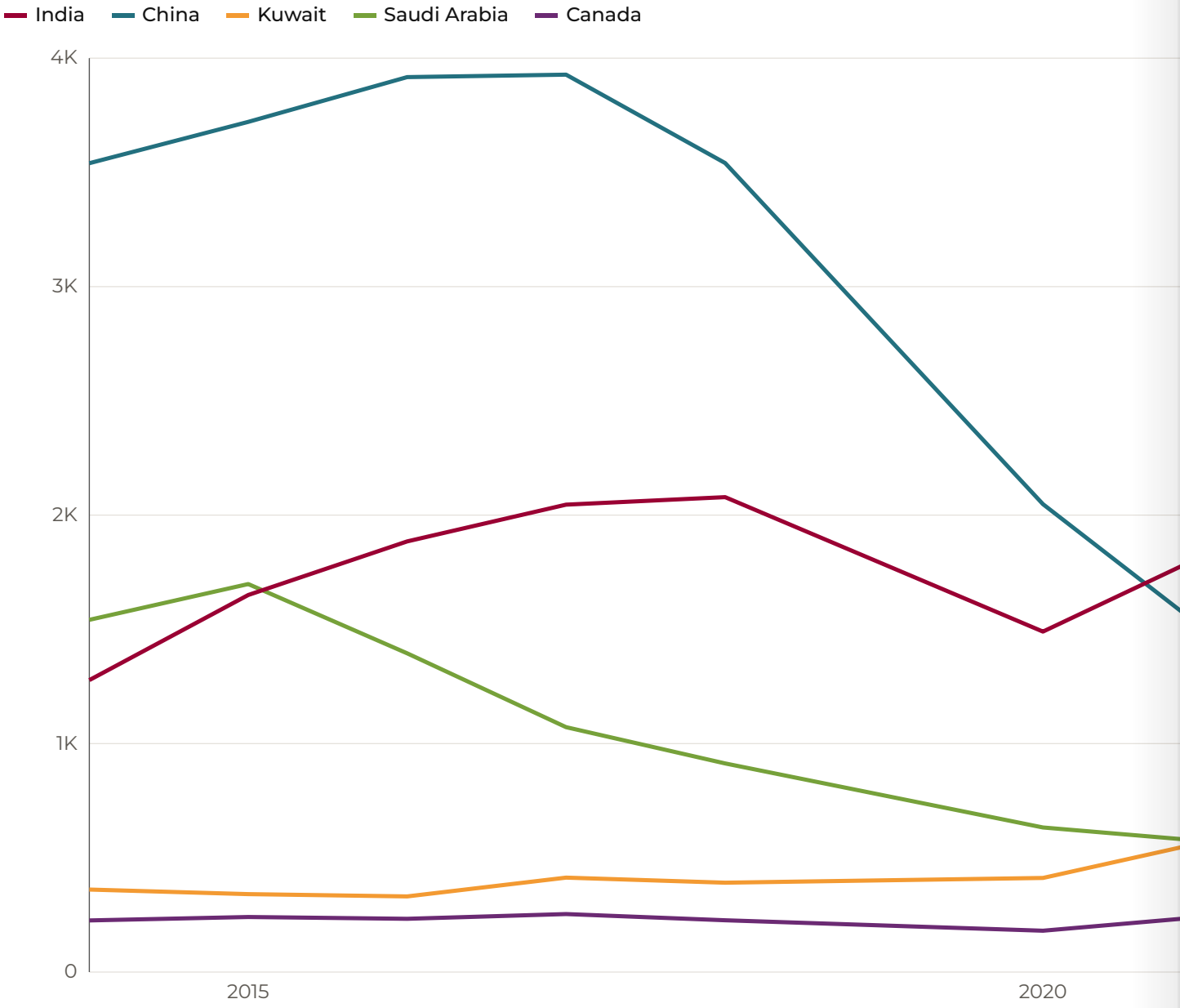
U.S. **22%** · **38th** of 51 · +2.7 pp since 2015

24%

Int. share of STEM master's, 2025

U.S. **52%** · **43rd** of 51 · +3.3 pp since 2015

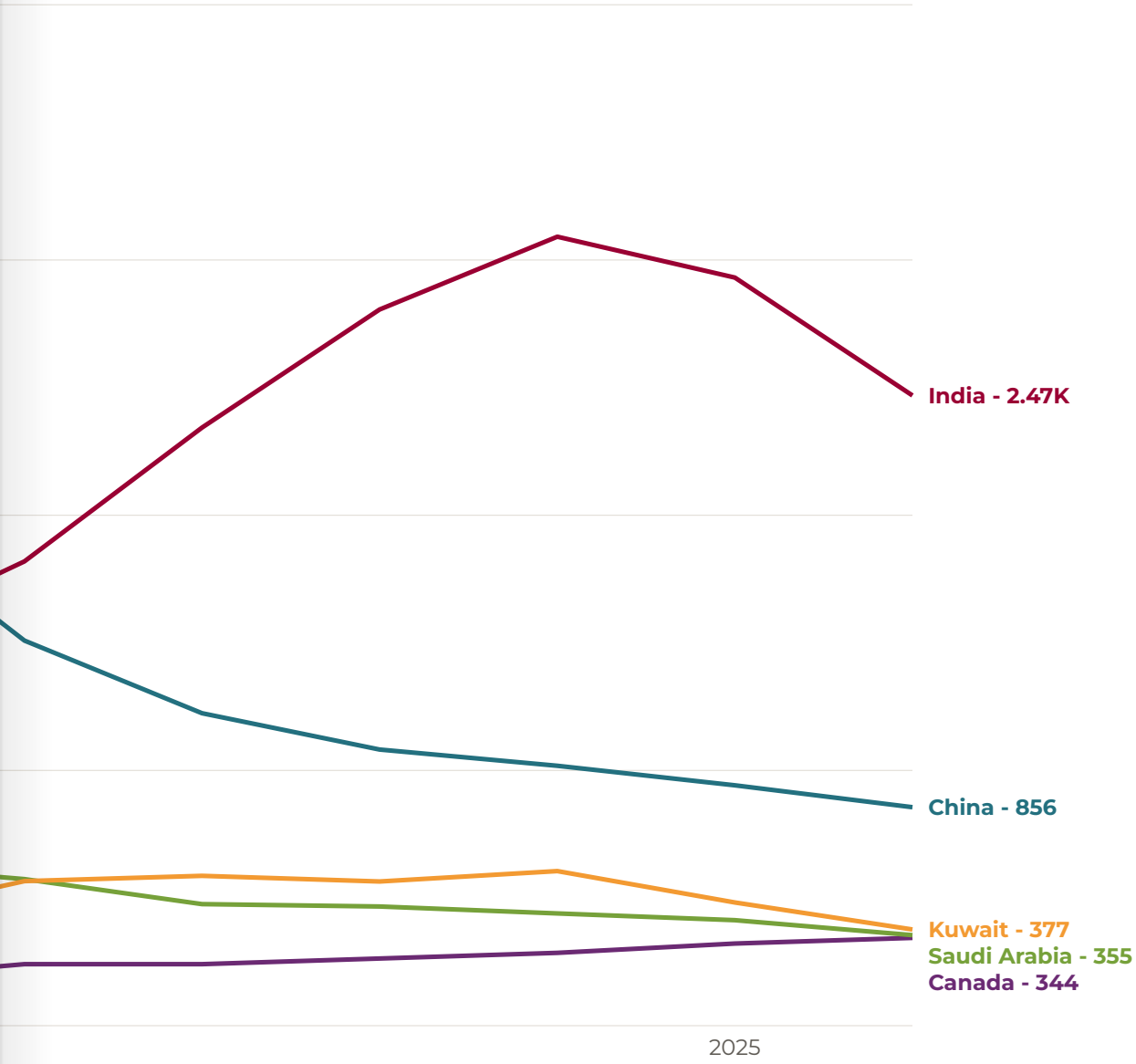
Figure 2 Where Do Colorado's International Students Come From?



Active F-1 and M-1 students by country of citizenship, the five largest in October 2026; one fall snapshot per year (the mor

In October 2026, Colorado had 9.26K active international students in SEVIS, 30th of 51. India accounted for 27% of them and China for 9.2%, against 27% and 18% nationally.

Students came from 160 countries, but the two largest supplied 36%. The state's total is down 22% since 2014.



nth closest to November), October 2014–October 2026. All education levels. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers.

9.26K

Active international students, October 2026

30th of 51 · U.S. **1.19M**

27%

From India

U.S. **27%**

74%

In STEM fields

U.S. **63%**

INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS

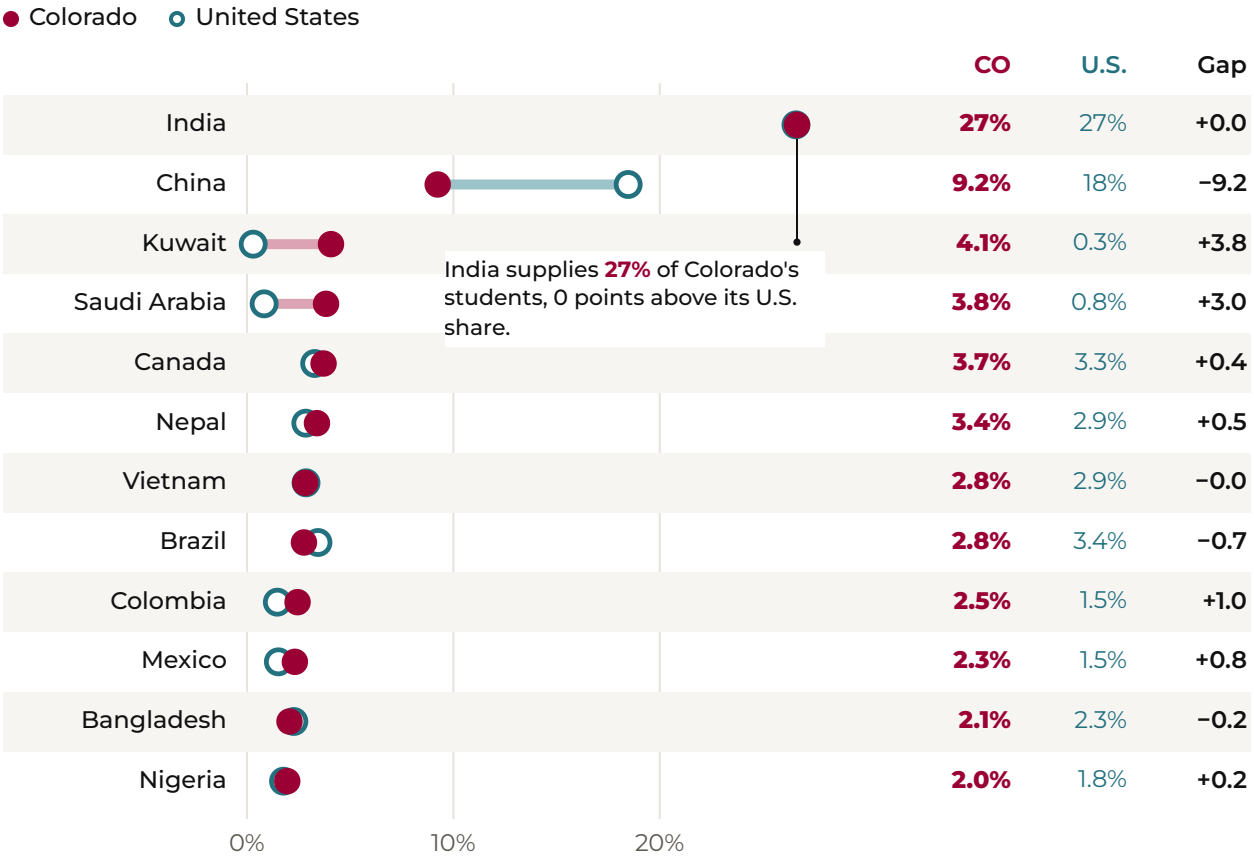
How Does Colorado's Mix of Countries Compare With the Nation's?

In October 2026, Colorado had **9.26K** active F-1 and M-1 students, 30th of 51 states and **0.8%** of the U.S. total. They came from 160 countries.

India supplied **27%** of them, against 27% nationally, and China **9.2%**, against 18%. Kuwait (4.1%), Saudi Arabia (3.8%) and Canada (3.7%) followed.

Together the two largest countries supplied **36%** of the state's international students (U.S. 45%), 30th among the states, against 42% in 2015.

Figure 3 Is Colorado's Mix of Countries Like the Nation's?



	CO	U.S.	Gap
India	27%	27%	+0.0
China	9.2%	18%	−9.2
Kuwait	4.1%	0.3%	+3.8
Saudi Arabia	3.8%	0.8%	+3.0
Canada	3.7%	3.3%	+0.4
Nepal	3.4%	2.9%	+0.5
Vietnam	2.8%	2.9%	−0.0
Brazil	2.8%	3.4%	−0.7
Colombia	2.5%	1.5%	+1.0
Mexico	2.3%	1.5%	+0.8
Bangladesh	2.1%	2.3%	−0.2
Nigeria	2.0%	1.8%	+0.2

Share of active F-1 and M-1 students, all levels. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers, October 2026.

9.26K
Active international students, October 2026
30th of 51 · U.S. **1.19M**

27%
From India
U.S. **27%**

9.2%
From China
U.S. **18%**

160
Countries represented
U.S. **219**

The state's count is down 8.8% from 2025 and down 29% since 2015, when it stood at 13K. Its share of all U.S. international students is down 0.3 points since 2015, to **0.8%**.

Since 2015, students from India went from 1.65K to 2.47K; students from China went from 3.72K to 856; students from Kuwait went from 341 to 377.

Table 1 International Students in Colorado, 2015–2026

	2015	2025	2026	Change since 2015	U.S. 2026	Rank
ALL INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS						
Active F-1 and M-1 students	13K	10.2K	**9.26K**	−29%	1.19M	30th
Share of U.S. active F-1/M-1 students	1.1%	0.8%	**0.8%**	−0.3 pp	–	30th
Countries of citizenship represented	164	166	**160**	−2.4%	219	30th
Share from the two largest countries of origin	42%	38%	**36%**	−5.8 pp	45%	30th
LARGEST COUNTRIES OF CITIZENSHIP (STUDENTS)					**U.S. SHARE**	**STATE SHARE**
India	1.65K	2.93K	**2.47K**	+50%	27%	27%
China	3.72K	942	**856**	−77%	18%	9.2%
Kuwait	341	483	**377**	+11%	0.3%	4.1%
Saudi Arabia	1.7K	413	**355**	−79%	0.8%	3.8%
Canada	241	322	**344**	+43%	3.3%	3.7%

Active F-1 and M-1 students, one fall snapshot per year (the month closest to November; 2019 has none; the latest year is October 2026). Rank among the 50 states and DC. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers.

Figure 4

Which Countries Supply Colorado's International STEM Students?

6.83K of Colorado's international students were in STEM fields in October 2026, **74%** of the total against 63% nationally, up 26% since 2015.

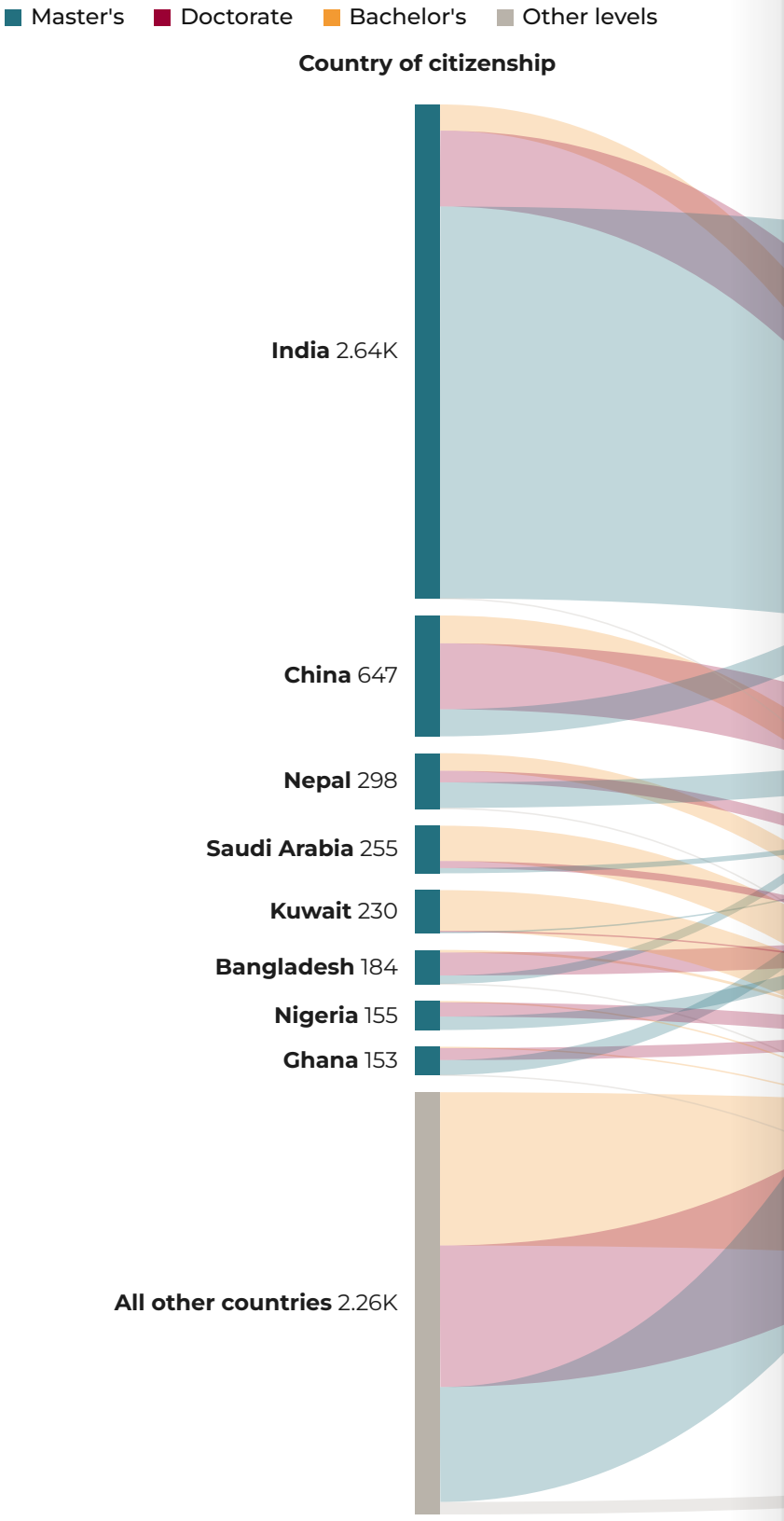
Master's students were the largest group, **3.23K**. India supplied 65% of them and China 4.5%.

STEM doctoral students went from 1.31K in 2015 to **1.88K**, and STEM master's students from 2.01K to 3.23K.

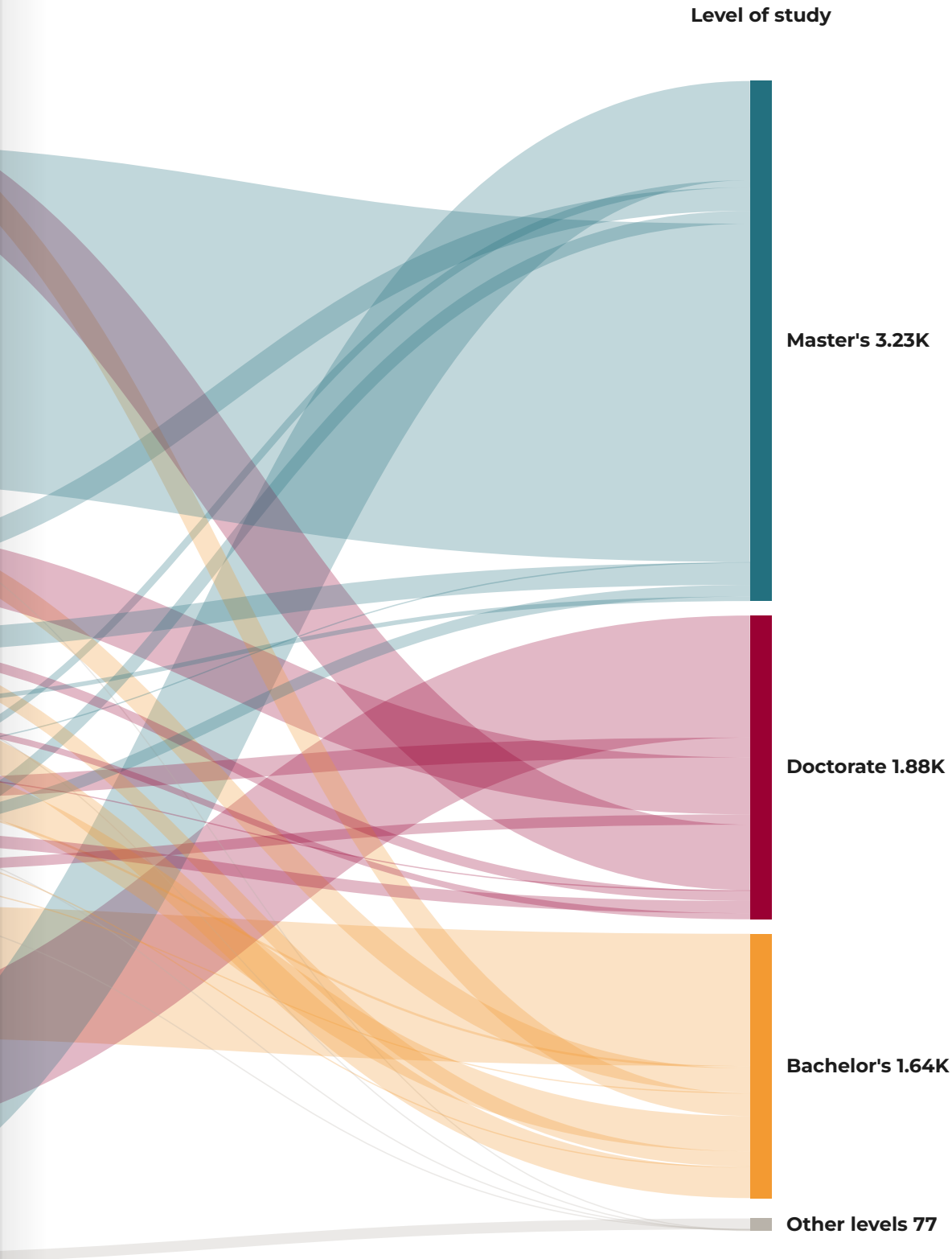
6.83K
Active STEM F-1/M-1 students, 2026
U.S. **749K** · **23rd** of 51 · +26% since 2015

74%
Share in STEM fields
U.S. **63%**

3.23K
Active STEM master's students, 2026
U.S. **393K** · **23rd** of 51 · +61% since 2015



Active F-1 and M-1 students in STEM fields by country of citizenship an
basis as its all-student pages, so the STEM count here exceeds the all-



d level of study, October 2026; the eight largest countries are shown. DHS does not draw its STEM pages on the same evel count for India (2.64K against 2.47K). Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers, October 2026.

INTERNATIONAL DEPENDENCE

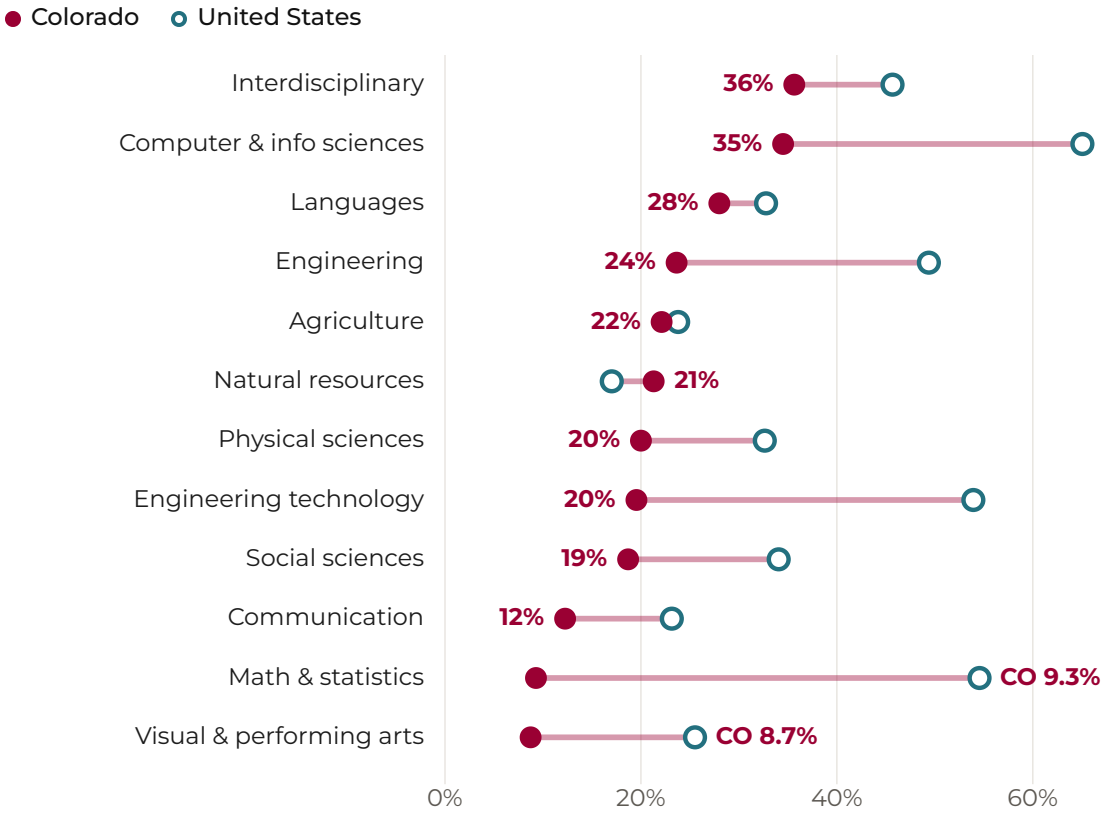
How International Are Colorado's Master's Fields?

Each row is a master's field with at least 30 graduates in Colorado in 2025, ranked by the share of degrees earned by international students (U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas). The filled dot is the state's share; the open dot is the national share for the same field.

Highest international shares. Interdisciplinary 36% (U.S. 46%); computer & info sciences 35% (U.S. 65%); languages 28% (U.S. 33%).

All master's degrees. 11% in 2025 (U.S. 22%; 38th of 51 states), up 0.6 points from 10% in 2024, and up 2.7 points since 2015 (8.4%).

Figure 5 Which Master's Fields Depend Most on International Students?



International share of master's degrees by field, 2025; fields with 30+ graduates. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

11%
Int. share of all master's, 2025
U.S. **22%** · **38th** of 51

24%
Int. share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · **43rd** of 51

35%
Int. share of CS master's, 2025
U.S. **65%** · **40th** of 47

The table gives the international share of degrees in each STEM field at three levels: Colorado first, the United States after the slash. The master's column is highlighted. A dash means the state awarded no degrees in the field at that level.

Highest international share among STEM master's fields. Computer & info sciences, 35% (U.S. 65%).

International share of STEM bachelor's. 3.2% in 2025 (U.S. 6.6%; 42nd of 51 states), up 0.1 points from 3.1% in 2024, and down 0.1 points since 2015 (3.3%).

Table 2 How International Is Each STEM Field?

Field	Bachelor's	Master's	Doctorates
Computer & info sciences	3.4% / 8.6%	**35% / 65%**	30% / 56%
Engineering	5.1% / 7.2%	**24% / 49%**	27% / 55%
Engineering technology	1.1% / 4.5%	**20% / 54%**	– / 42%
Math & statistics	3.8% / 17%	**9.3% / 55%**	17% / 53%
Physical sciences	3.6% / 6.0%	**20% / 33%**	20% / 38%
Biological sciences	1.5% / 3.4%	**4.7% / 23%**	10% / 23%
Natural resources	1.5% / 2.0%	**21% / 17%**	– / 27%
Architecture	1.9% / 7.3%	**2.2% / 29%**	– / 55%

International share in Colorado / U.S., 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

INTERNATIONAL DEPENDENCE

How Has Colorado's STEM Master's Output Grown?

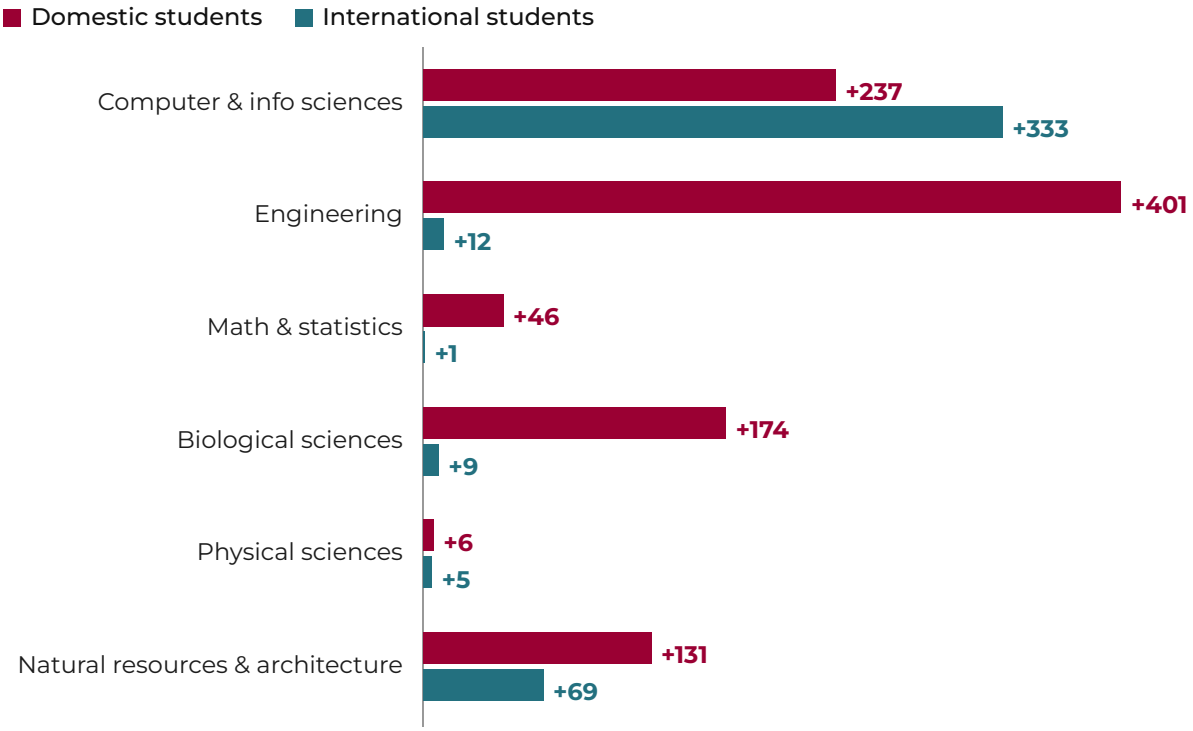
Each pair of bars is the change in the number of STEM master's degrees awarded in Colorado between 2015 and 2025 in one field: to domestic students (U.S. citizens and permanent residents) and to international students. Bars to the left of the axis are declines.

STEM master's degrees. 4.19K in 2025, against 2.76K in 2015: +429 for international students and +995 for domestic students.

Computer & info sciences. +237 for domestic students and +333 for international students.

Engineering. +401 for domestic students and +12 for international students.

Figure 6 Where Did the STEM Master's Growth Come From?



Change in STEM master's degrees by field, 2015–2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

995
International STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **117K** · **26th** of 51

25%
STEM share of master's, 2025
U.S. **23%** · **14th** of 51

0.9%
Share of U.S. international STEM master's, 2025
26th of 51

5.3
STEM master's per doctorate, 2025
U.S. **6.4** · **29th** of 51

The table gives the number of STEM master's degrees awarded in Colorado in each field in 2015 and 2025, the change between the two years, the number awarded to international students in 2025, and international students' share of the field's degrees in each year.

STEM share of master's degrees. 25% in 2025 (U.S. 23%; 14th of 51 states), up 0.4 points from 25% in 2024, and up 6.6 points since 2015 (19%).

Table 3 How Many STEM Master's Degrees Does Each Field Award?

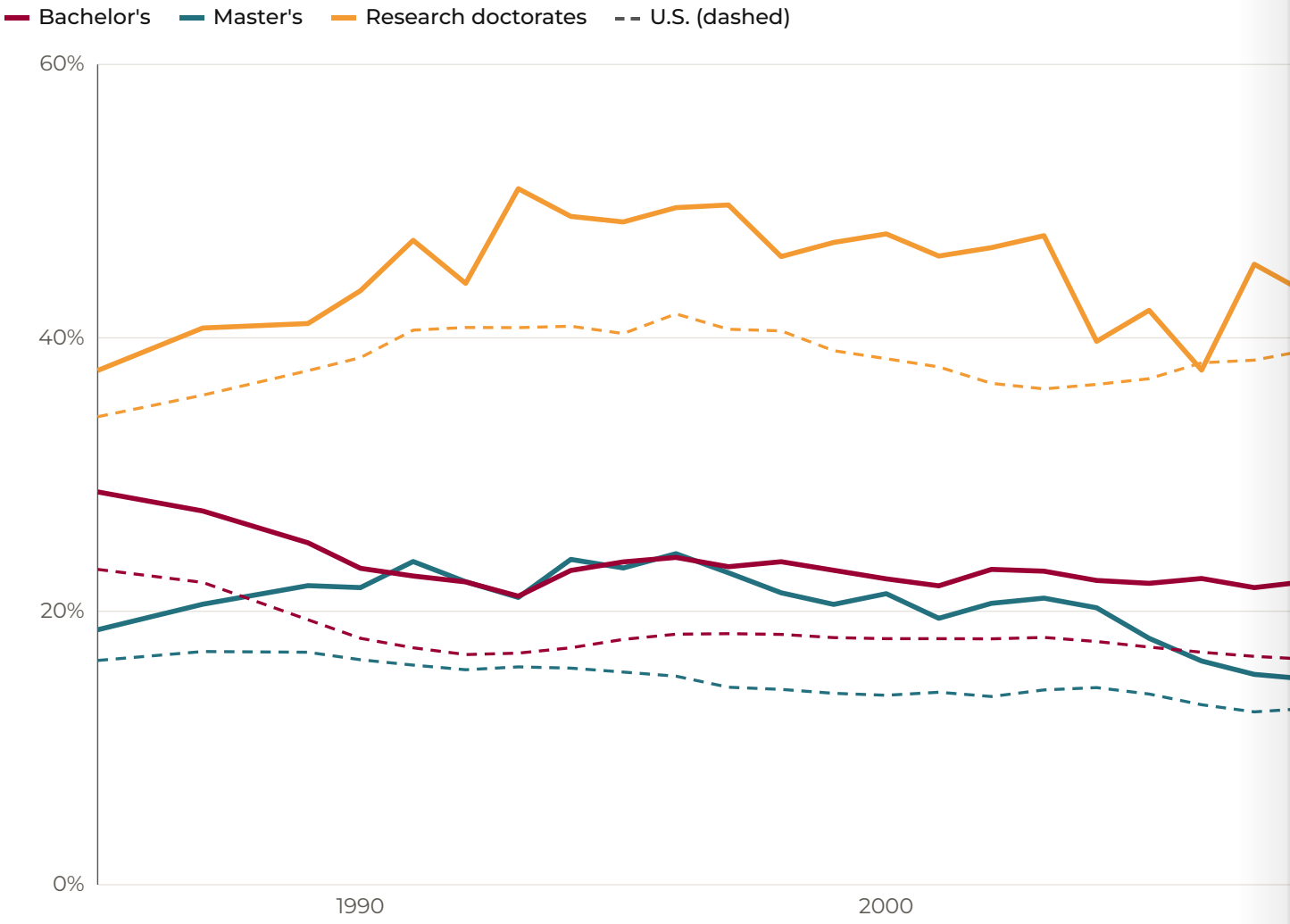
Field	2015	2025	Change	International 2025	Int. share 2015	Int. share 2025
Computer & info sciences	824	**1.39K**	+69%	481	18%	35%
Engineering	1.06K	**1.47K**	+39%	344	31%	23%
Math & statistics	93	**140**	+51%	13	13%	9.3%
Biological sciences	266	**449**	+69%	21	4.5%	4.7%
Physical sciences	184	**195**	+6.0%	39	18%	20%
Natural resources & architecture	338	**538**	+59%	97	8.3%	18%

STEM master's degrees awarded in Colorado, all students and international students, 2015 and 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

SECTION 2

STEM Degrees

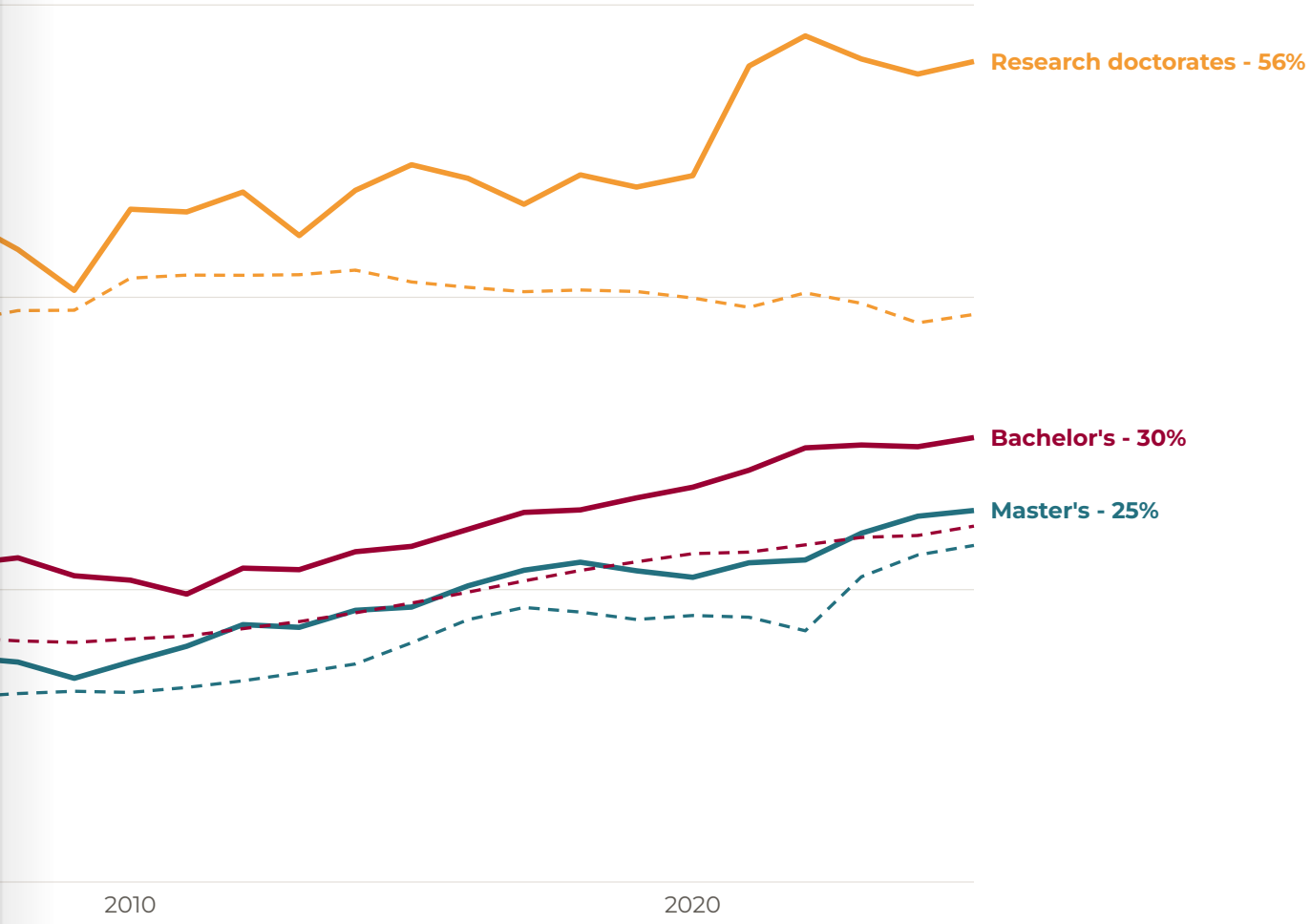
Figure 7 How Much of Colorado's Degree Output Is STEM?



STEM share of degrees by level; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

STEM fields account for 30% of Colorado's bachelor's degrees, 25% of its master's and 56% of its research doctorates (U.S. 24%, 23% and 39%).

The STEM share of master's degrees is up 6.6 points since 2015, and the state ranks 14th of 51 on it. On the STEM share of bachelor's degrees it ranks 6th of 51.



30%

STEM share of bachelor's, 2025

U.S. **24%** · **6th** of 51 · +7.4 pp since 2015

25%

STEM share of master's, 2025

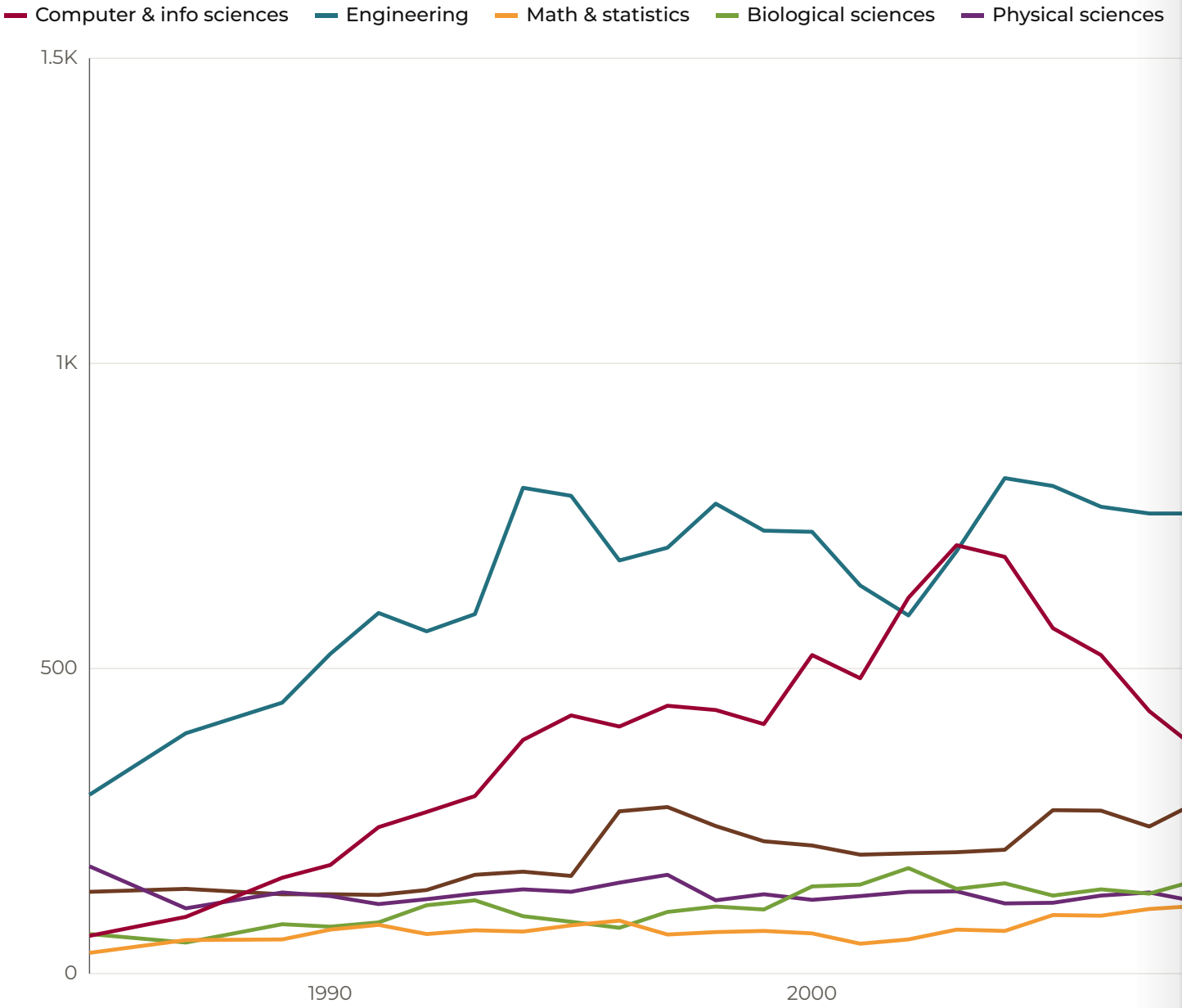
U.S. **23%** · **14th** of 51 · +6.6 pp since 2015

56%

STEM share of research doctorates, 2025

U.S. **39%** · **5th** of 51 · +7.1 pp since 2015

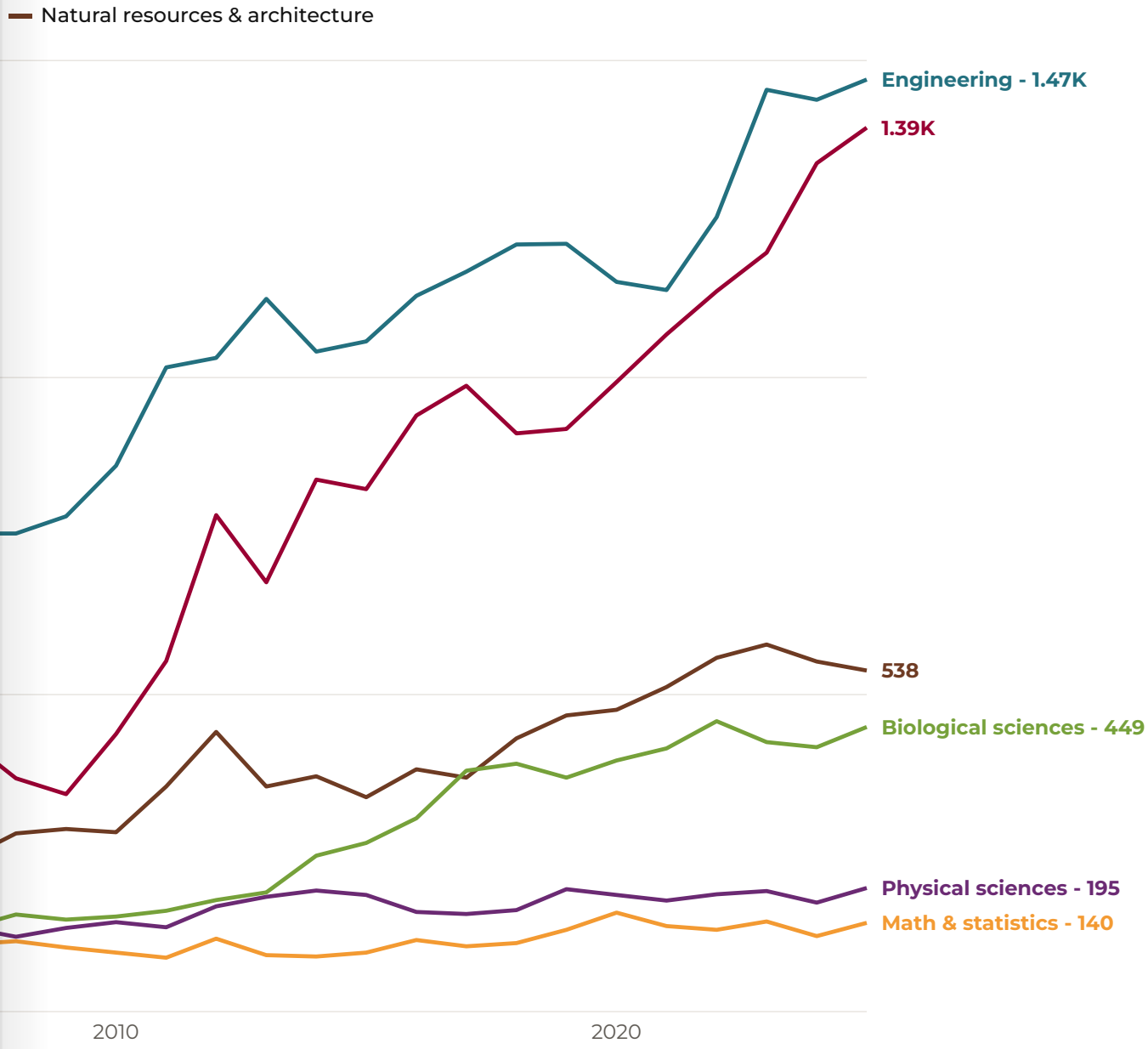
Figure 8 Which STEM Fields Produce Colorado's Master's Degrees?



STEM master's degrees by field, all students. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Engineering produced the most STEM master's degrees in 2025, 1.47K, followed by computer & info sciences (1.39K) and natural resources & architecture (538). Master's degrees in engineering are up 39% since 2015.

International students earned 995 of the state's STEM master's degrees in 2025, 0.9% of the national total (26th of 51).



995

International STEM master's, 2025

U.S. **117K** · **26th** of 51 · +76% since 2015

0.9%

Share of U.S. international STEM master's, 2025

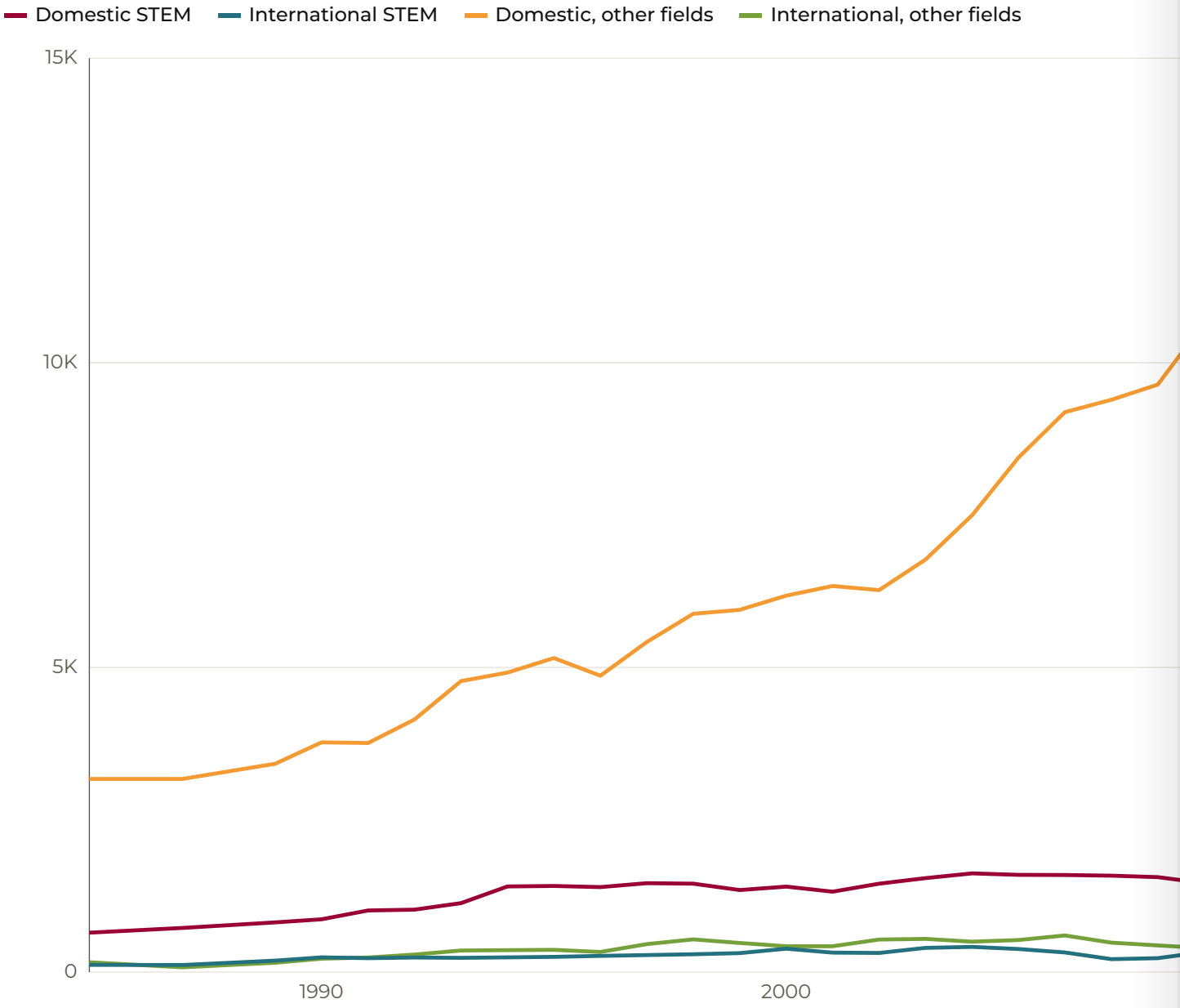
· **26th** of 51 · −0.2 pp since 2015

35%

Int. share of CS master's, 2025

U.S. **65%** · **40th** of 47 · +16.5 pp since 2015

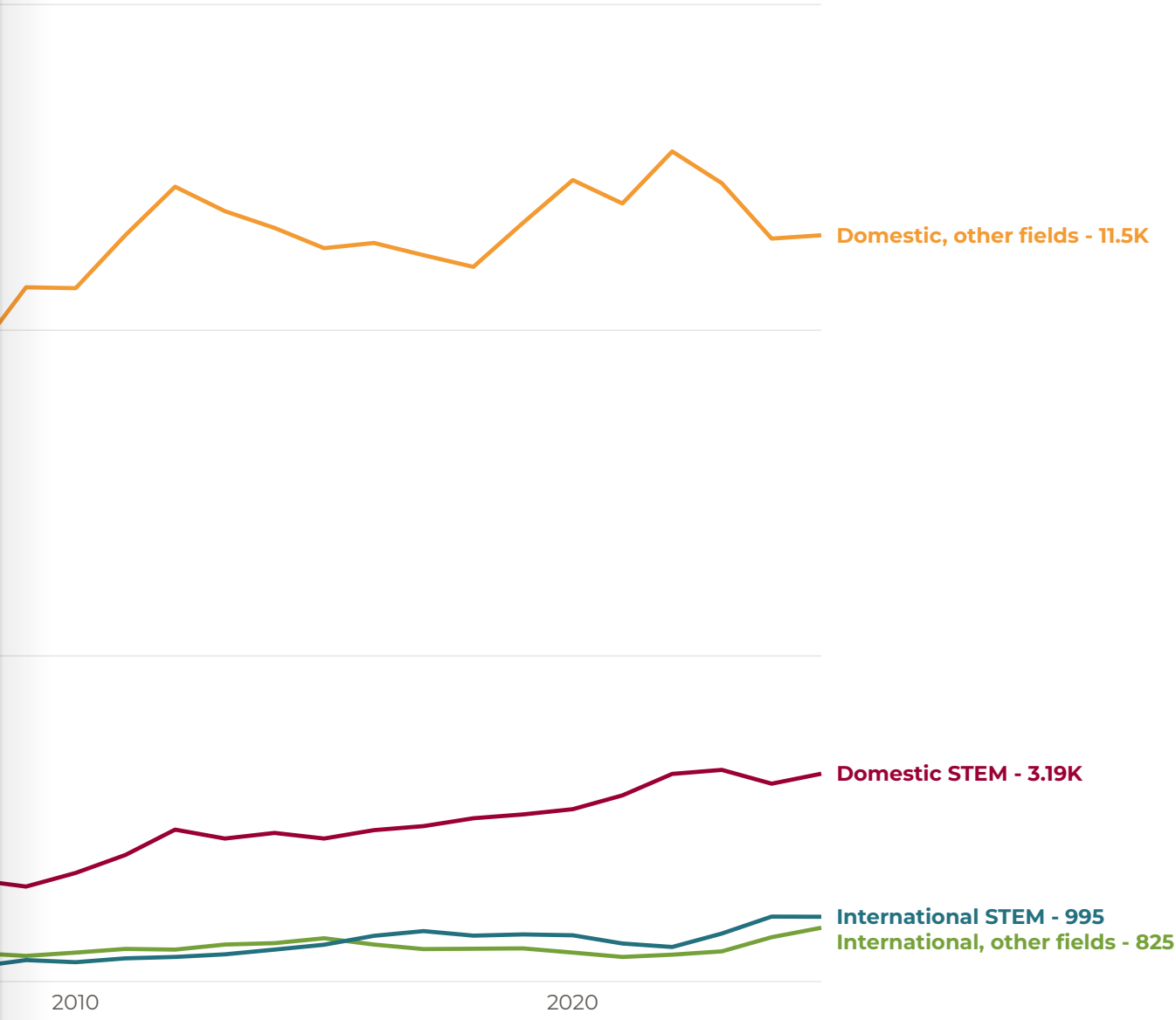
Figure 9 Who Earns Colorado's Master's Degrees?



Master's degrees by student residency and field group. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Between 2015 and 2025, 429 more STEM master's degrees went to international students and 995 more to domestic students.

International students earn 24% of Colorado's STEM master's but 6.7% of master's in other fields (U.S. 52% and 12%).



11%

Int. share of all master's, 2025

U.S. **22%** · **38th** of 51 · +2.7 pp since 2015

24%

Int. share of STEM master's, 2025

U.S. **52%** · **43rd** of 51 · +3.3 pp since 2015

5.3

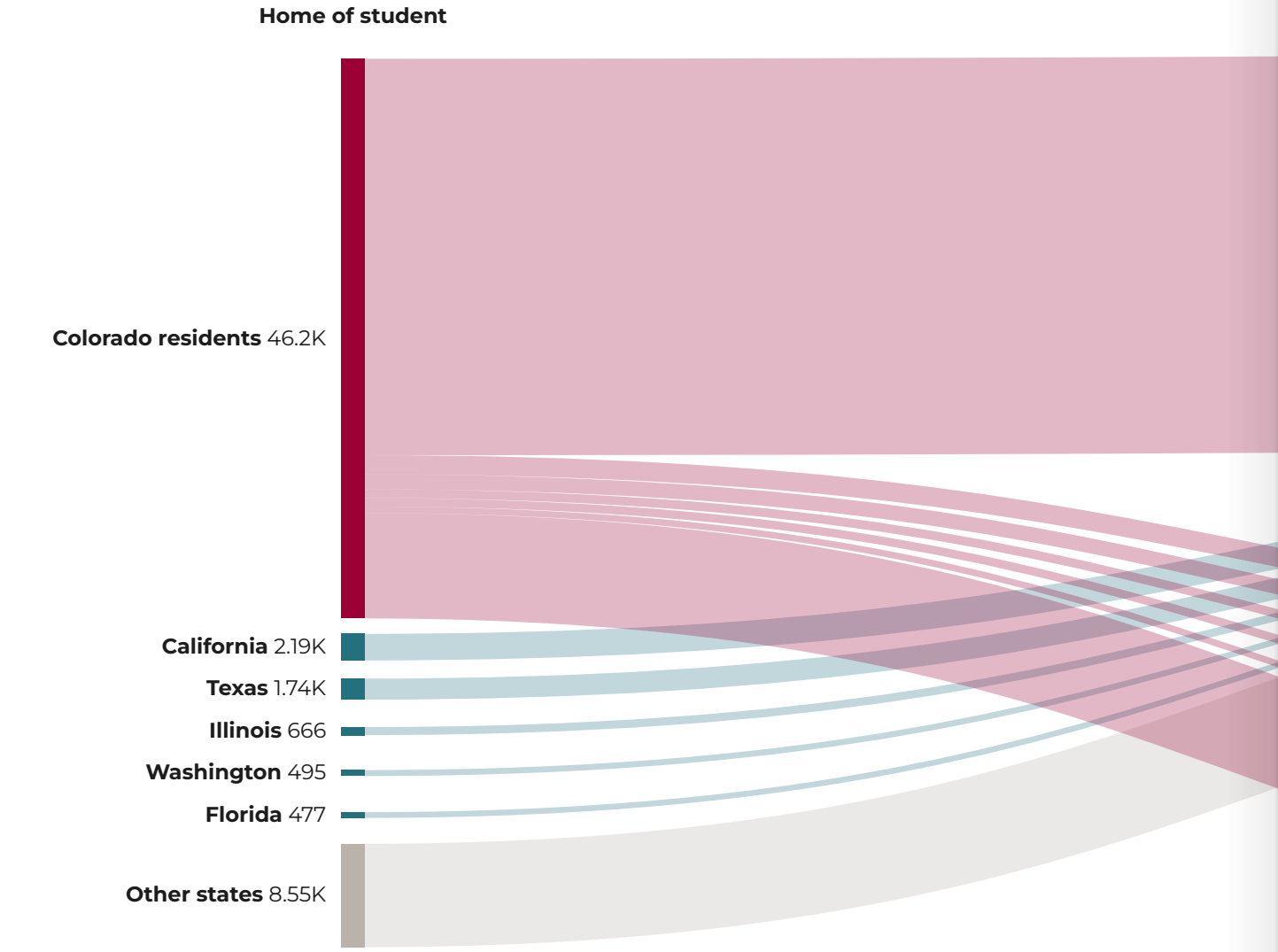
STEM master's per doctorate, 2025

U.S. **6.4** · **29th** of 51 · +1.1 since 2015

SECTION 3

Where Students Come From

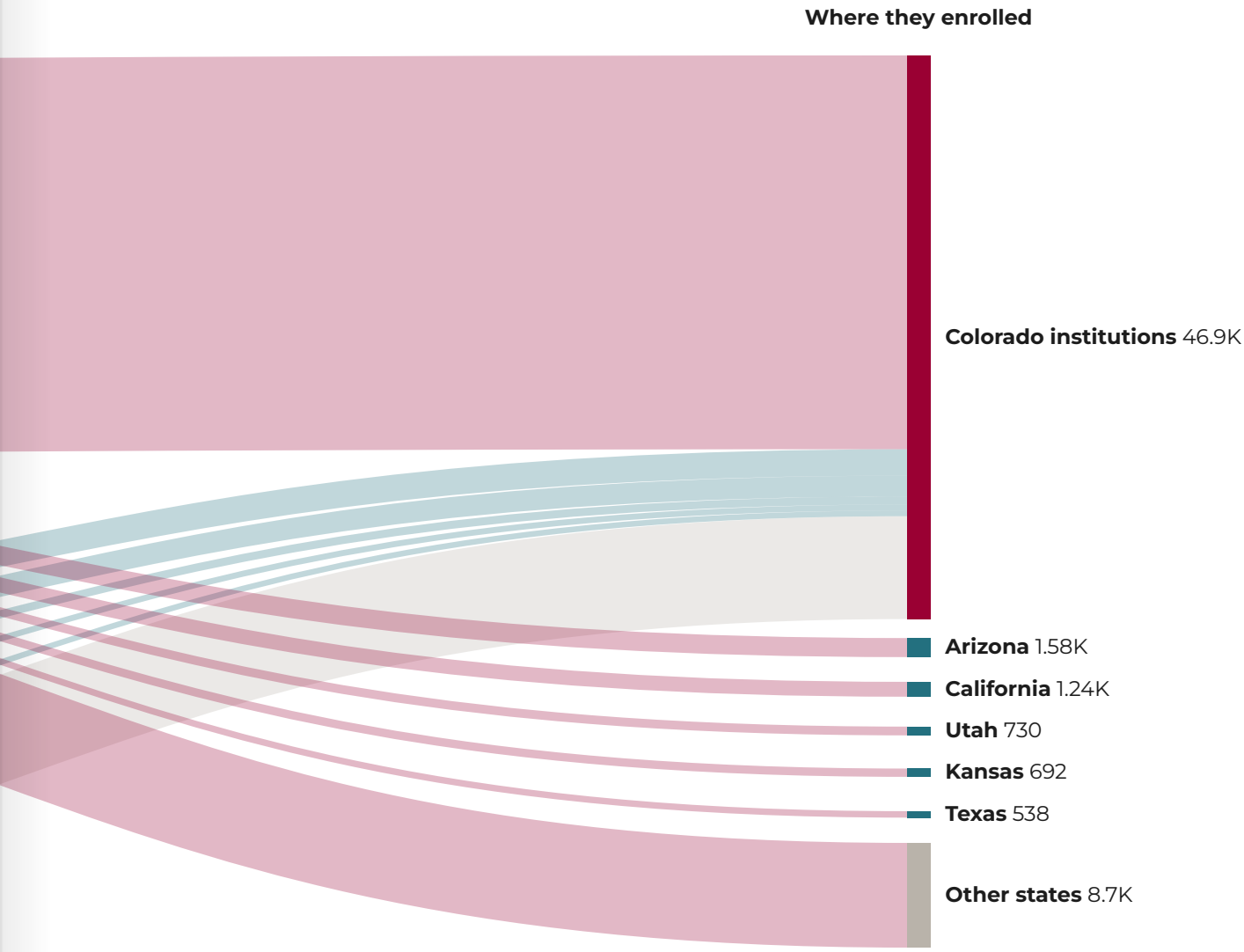
Figure 10 First-Time Students by Home and Destination, Fall 2024



Home of first-time degree-seeking undergraduates (left) and the state of the institution entered (right); the five largest s

32.7K residents stayed in Colorado for college in fall 2024; 13.7K students arrived from other states and 402 from abroad, while 13.5K residents left.

Each band runs from a student's home on the left to the state where they enrolled on the right. 70% of the state's first-time students are residents (U.S. –).



ources and destinations, the rest grouped. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

70%

First-time students from in state, 2024

· **30th** of 51 · −2.5 pp since 2016

0.9%

First-time students from abroad, 2024

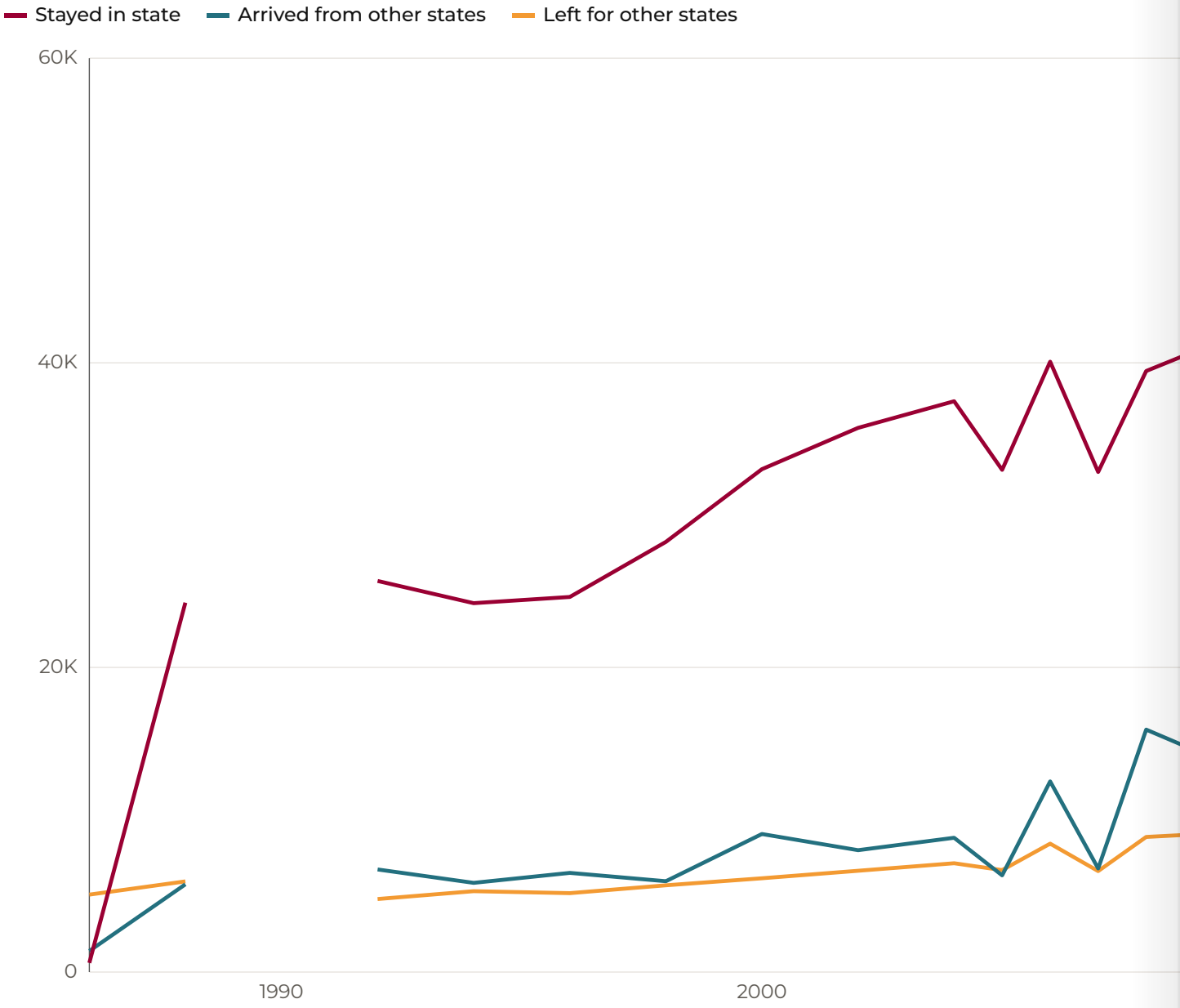
U.S. **3.1%** · **49th** of 51 · −1.2 pp since 2016

+0

Net migration per 100 residents, 2024

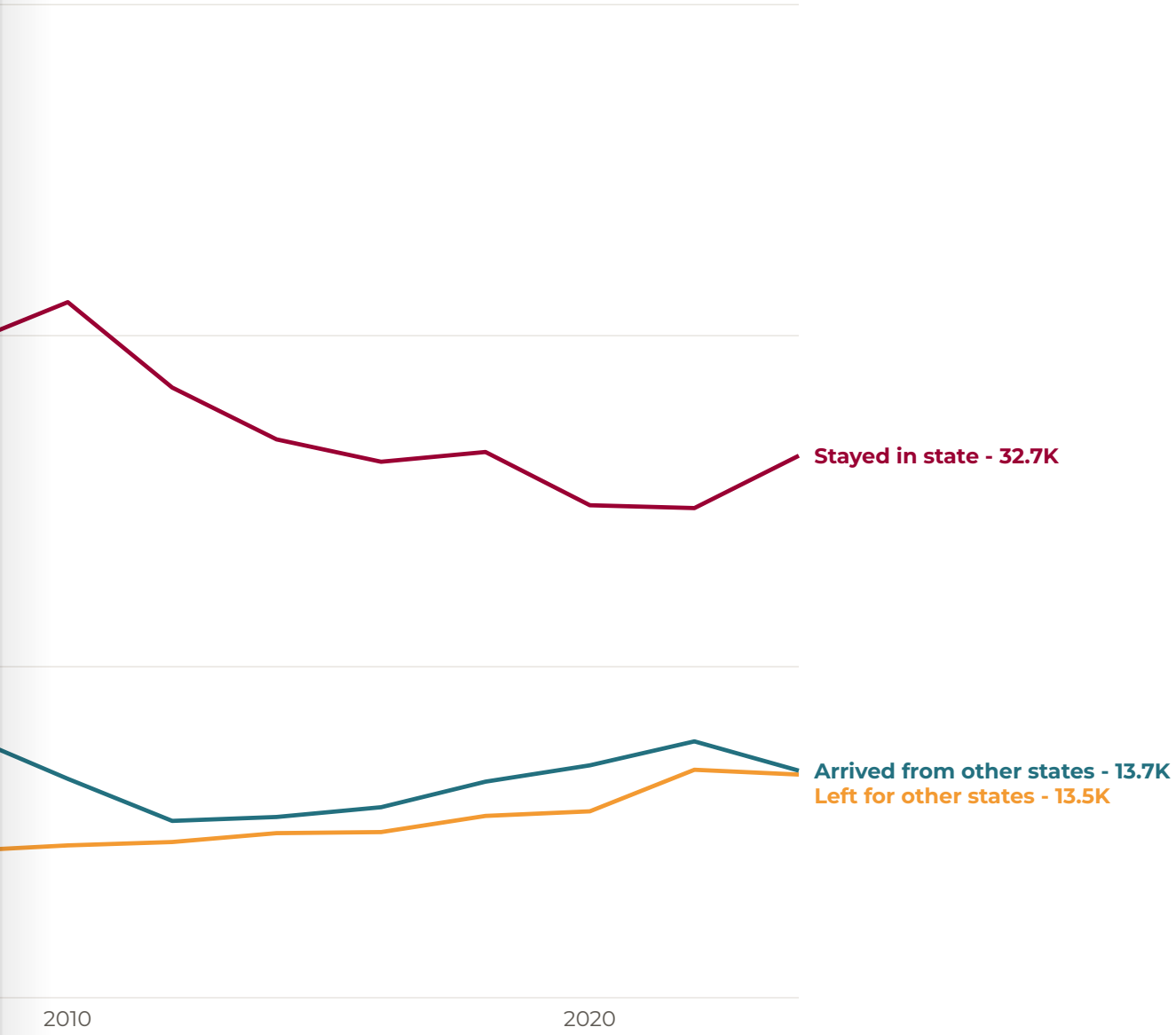
· **35th** of 51 · −3.0 since 2016

Figure 11 How Have the Flows Changed?



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates by flow; even years before 2001. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

Since 2015, the number of residents staying in state for college is roughly flat, arrivals from other states are up 19%, and residents leaving are up 35%.



Net migration was +0 per 100 resident first-time students (35th of 51). The top destination for residents who left was Arizona (1.58K).

Figure 12

Where Do Colorado's Newcomers Come From?

The bands show where first-time degree-seeking undergraduates who enrolled at Colorado's institutions in fall 2024 but did not live in the state came from: the 12 largest home states and students from abroad, with all other states grouped. Band widths are proportional to the number of students. Home is the state where the student lived when admitted.

Students arriving from other states. 13.7K in fall 2024, down 11% from 15.5K in fall 2022, and up 19% since fall 2016 (11.5K).

14.1K

First-time students from other states and abroad, fall 2024

Abroad **402**

0.9%

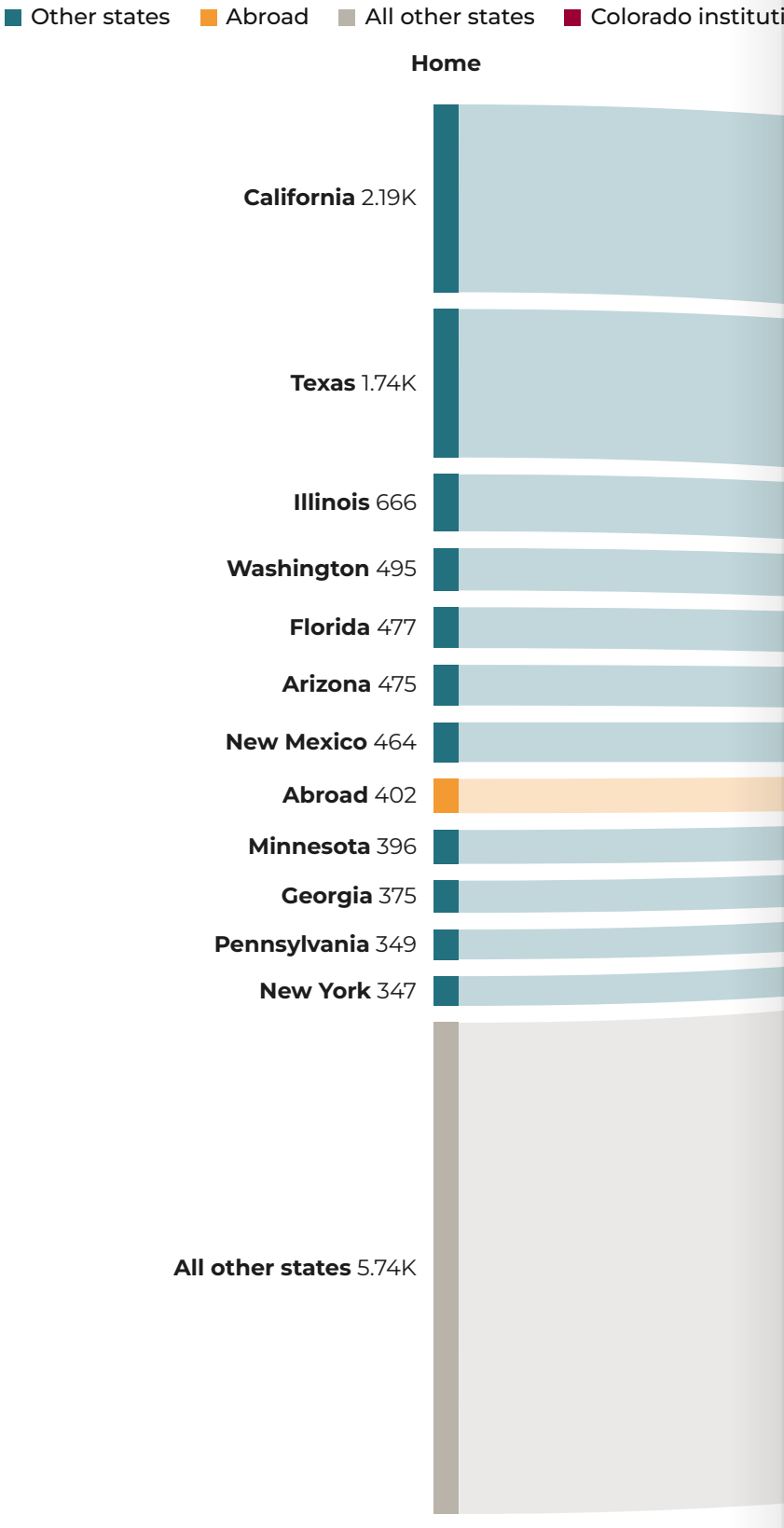
First-time students from abroad, 2024

U.S. **3.1%** · **49th** of 51 · −1.2 pp since 2016

70%

First-time students from in state, 2024

30th of 51 · −2.5 pp since 2016



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates, fall 2024; the 12 largest flow

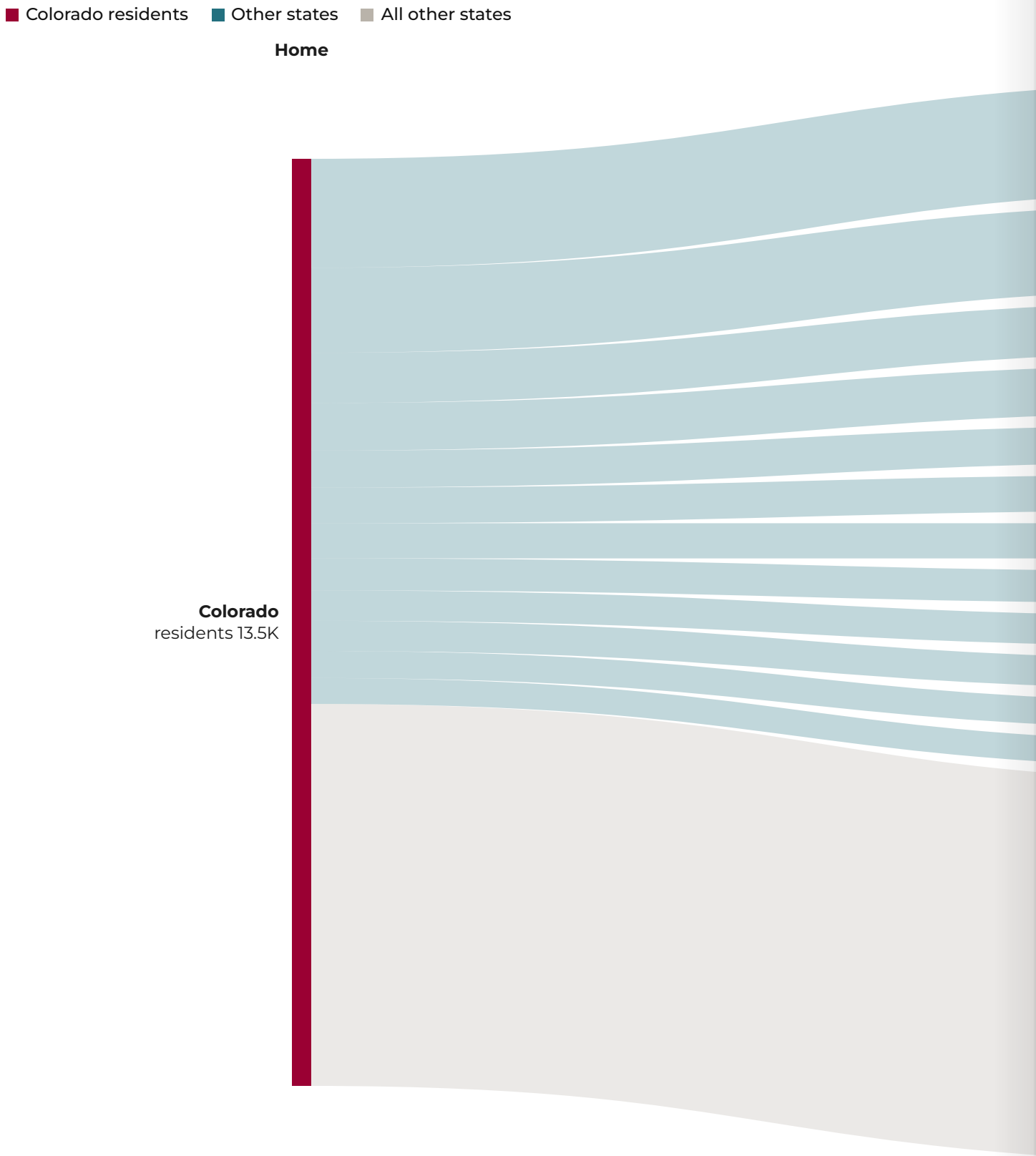
ions

Enrolled in



Colorado
institutions 14.1K

ws. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates, fall 2024; the 12 largest flows. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

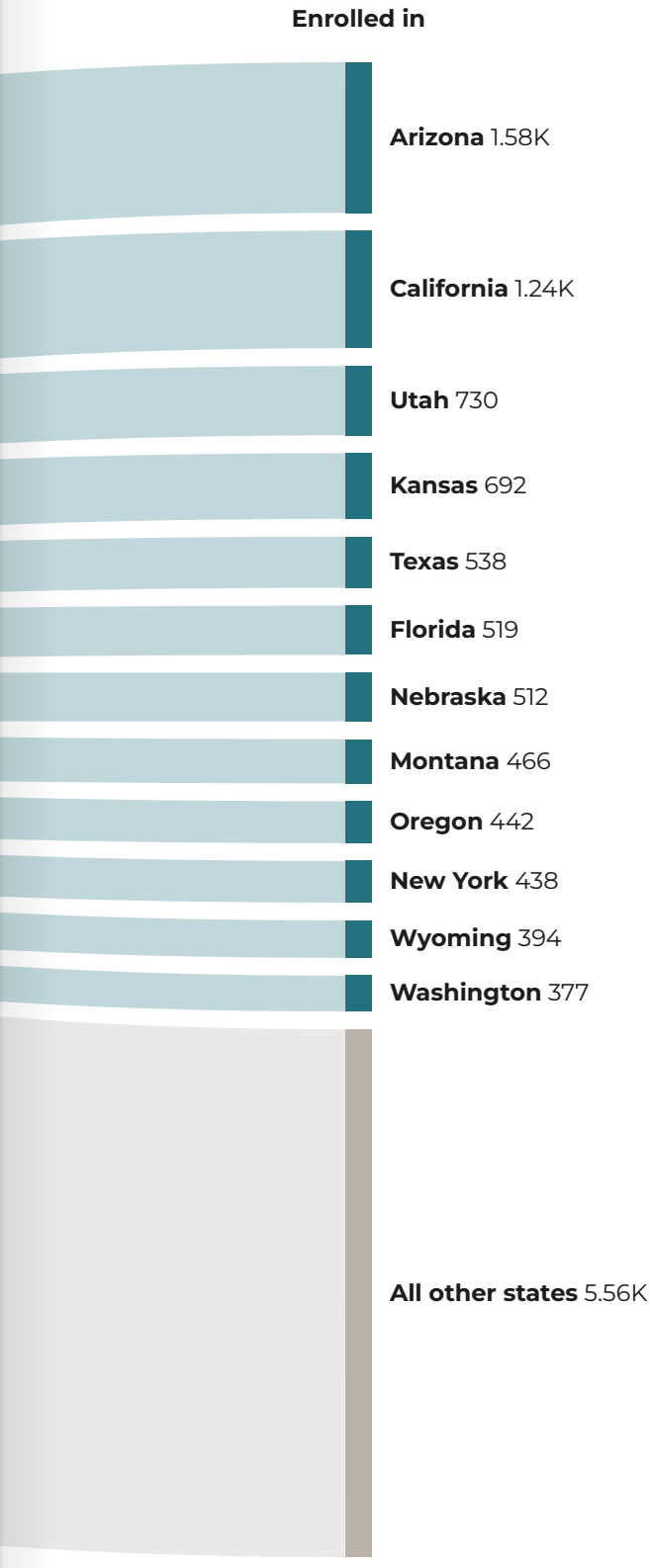


Figure 13

Where Do Colorado's Residents Go When They Leave?

The bands show where Colorado residents who left the state to start college in fall 2024 enrolled: the 12 largest destination states, with all other states grouped. Band widths are proportional to the number of students. Residents who enrolled in the state are not shown.

Residents leaving for other states. 13.5K in fall 2024, down 2.1% from 13.8K in fall 2022, and up 35% since fall 2016 (10K).

Residents staying in the state. 32.7K in fall 2024, up 11% from 29.6K in fall 2022, and up 1.1% since fall 2016 (32.4K).

13.5K

Residents who started college in another state, fall 2024

Arrivals **14.1K**

+0

Net migration per 100 residents, 2024

35th of 51 · −3.0 since 2016

1.58K

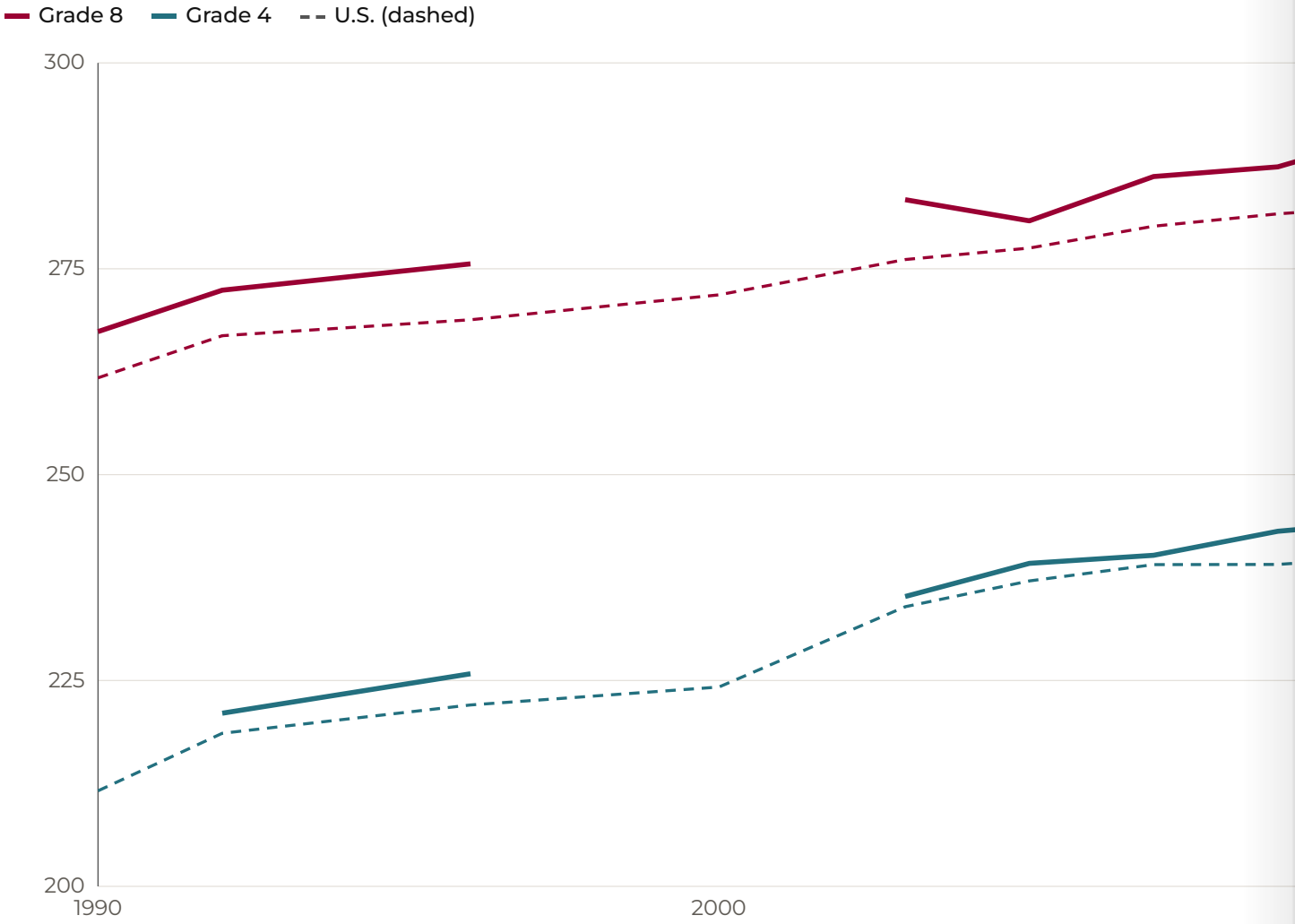
Went to Arizona

The largest destination

SECTION 4

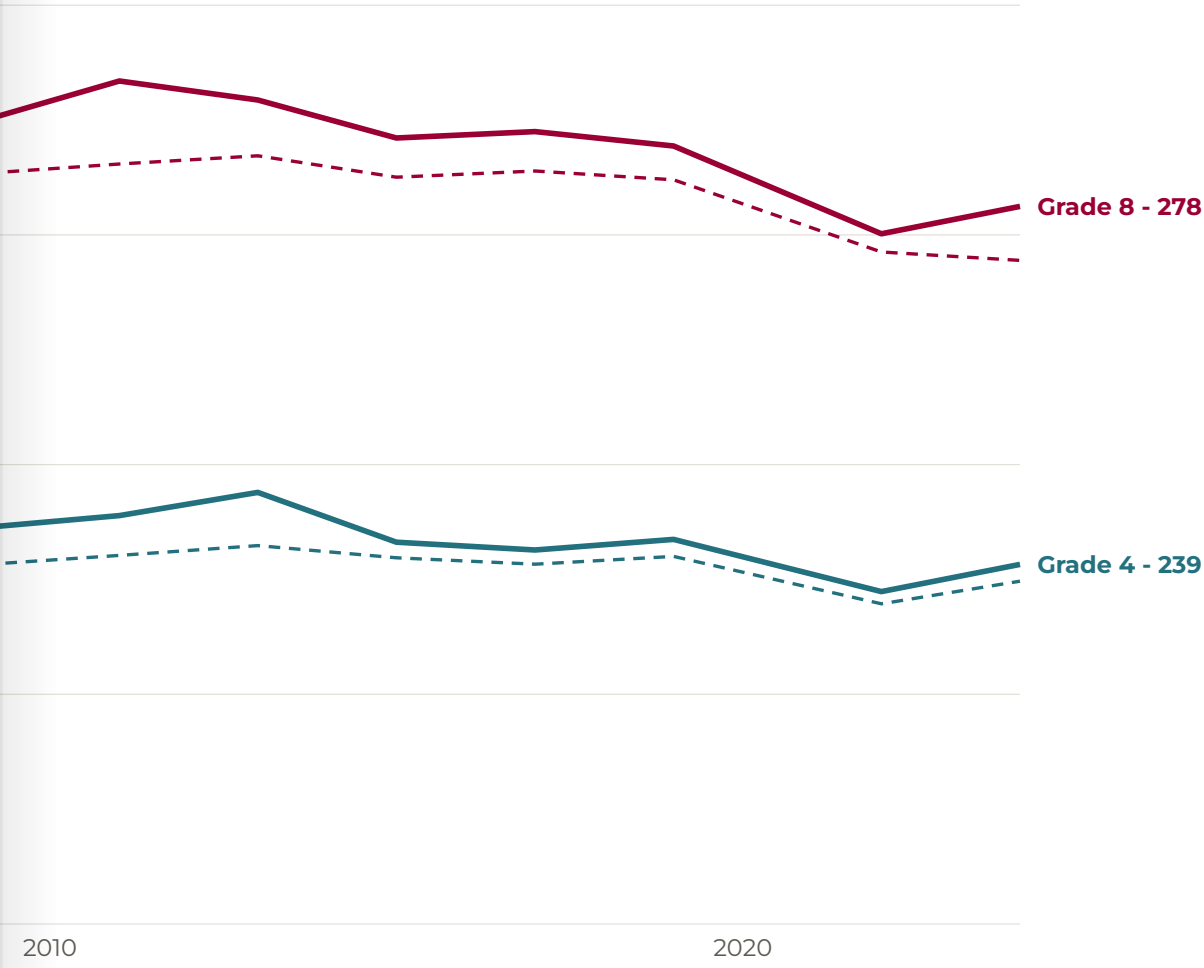
K-12 Preparation

Figure 14 How Well Prepared in Mathematics Are Colorado's Students?



Average NAEP mathematics score, public schools, 0–500 scale; state solid, U.S. public schools dashed. Data from NCES, N

The talent pipeline starts in school. Colorado's eighth graders averaged 278 in mathematics on the 2024 NAEP, against 272 for U.S. public schools, 14th of 51 among the states. 32% scored at or above the Proficient level (U.S. 27%). Differences of a point or two are often within the margin of error.



lational Assessment of Educational Progress.

278

Grade 8 math score (NAEP), 2024

U.S. **272** · **14th** of 51 · −7.4 since 2015

32%

Grade 8 math, at or above Proficient, 2024

U.S. **27%** · **8th** of 51 · −4.5 pp since 2015

265

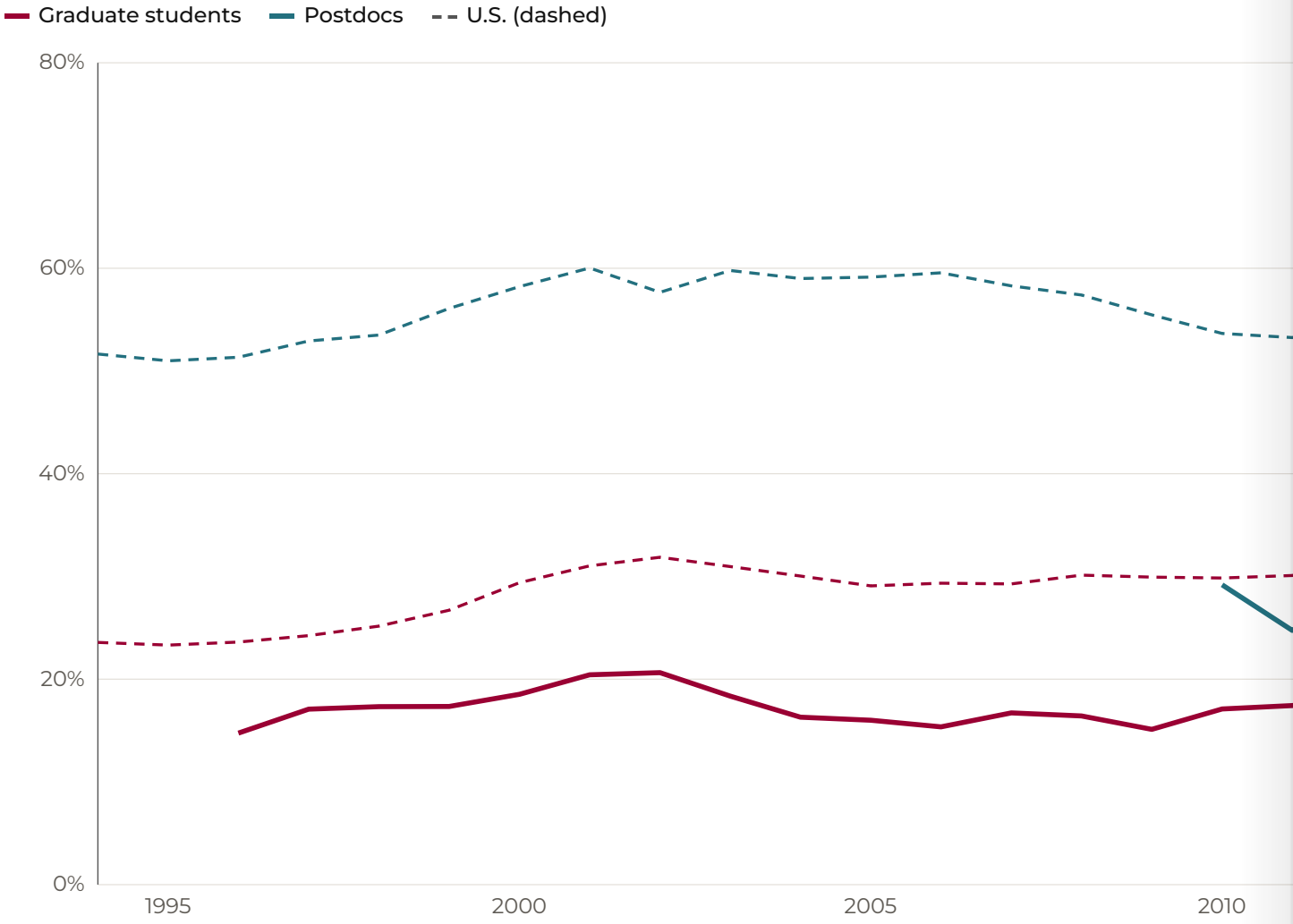
Grade 8 reading score (NAEP), 2024

U.S. **257** · **3rd** of 51 · −3.5 since 2015

SECTION 5

Graduate Research

Figure 15 How Many of Colorado's Science and Engineering Graduate Students Hold Te



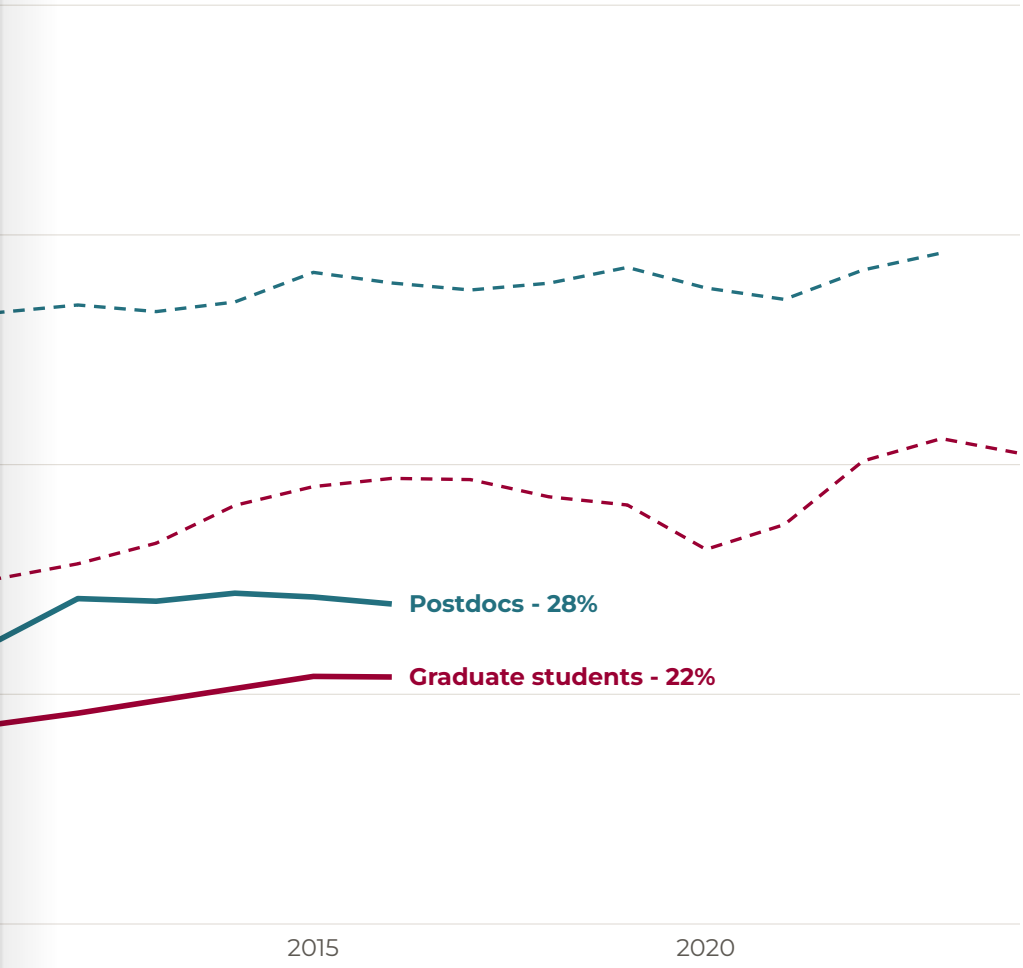
Temporary-visa share of science and engineering graduate students and postdoctoral appointees, by the institution's sta
Students and Postdoctorates.

In 2016, the last year NSF published state tables, 22% of Colorado's science and engineering graduate students held temporary visas (U.S. 39%; 47th of 51).

Among postdoctoral researchers, the share was 28% (U.S. 56%). Postdocs are the stage of research training most dependent on international talent, and IPEDS does not count them.

The state's institutions awarded 1.24K research doctorates in 2025, 2.1% of the U.S. total (Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Earned Doctorates; NSF publishes doctorates by citizenship only for the nation).

emporary Visas?



te; state solid, U.S. dashed. NSF stopped publishing state tables after 2016. Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Graduate

22%

S&E grad students on temporary visas, 2016

U.S. **39%** · **47th** of 51 · −0.1 pp since 2015

28%

S&E postdocs on temporary visas, 2016

U.S. **56%** · **49th** of 51 · −0.6 pp since 2015

1.24K

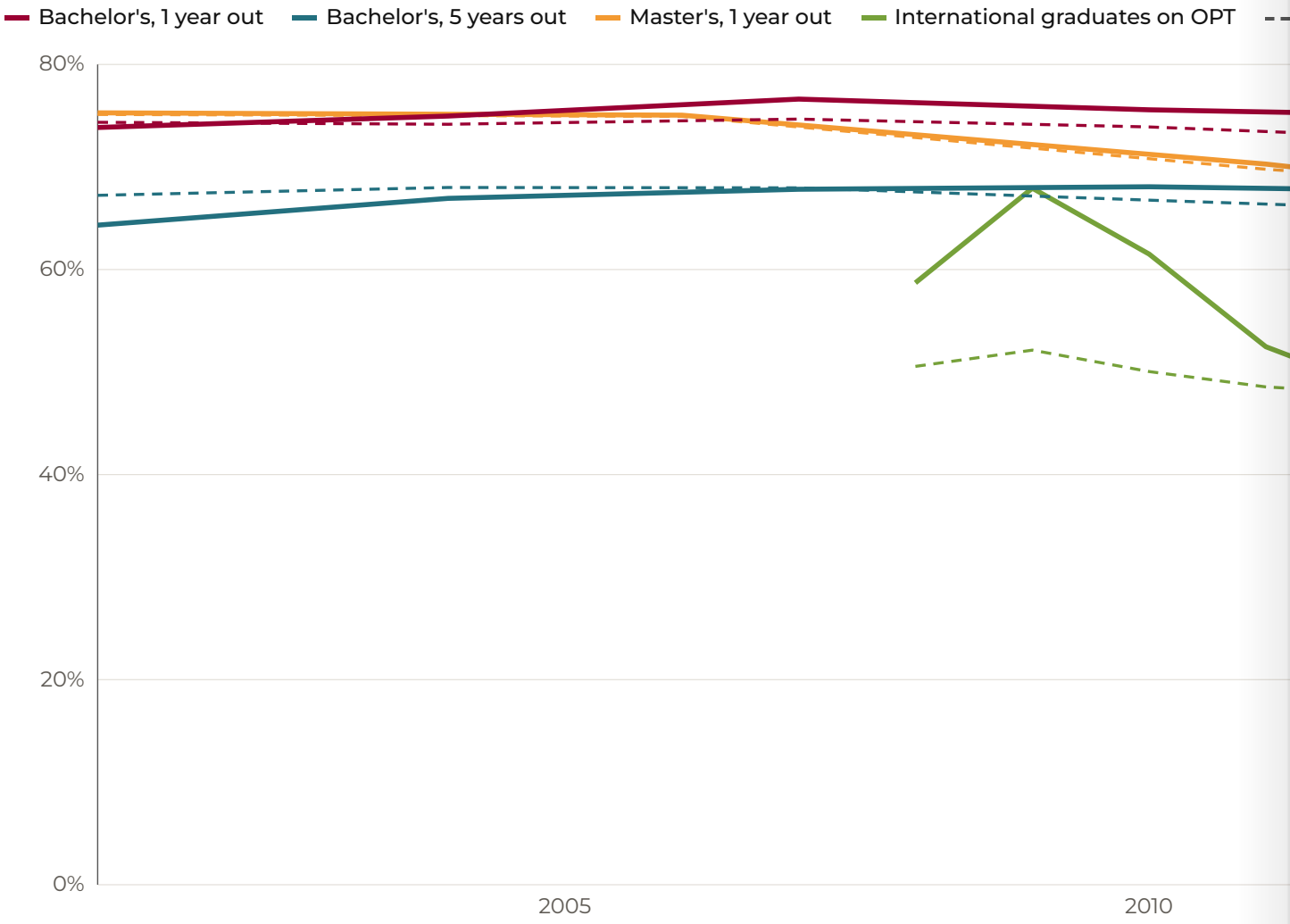
Research doctorates awarded (NSF SED), 2025

U.S. **59K** · **17th** of 51 · +24% since 2015

SECTION 6

Do Graduates Stay?

Figure 16 How Many of Colorado's Graduates Go On to Work in the State?

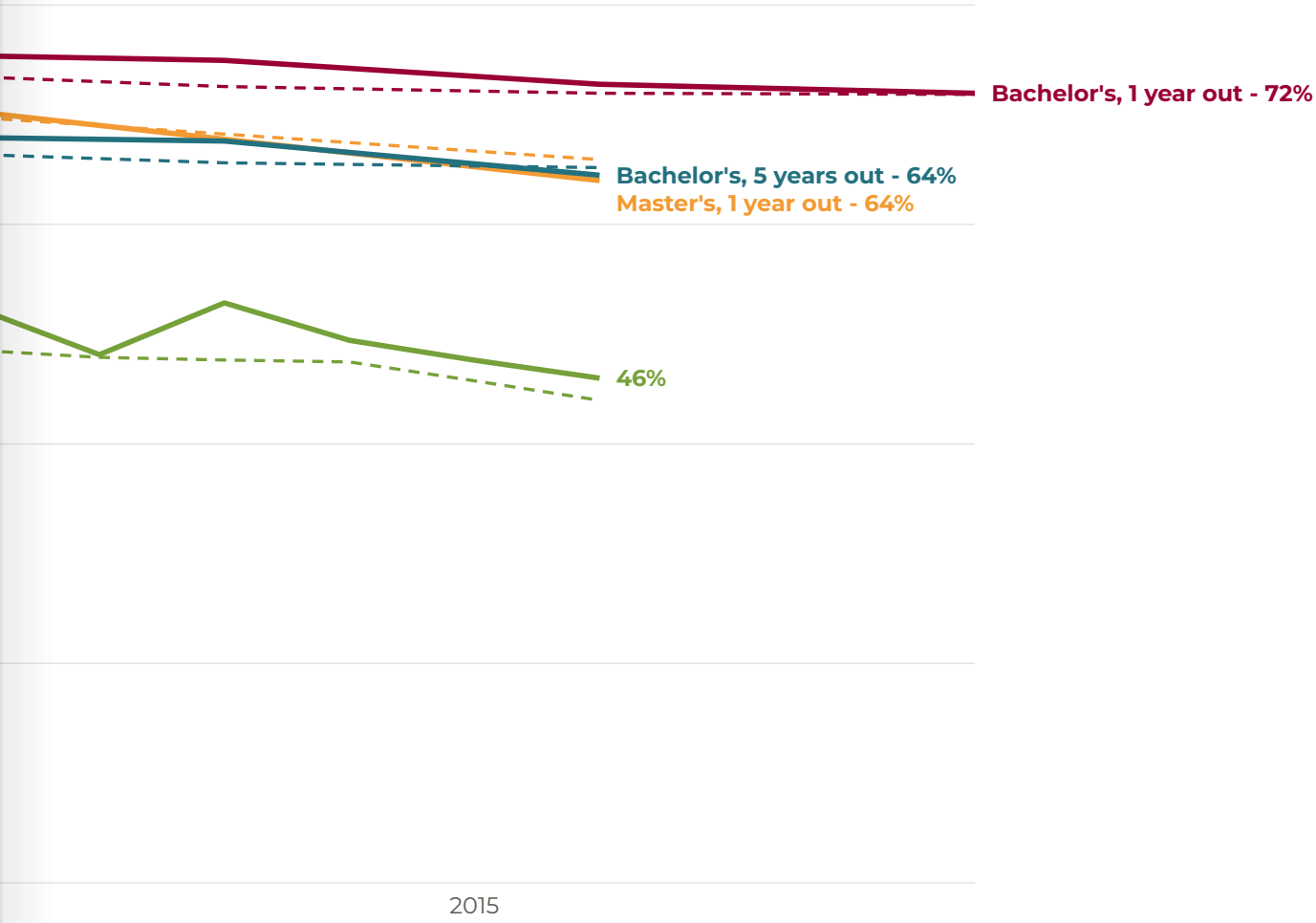


Share of employed graduates working in the state of their institution, by graduating cohort (Data from U.S. Census Burea
state where they studied (Data from ICE, SEVIS FOIA releases; shares only, the file is truncated). State solid, U.S. or particip

Of Colorado's bachelor's graduates who were working a year after graduating, 72% worked in the state (participating states 72%). Five years out the share was 64%.

Among international graduates on Optional Practical Training in 2016, 46% worked in the state where they studied (U.S. 44%). Through migration between states, the state gained 4.9 bachelor's-plus adults per 1,000 such residents in 2025 (Data from U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey).

U.S. (dashed)



au, Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes; participating institutions only); international graduates' OPT jobs in the
pating states dashed.

72%

Bachelor's grads working in-state, 1 year out, 2019

U.S. **72%** · **12th** of 33 · −0.8 pp since 2016

46%

OPT graduates working in the state, 2016

U.S. **44%** · **15th** of 51 · −1.6 pp since 2015

+4.9

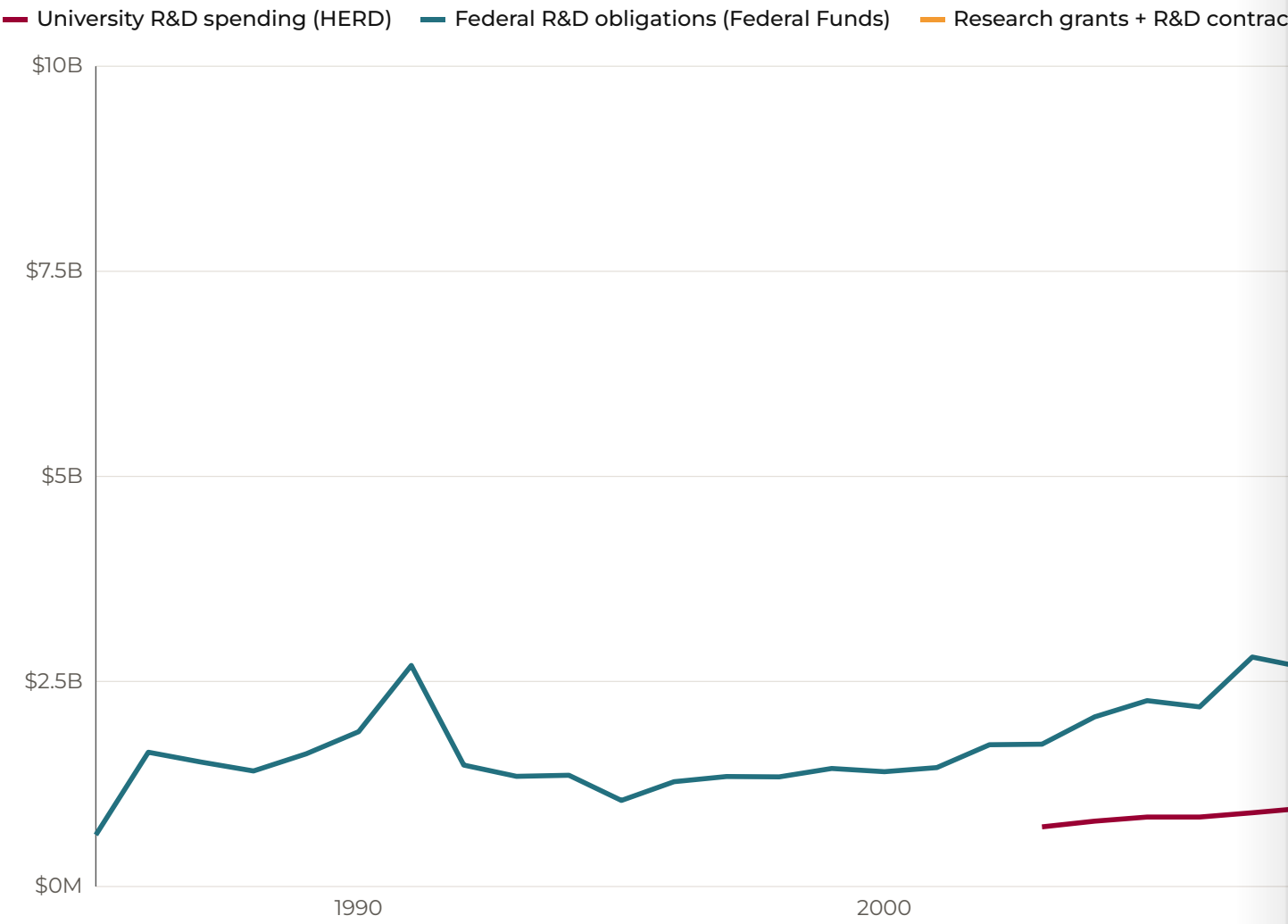
Net migration, bachelor's-plus, per 1,000, 2025

· **14th** of 51 · −5.2 since 2015

SECTION 7

Research Funding

Figure 17 How Much Research Money Flows Into Colorado?

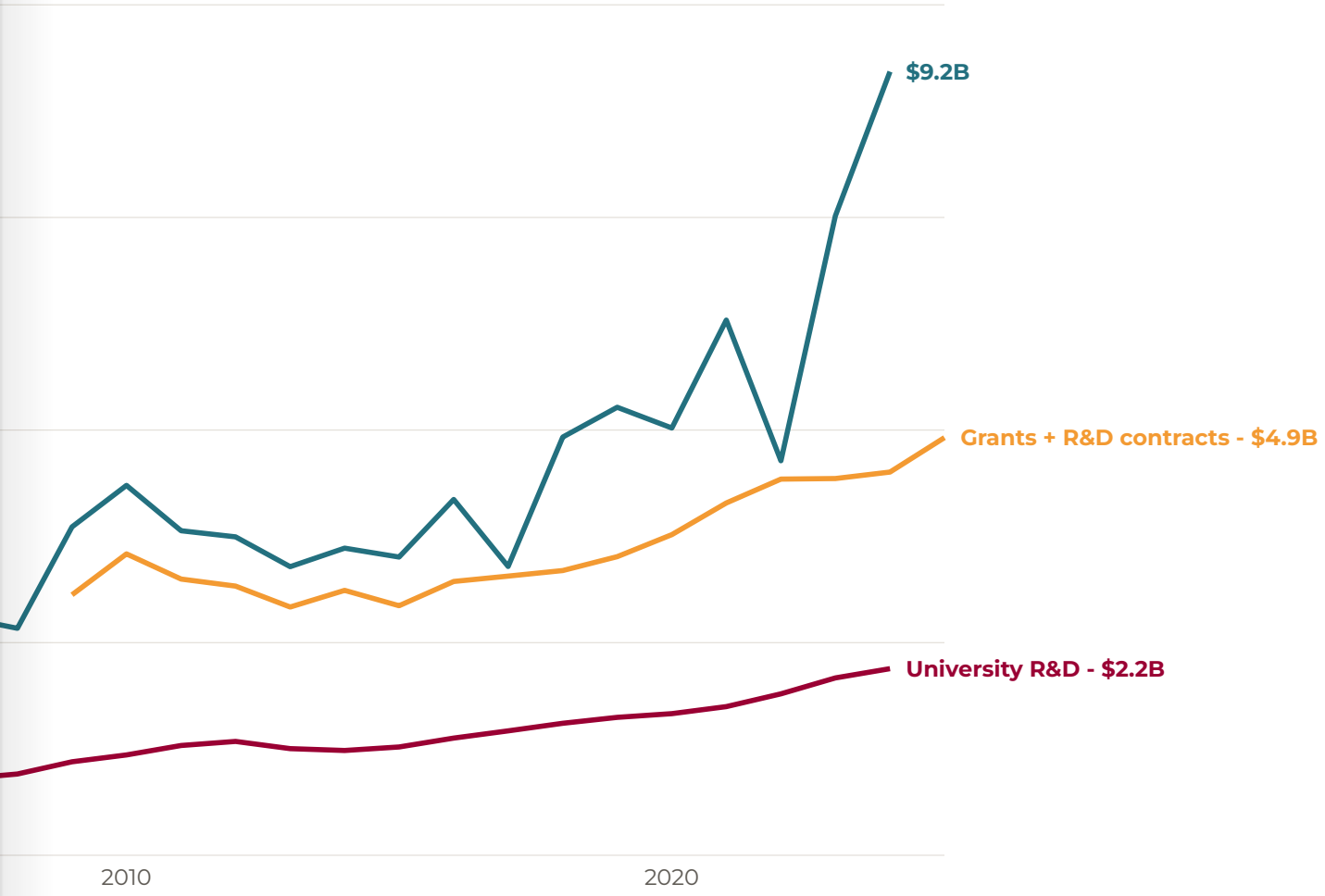


Millions of nominal dollars, fiscal years. University R&D: Data from NSF NCSES, Higher Education Research and Developm
Survey of Federal Funds for R&D (coverage widens in FY2021). Grants from NSF, NIH, NASA and DOE Science plus R&D co

Colorado's universities spent $2.19B on research and development in FY2024, 16th of 51 among the states; 71% of it was federally funded (U.S. 55%).

Federal agencies obligated $9.21B for R&D performed in the state in FY2024. Research funding drives demand for graduate students and postdocs, the stage of training most dependent on international talent.

ts (USAspending)



ent Survey (FY2003-09 predecessor survey). Federal R&D obligations by state of performance: Data from NSF NCSES, ntracts: Data from USAspending.gov.

$2.19B

University R&D spending, 2024

U.S. **$118B** · **16th** of 51 · +72% since 2015

71%

Federal share of university R&D, 2024

U.S. **55%** · **2nd** of 51 · −1.9 pp since 2015

$9.21B

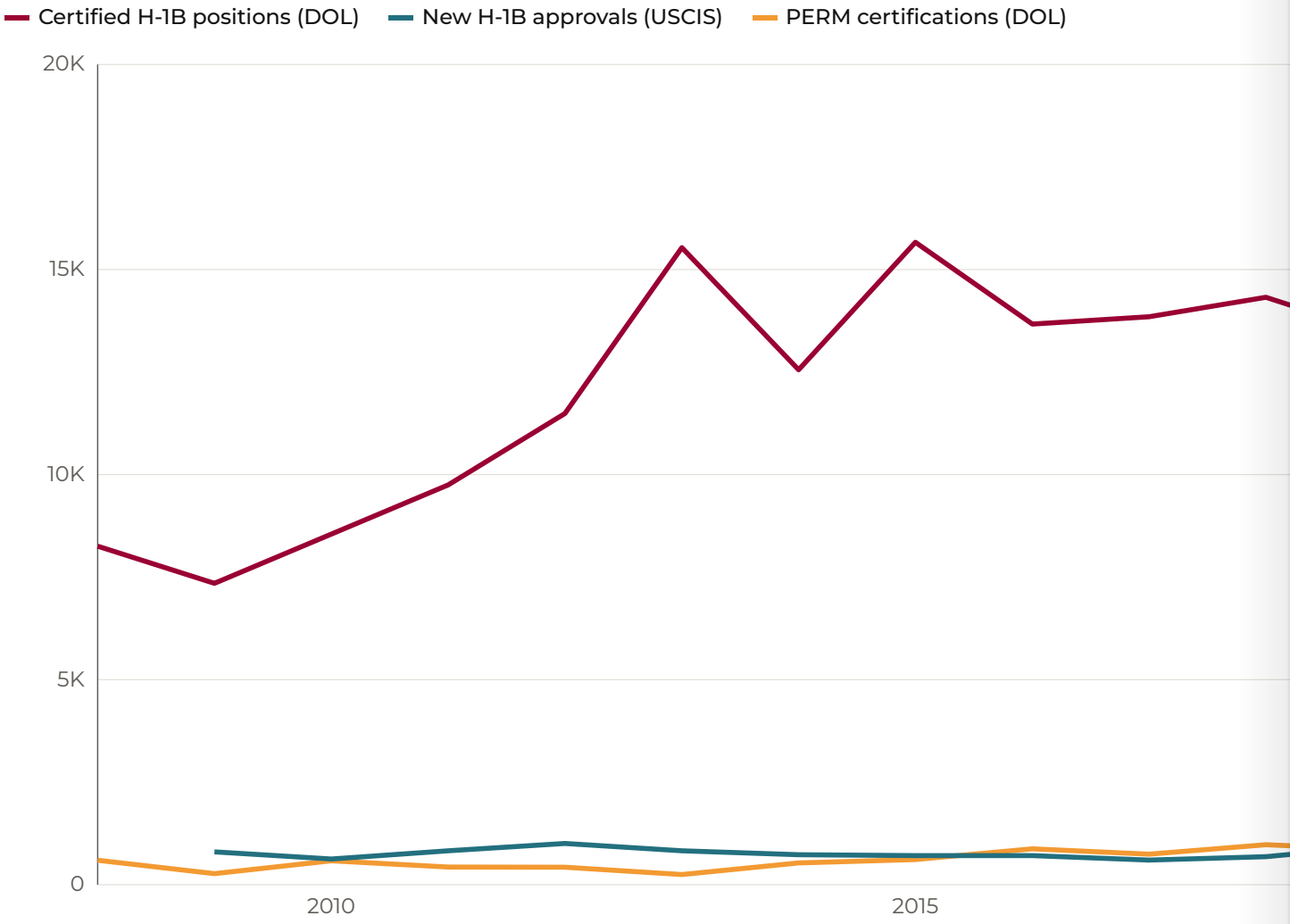
Federal R&D obligations, 2024

U.S. **$193B** · **7th** of 51 · 2.63× since 2015

SECTION 8

H-1B Jobs and Green Cards

Figure 18 How Many Skilled-Visa Jobs and Green-Card Certifications Does Colorado Ge

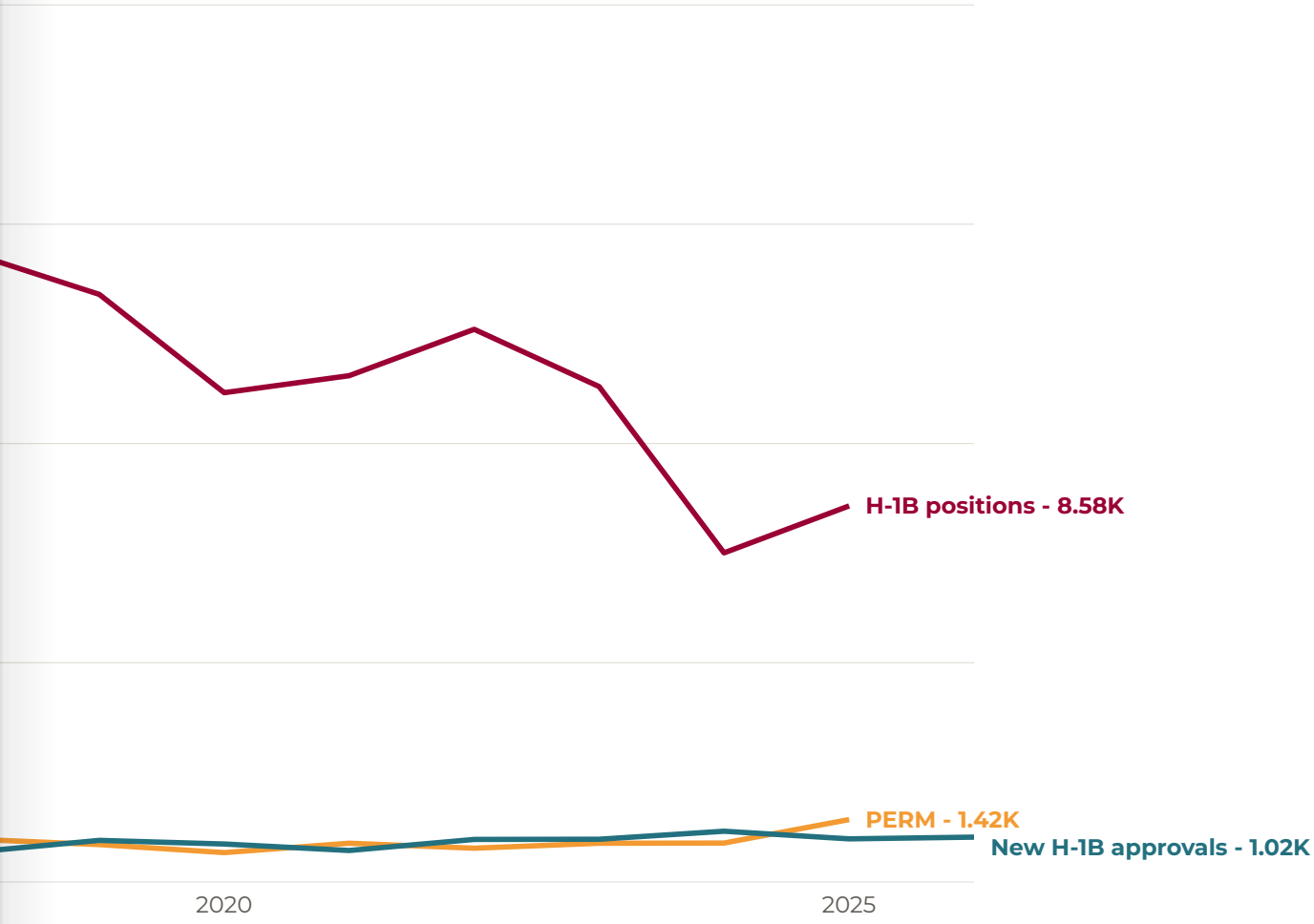


Certified H-1B positions on labor condition applications by worksite and certified PERM green-card applications, by fiscal
from USCIS, H-1B Employer Data Hub).

Employers were certified for 8.58K H-1B positions at Colorado worksites in FY2025, 20th of 51 among the states. A labor certification comes before the petition, so this overstates hires; USCIS approved 1.02K new H-1B petitions from employers in the state in FY2026.

DOL certified 1.42K PERM applications, the employer's step toward an employment-based green card, for jobs in the state in FY2025. In FY2024, 7.9% were for workers still on F-1 student visas (U.S. 8.7%): the most direct link from classroom to permanent residence.

nerate?



year (Data from DOL, Office of Foreign Labor Certification); new H-1B petition approvals by the employer's address (Data

8.58K

Certified H-1B positions (worksite), 2025

U.S. **914K** · **20th** of 51 · −45% since 2015

1.42K

PERM green-card certifications, 2025

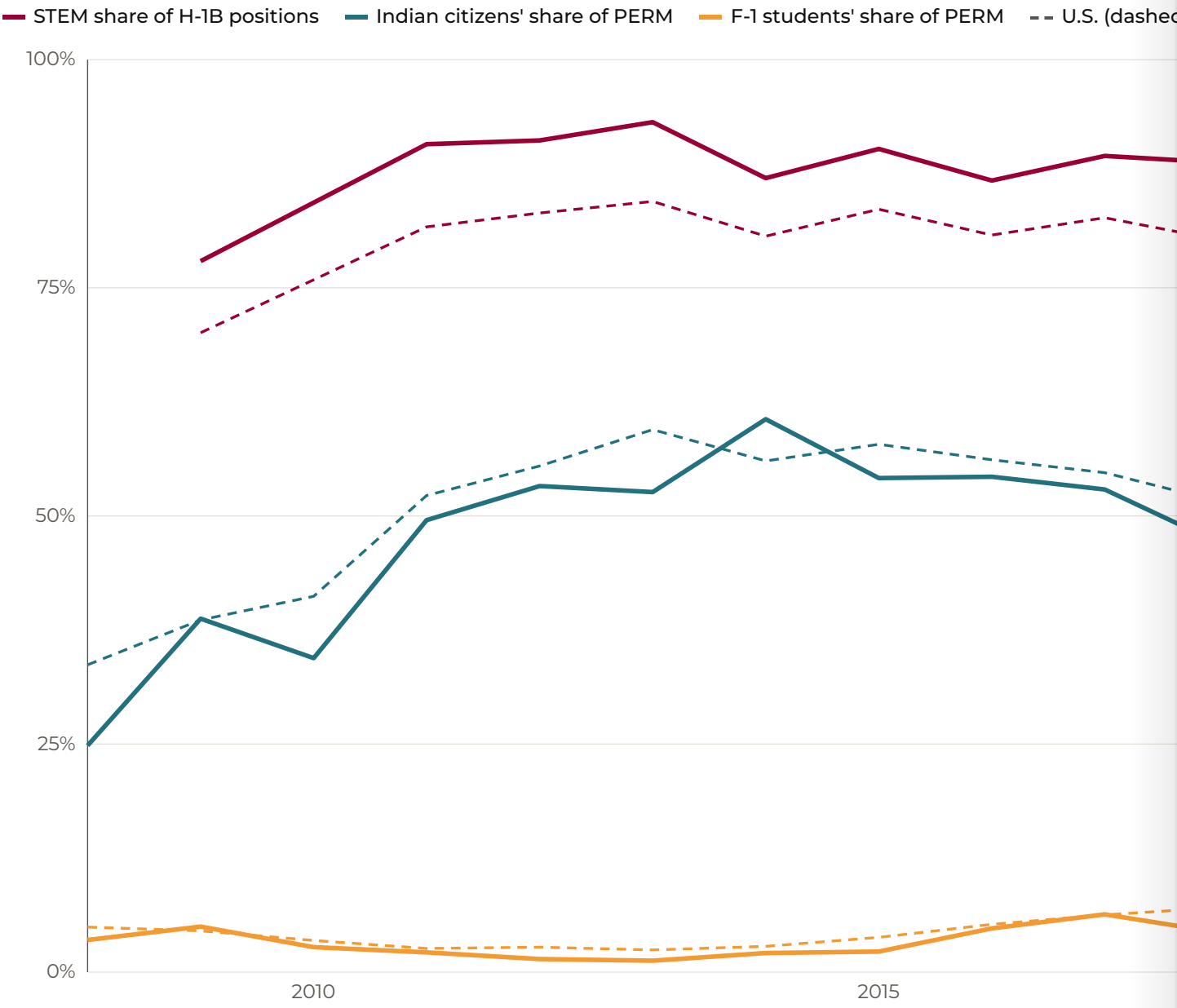
U.S. **138K** · **21st** of 51 · 2.31× since 2015

7.9%

PERM workers on F-1 student visas, 2024

U.S. **8.7%** · **33rd** of 51 · +5.6 pp since 2015

Figure 19 Who Holds Colorado's Skilled-Visa Jobs?

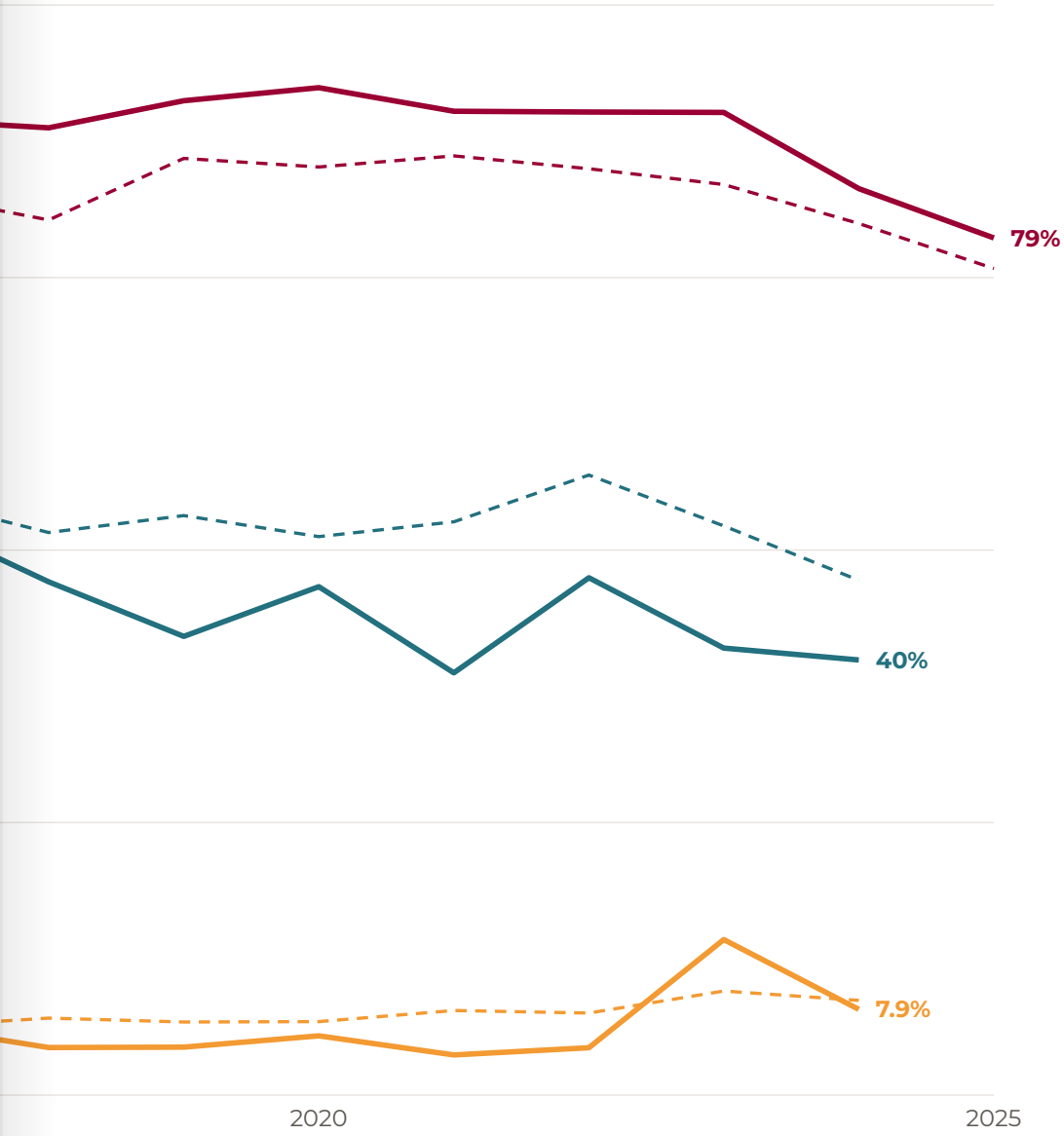


State solid, U.S. dashed. PERM citizenship and class of admission are not on the form DOL uses from FY2025. Data from D

79% of the state's certified H-1B positions were in STEM occupations in FY2025 (U.S. 76%).

Citizens of India held 40% of the state's PERM certifications in FY2024 (U.S. 47%). Under per-country caps they face the longest waits for a green card, so this share measures the state's exposure to the backlog.

d)



OL, Office of Foreign Labor Certification.

79%

STEM share of H-1B positions, 2025

U.S. **76%** · **13th** of 51 · −11.6 pp since 2015

40%

PERM certifications for Indian citizens, 2024

U.S. **47%** · **23rd** of 51 · −14.2 pp since 2015

$115K

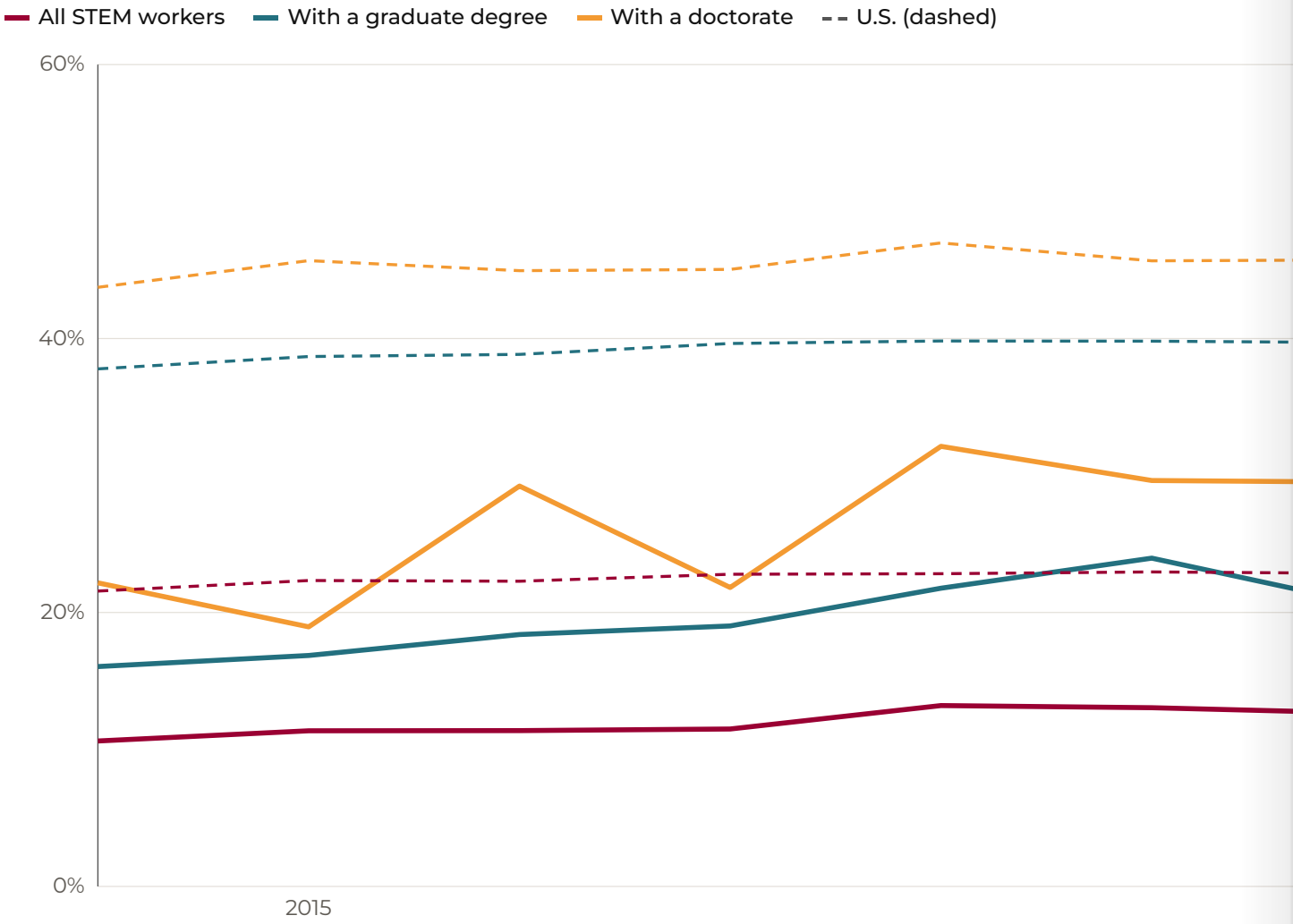
Median offered H-1B wage (nominal), 2025

U.S. **$119K** · **9th** of 51 · +60% since 2015

SECTION 9

STEM Workforce

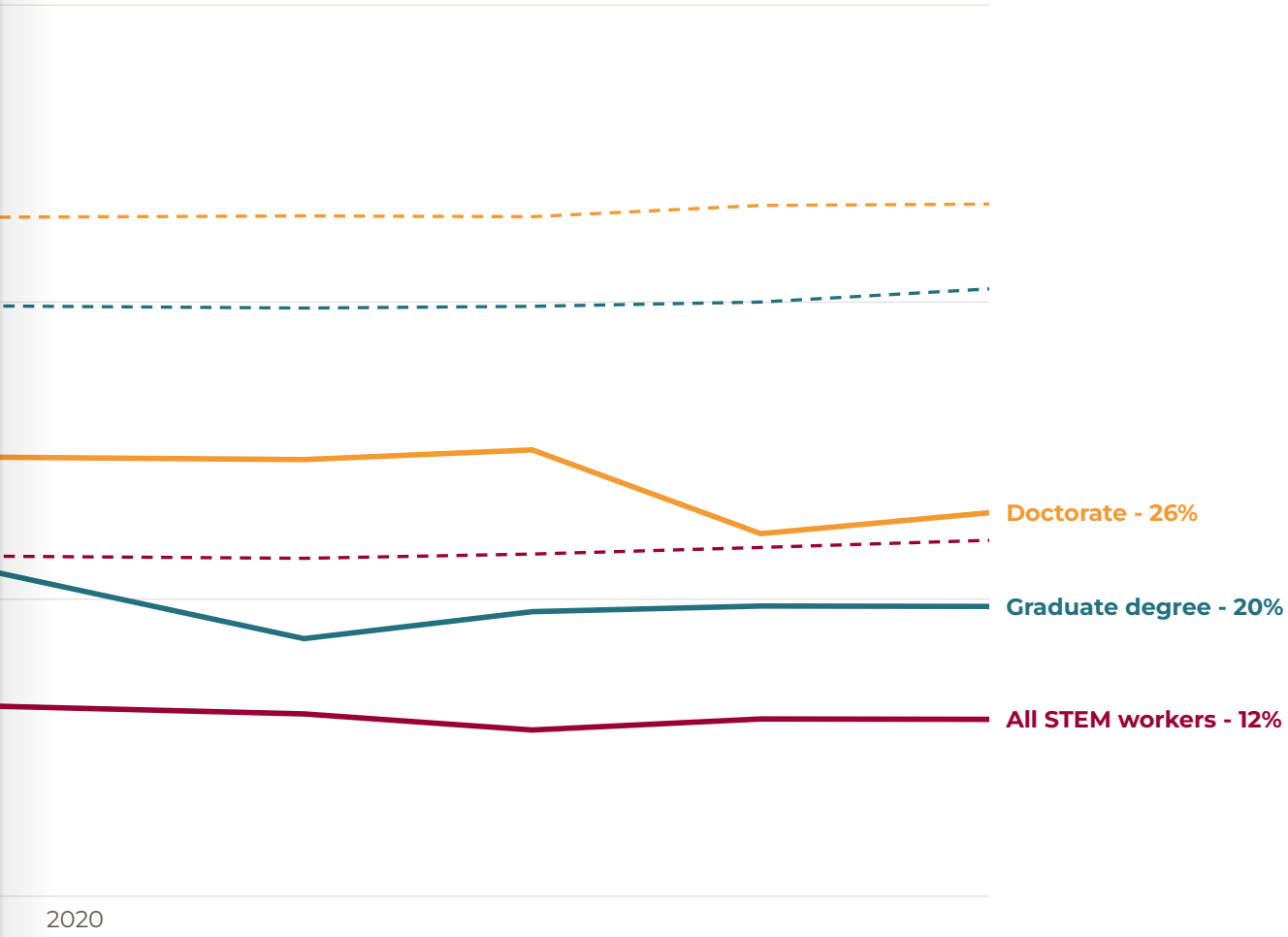
Figure 20 How Much of Colorado's STEM Workforce Was Born Abroad?



Foreign-born share of employed workers in STEM occupations, by state of residence; state solid, U.S. dashed. Shares resti
Community Survey.

In 2024, 12% of the people working in STEM occupations in Colorado were born abroad (U.S. 24%; 34th of 51).

The share rises with education: 20% of STEM workers with a graduate degree were foreign-born (U.S. 41%). 5.4% of all STEM workers were not U.S. citizens.



ng on fewer than 100 survey records are left out. No 2020 (experimental data). Data from U.S. Census Bureau, American

12%

Foreign-born share of STEM workers, 2024

U.S. **24%** · **34th** of 51 · +0.6 pp since 2015

20%

Foreign-born, STEM workers with grad degrees, 2024

U.S. **41%** · **40th** of 44 · +2.7 pp since 2015

5.4%

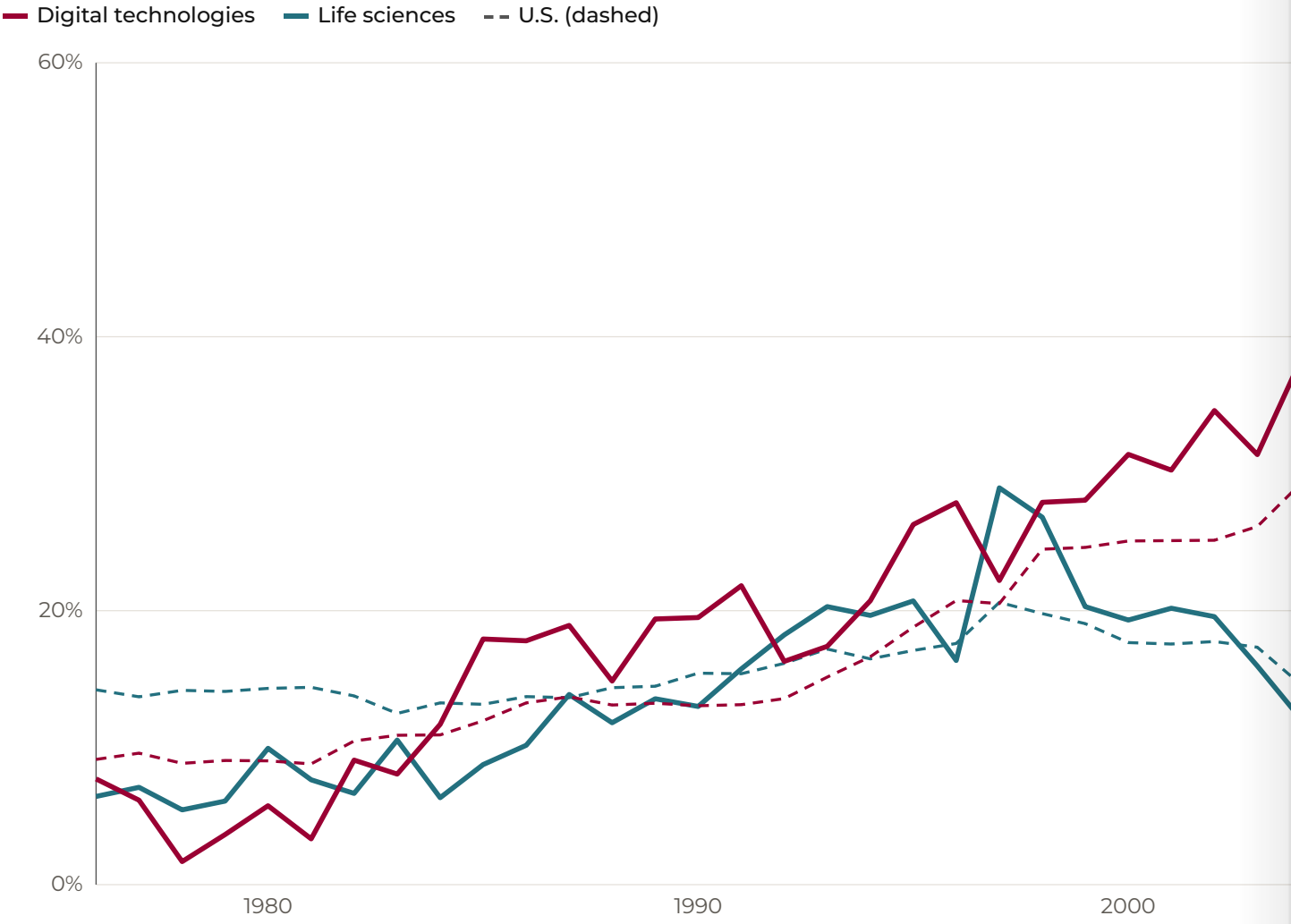
Noncitizen share of STEM workers, 2024

U.S. **11%** · **37th** of 51 · −0.6 pp since 2015

SECTION 10

Patents

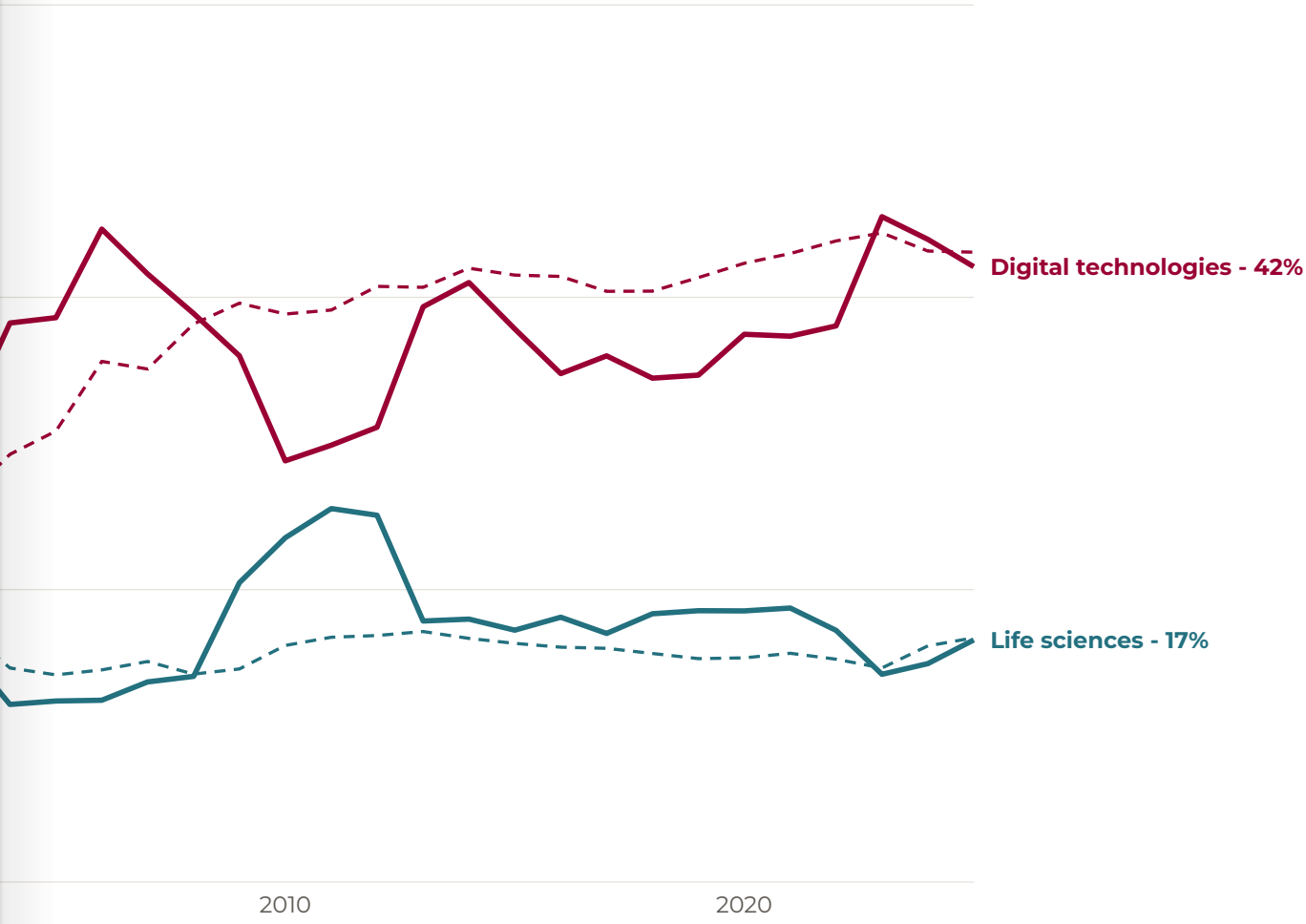
Figure 21 What Kinds of Technology Does Colorado Patent?



Share of patents granted to owners in the state, by WIPO technology field of the first classification; state solid, U.S. dashed

Organizations and people in Colorado were granted 2.08K U.S. patents in 2025, 1.5% of all patents with a U.S. owner (16th of 51).

42% were in digital technologies (U.S. 43%) and 17% in the life sciences (U.S. 17%).



d. Fractional counts by the owner's (assignee's) location, not where inventors live. Data from USPTO, PatentsView.

2.08K

Patents granted to owners in the state, 2025

U.S. **135K** · **16th** of 51 · +28% since 2015

42%

Patents in digital technologies, 2025

U.S. **43%** · **12th** of 51 · +4.3 pp since 2015

17%

Patents in life sciences, 2025

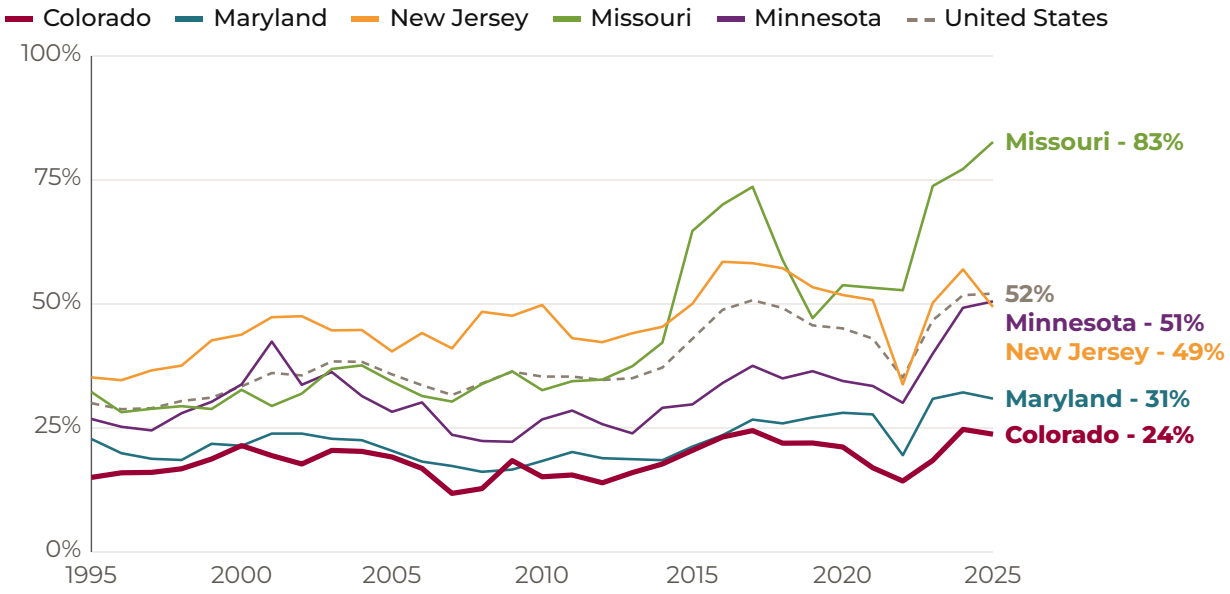
U.S. **17%** · **27th** of 51 · −0.7 pp since 2015

SECTION 11

Competitors

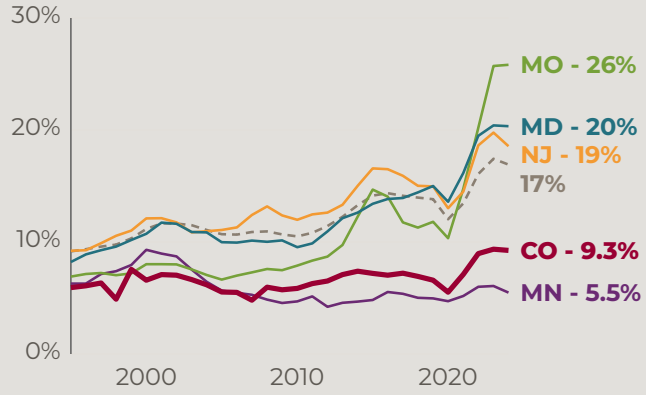
The four states closest in size are Maryland, New Jersey, Missouri, Minnesota. Colorado ranks 5th of the five on the international share of STEM master's; Missouri is the most dependent at 83%.

Figure 22 How Dependent Are Colorado and Its Peers on International STEM Master's?



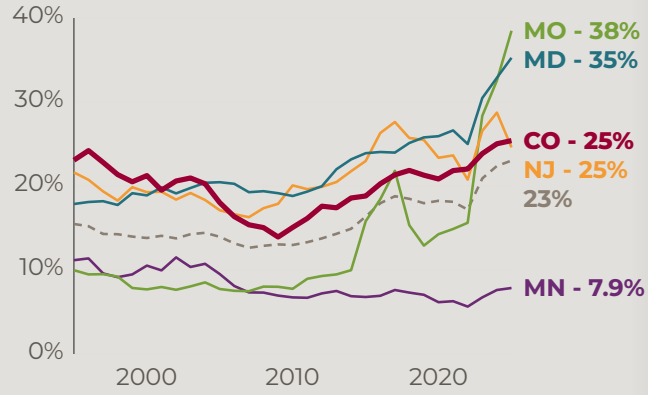
Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Figure 23 Int. share of grad students



Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 24 STEM share of master's



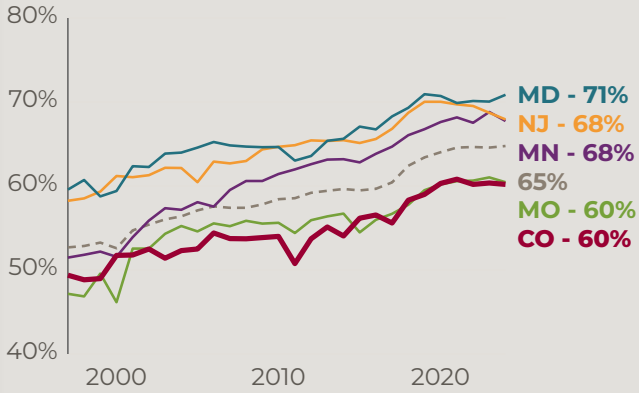
Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Table 4 How Does Colorado Compare With States of Similar Size?

Measure	CO	MD	NJ	MO	MN	U.S.
Students enrolled	**371K**	356K	393K	342K	411K	19.7M
Graduate share of students	**15%**	21%	18%	23%	27%	17%
STEM share of bachelor's	**30%**	35%	25%	21%	18%	24%
STEM share of master's	**25%**	35%	25%	38%	7.9%	23%
International STEM master's	**995**	2.49K	2.28K	7.27K	1.07K	117K
Share of U.S. international STEM master's	**0.9%**	2.1%	2.0%	6.2%	0.9%	–
Int. share of STEM master's	**24%**	31%	49%	83%	51%	52%
Int. share of STEM research doctorates	**21%**	39%	50%	51%	33%	43%
Int. share of grad students	**9.3%**	20%	19%	26%	5.5%	17%
Int. share of undergraduate enrollment	**2.0%**	4.0%	3.8%	2.7%	2.7%	3.0%
Six-year graduation rate	**60%**	71%	68%	60%	68%	65%
In-state tuition, public 4-year	**$9.74K**	$10.1K	$16.2K	$10.5K	$13.4K	$9.71K
Appropriations per student	**$1.51K**	$17.5K	$11.2K	$8.75K	$11.1K	$11.4K
Average faculty salary	**$98K**	$115K	$133K	$93.7K	$96.8K	$106K
First-time students from in state	**70%**	76%	87%	74%	78%	–
Net migration per 100 residents	**+0**	−16	−31	+0	−15	–

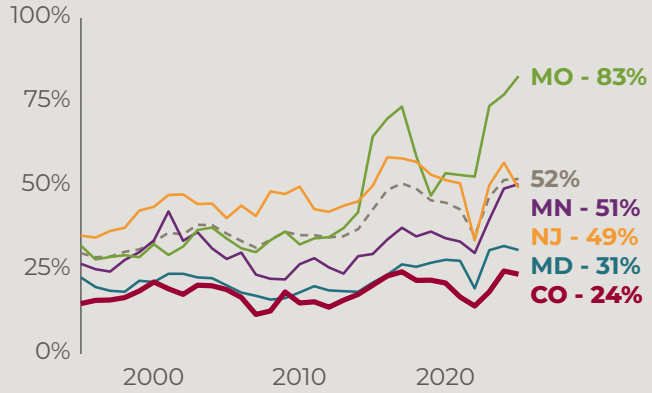
Latest year for each measure. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 25 Six-year graduation rate



Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 26 Int. share of STEM master's

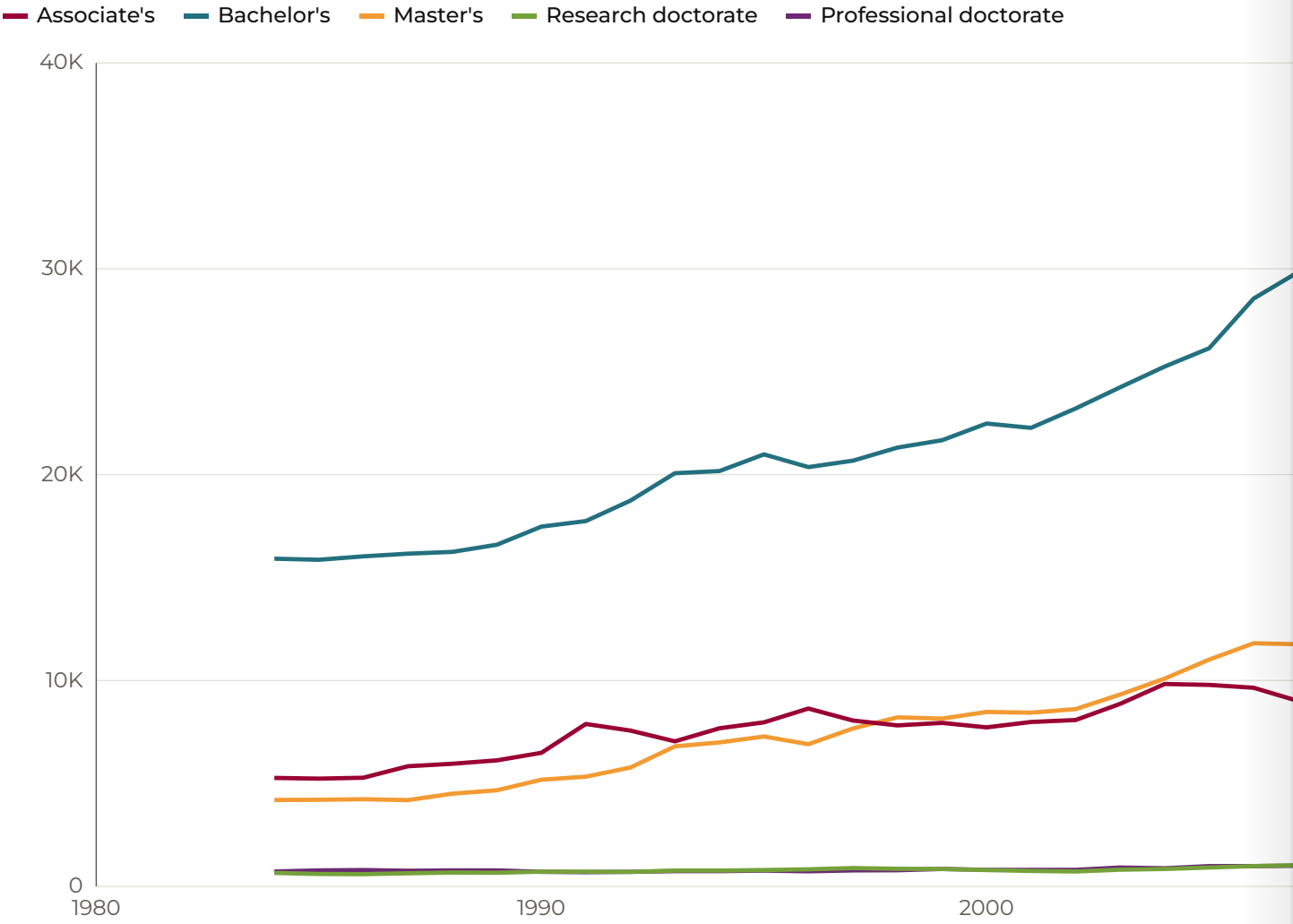


Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 12

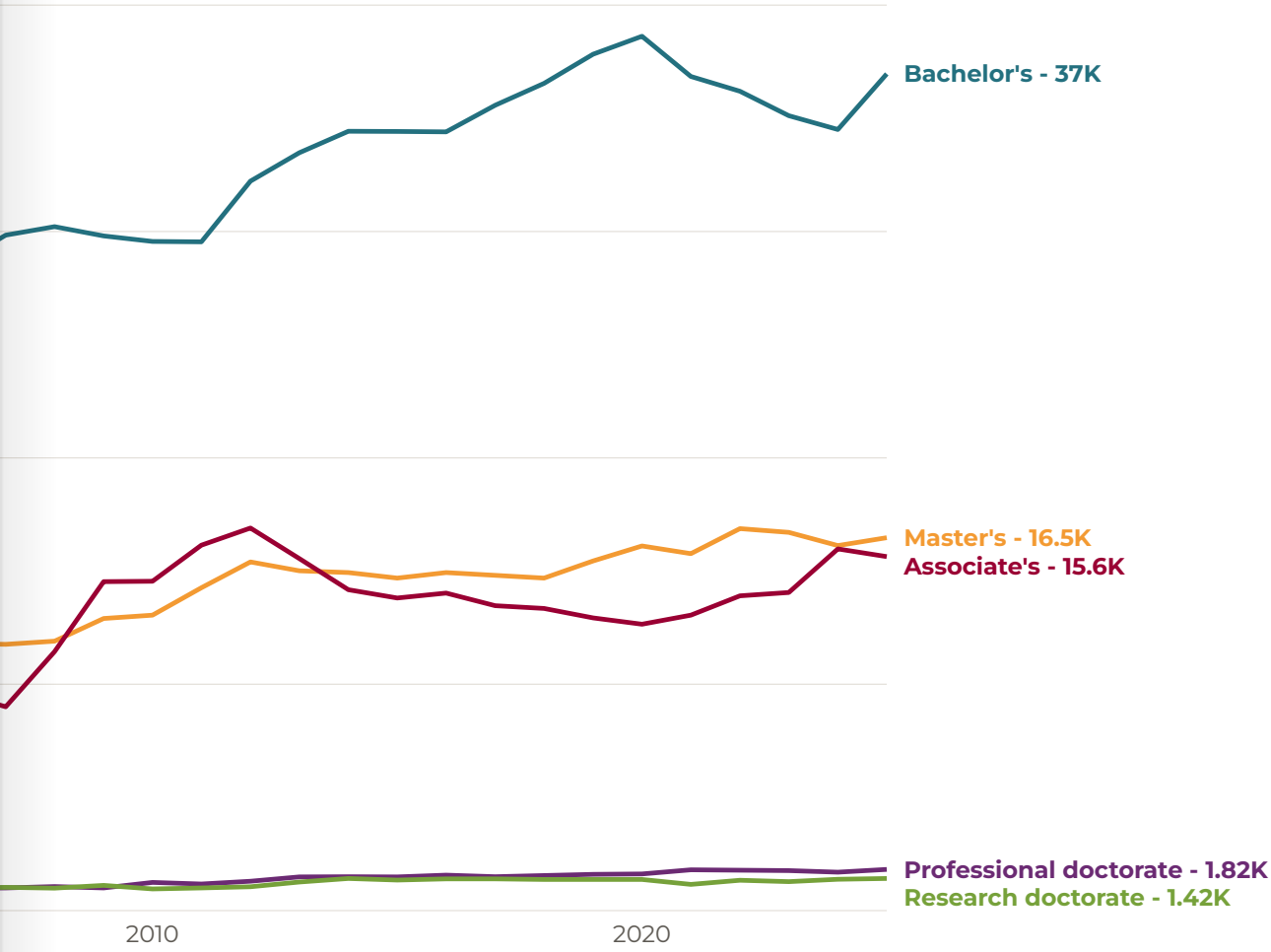
Fields of Study

Figure 27 How Many Degrees Does Colorado Award?



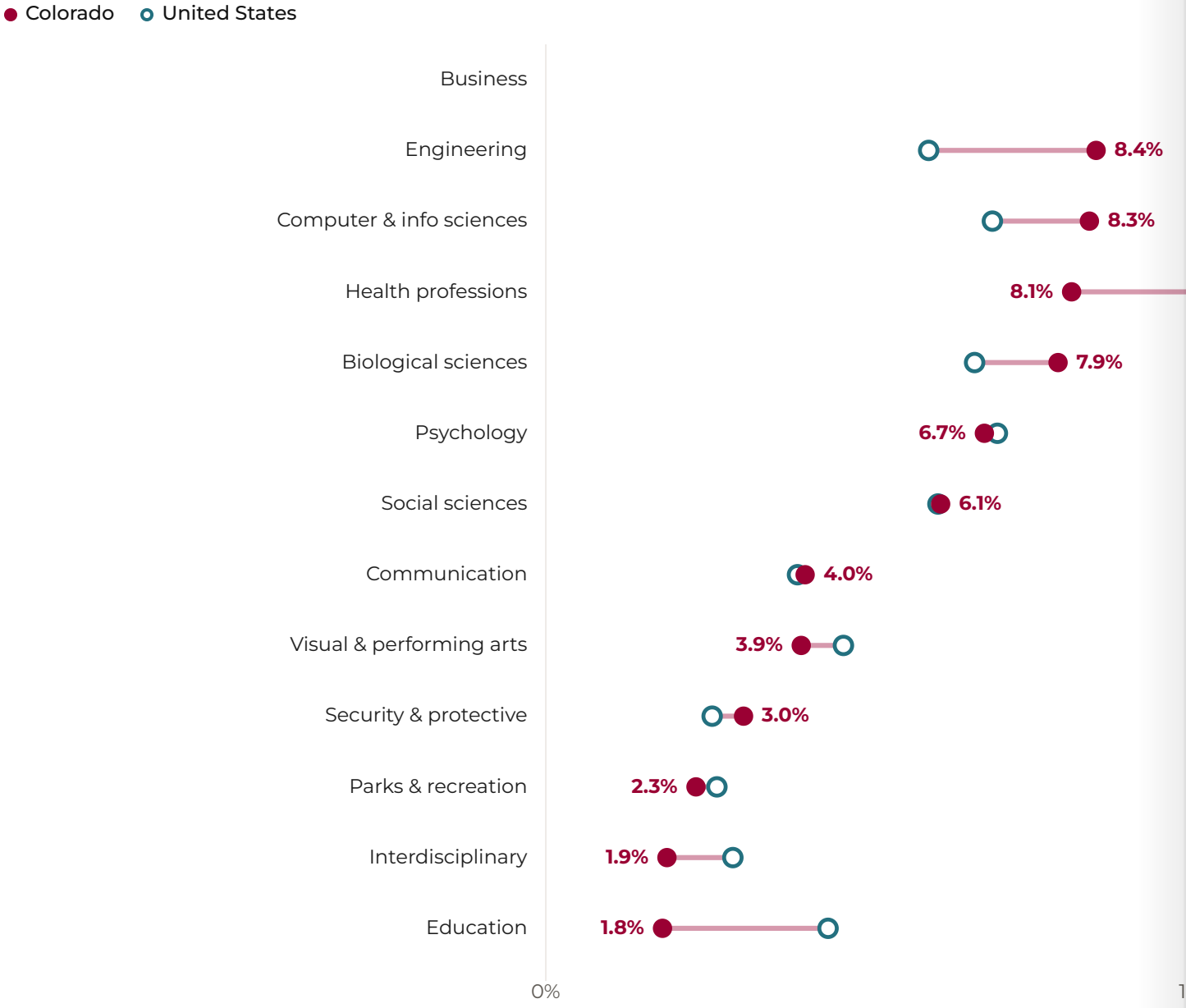
Degrees awarded by level, first majors. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

In 2025, Colorado's institutions awarded 15.6K associate's degrees, 37K bachelor's degrees, 16.5K master's degrees, 1.42K research doctorate degrees, 1.82K professional doctorate degrees.



Since 2015: associate's up 13%; bachelor's up 7%; master's up 12%; research doctorate up 5%; professional doctorate up 22%. The state awards 11.7 bachelor's degrees for every 100 undergraduates (U.S. 12.3).

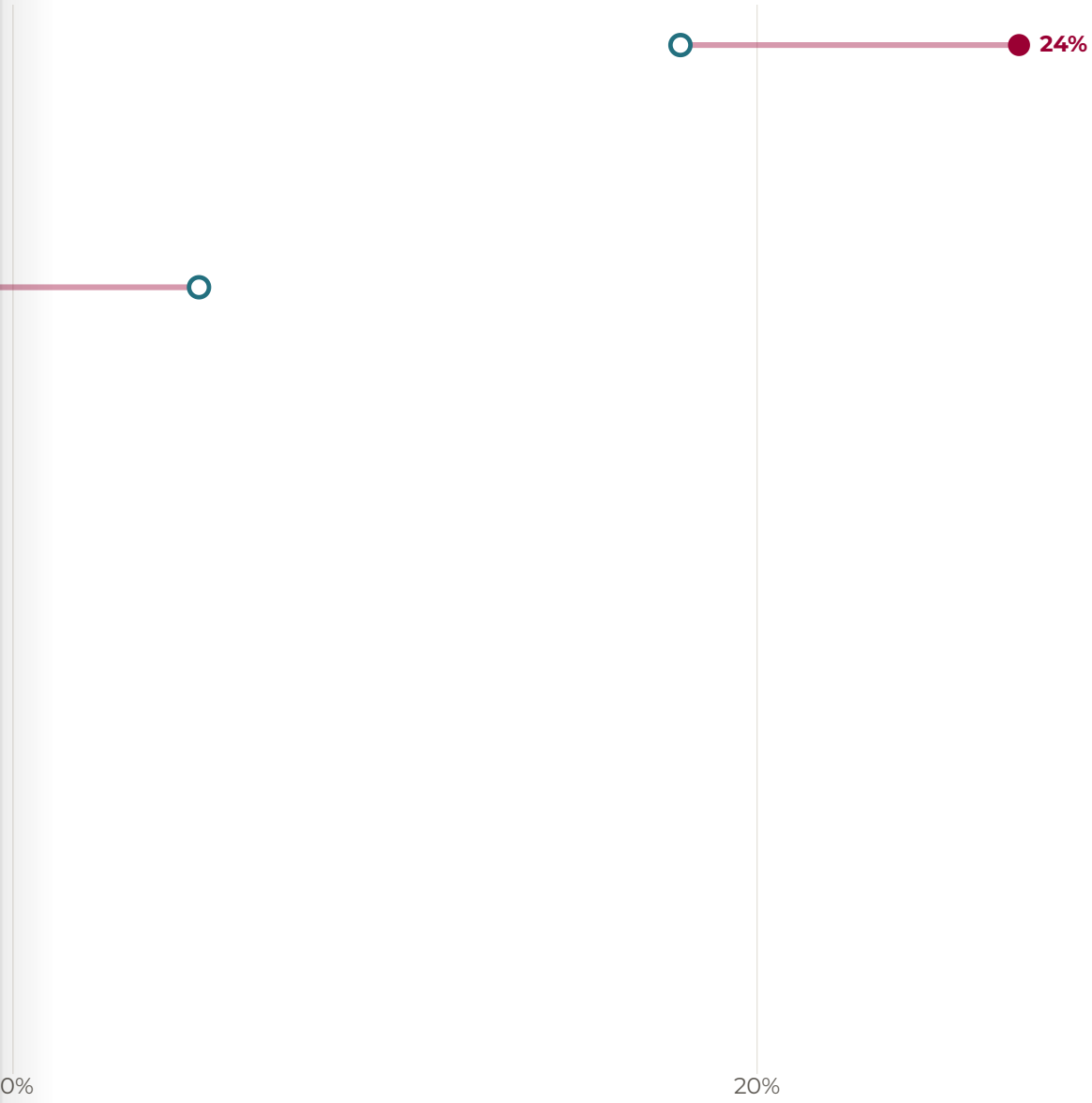
Figure 28 What Do Colorado's Bachelor's Graduates Study?



Share of bachelor's degrees by field, 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Colorado's largest bachelor's fields are business (24%; U.S. 19%), engineering (8.4%; U.S. 5.9%), computer & info sciences (8.3%; U.S. 6.9%).

Relative to the nation, Colorado's bachelor's degrees are most concentrated in architecture (1.73× the U.S. share), engineering (1.44× the U.S. share), natural resources (1.29× the U.S. share).



8.3%

Bachelor's in computer science, 2025

U.S. **6.9%** · **8th** of 51 · +4.5 pp since 2015

9.4%

Bachelor's in engineering, 2025

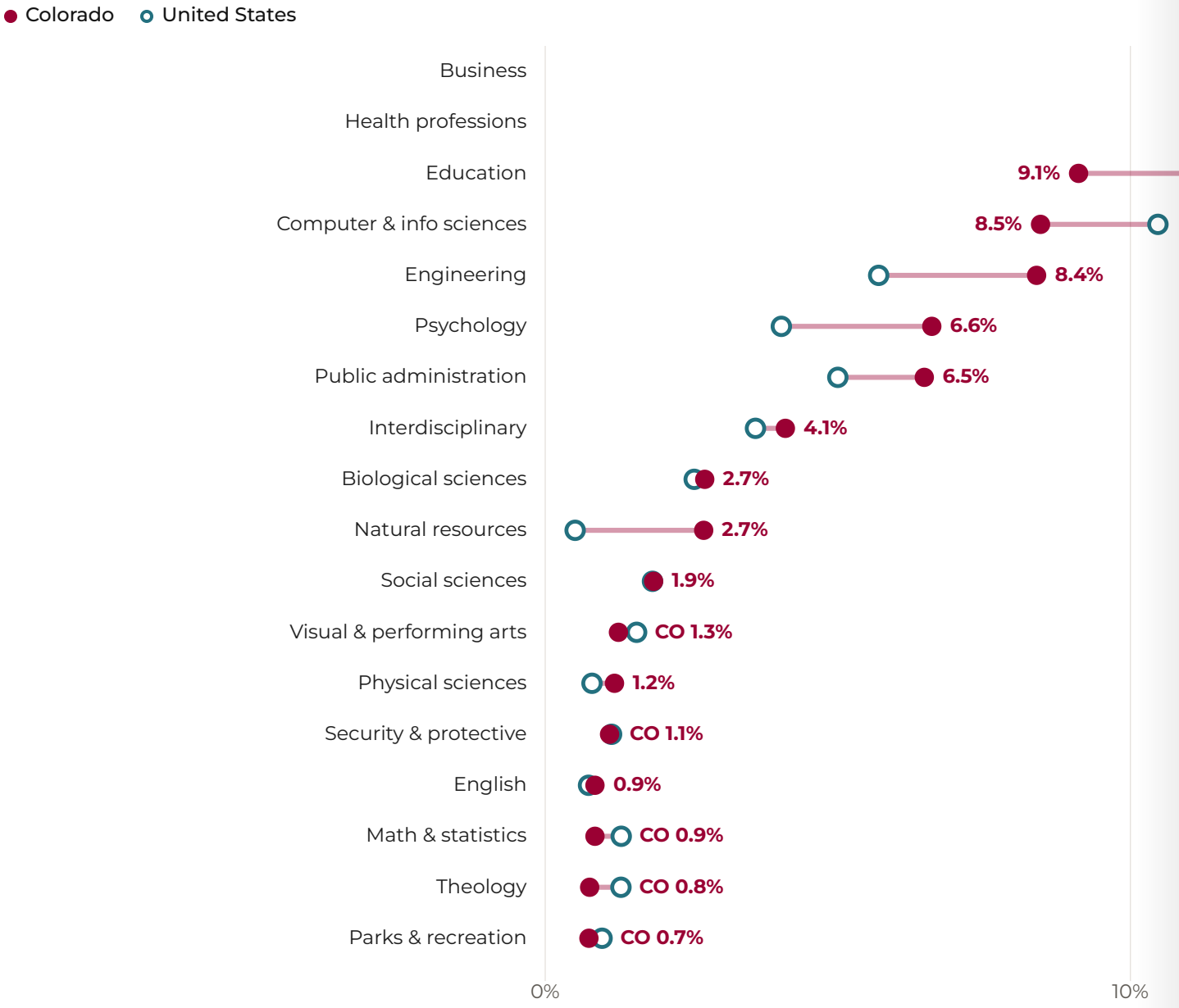
U.S. **6.8%** · **5th** of 51 · +1.9 pp since 2015

24%

Bachelor's in business, 2025

U.S. **19%** · **7th** of 51 · +2.7 pp since 2015

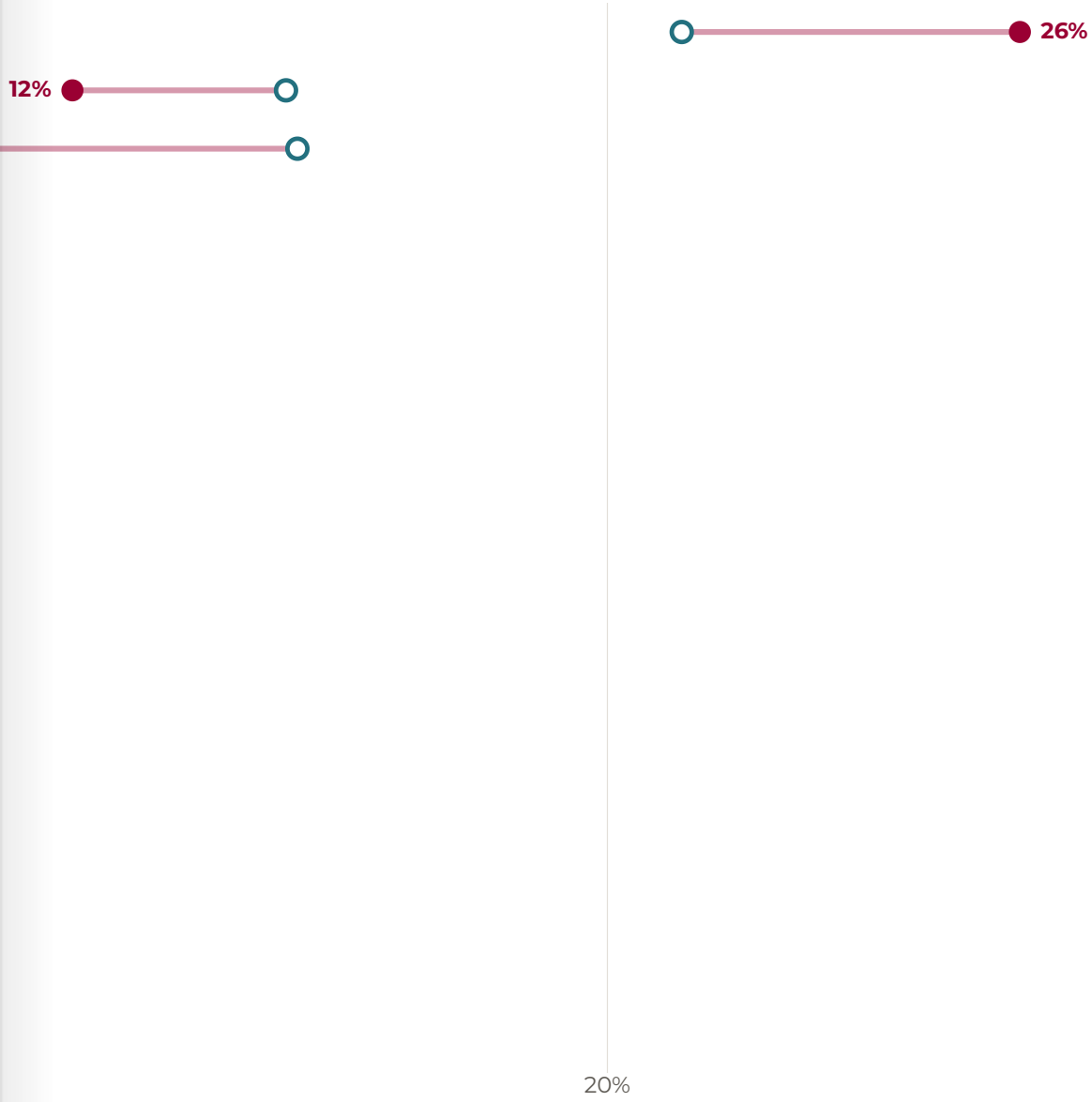
Figure 29 What Do Colorado's Master's Graduates Study?



Share of master's degrees by field, 2025; largest fields. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Colorado's largest master's fields are business (26%; U.S. 21%), health professions (12%; U.S. 15%), education (9.1%; U.S. 15%).

International students earn 11% of all master's degrees in the state (U.S. 22%), and STEM fields account for 25% of them.



25%

STEM share of master's, 2025

U.S. **23%** · **14th** of 51 · +6.6 pp since 2015

11%

Int. share of all master's, 2025

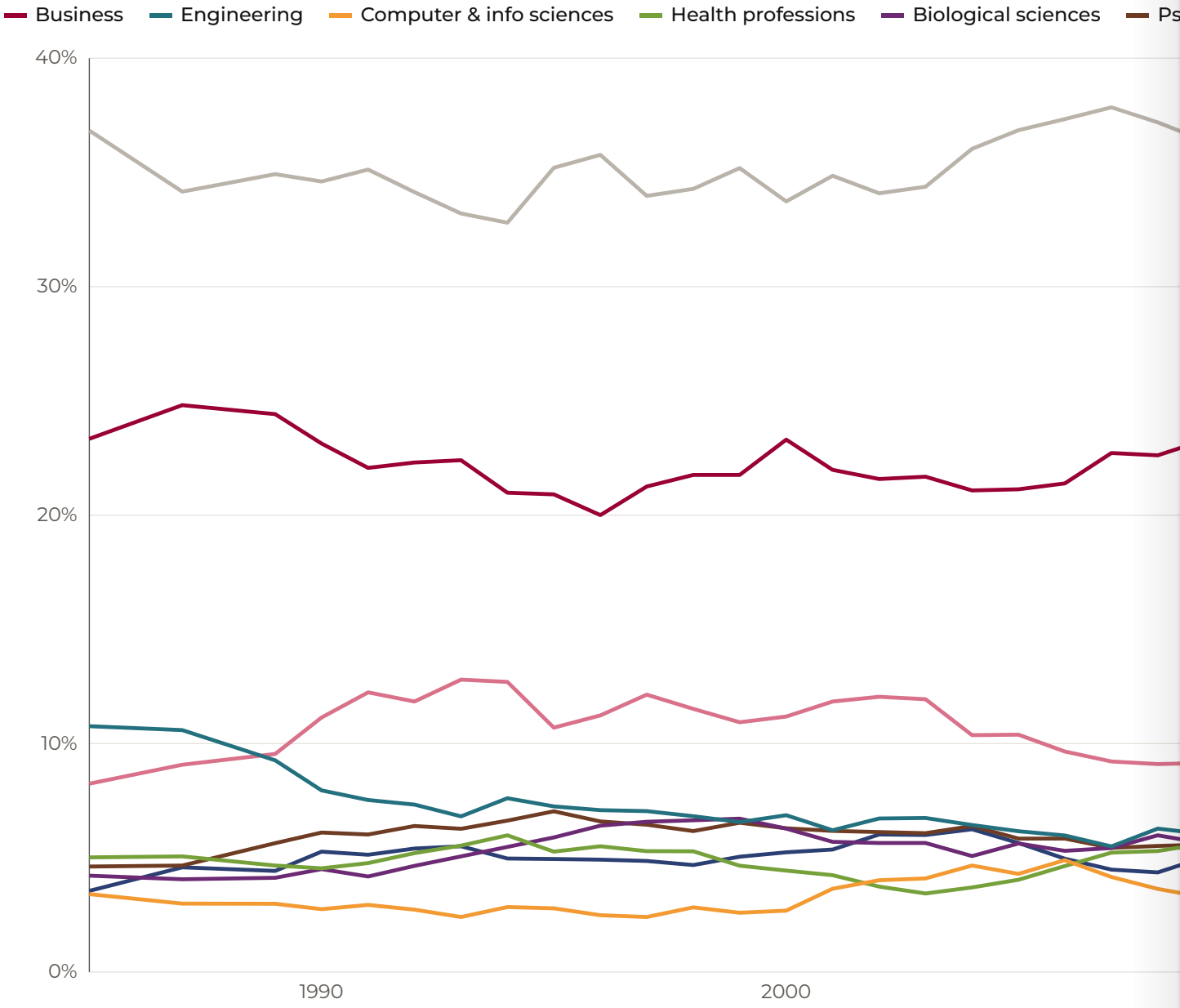
U.S. **22%** · **38th** of 51 · +2.7 pp since 2015

35%

Int. share of CS master's, 2025

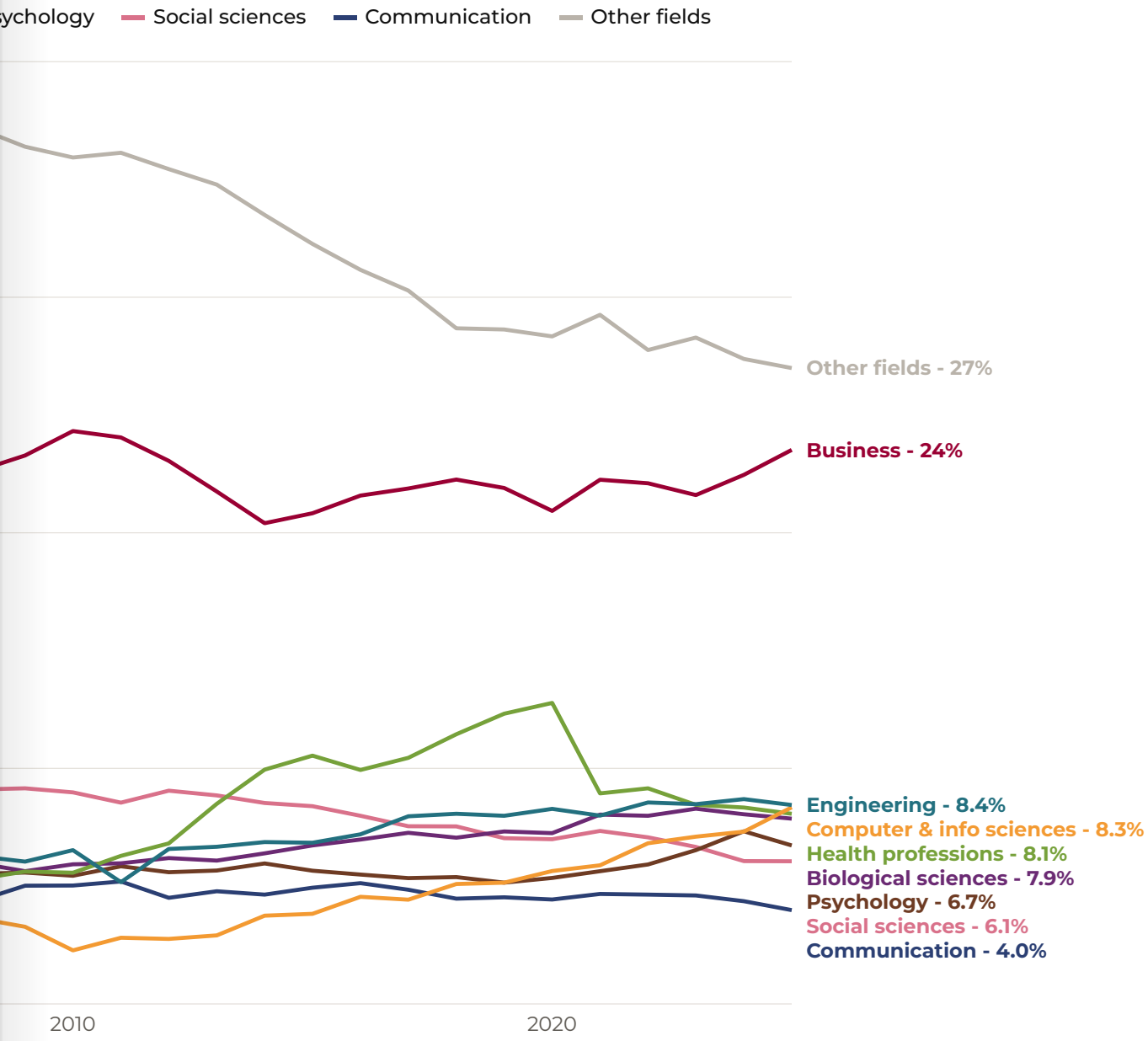
U.S. **65%** · **40th** of 47 · +16.5 pp since 2015

Figure 30 How Has Colorado's Bachelor's Field Mix Changed?



Share of bachelor's degrees in the largest fields. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Since 2015, computer & info sciences has gained the most ground, 4.5 points of the state's bachelor's degrees, while health professions lost the most (2.5 points).



The chart follows the share of bachelor's degrees in each of the state's largest fields; smaller fields are grouped as other fields.

FIELDS OF STUDY

Where Is Colorado Specialized, and What Do Its Doctoral Graduates Study?

The location quotient divides a field's share of Colorado's bachelor's degrees by its share of all U.S. bachelor's degrees in 2025. A quotient of 1.00 means the same share as the nation; 2.00 means twice the national share. The table lists the 10 fields with the highest quotients among fields with at least 50 degrees.

Highest location quotients. Architecture 1.73 (1.0% of the state's bachelor's degrees; U.S. 0.6%); engineering 1.44 (8.4% of the state's bachelor's degrees; U.S. 5.9%); natural resources 1.29 (1.4% of the state's bachelor's degrees; U.S. 1.1%).

Table 5 Where Is Colorado Most Specialized?

Field	Location quotient	State share	U.S. share	Degrees
Architecture	**1.73**	1.0%	0.6%	362
Engineering	**1.44**	8.4%	5.9%	3.12K
Natural resources	**1.29**	1.4%	1.1%	534
Business	**1.24**	24%	19%	8.69K
Computer & info sciences	**1.22**	8.3%	6.9%	3.08K
Biological sciences	**1.20**	7.9%	6.6%	2.91K
Security & protective	**1.19**	3.0%	2.6%	1.12K
Physical sciences	**1.11**	1.4%	1.3%	529
Engineering technology	**1.10**	1.0%	0.9%	364
Communications tech	**1.07**	0.3%	0.3%	105

Bachelor's degrees; location quotient = state share ÷ U.S. share; fields with 50+ degrees. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

30%
STEM share of bachelor's, 2025
U.S. **24%** · **6th** of 51

8.3%
Bachelor's in computer science, 2025
U.S. **6.9%** · **8th** of 51

9.4%
Bachelor's in engineering, 2025
U.S. **6.8%** · **5th** of 51

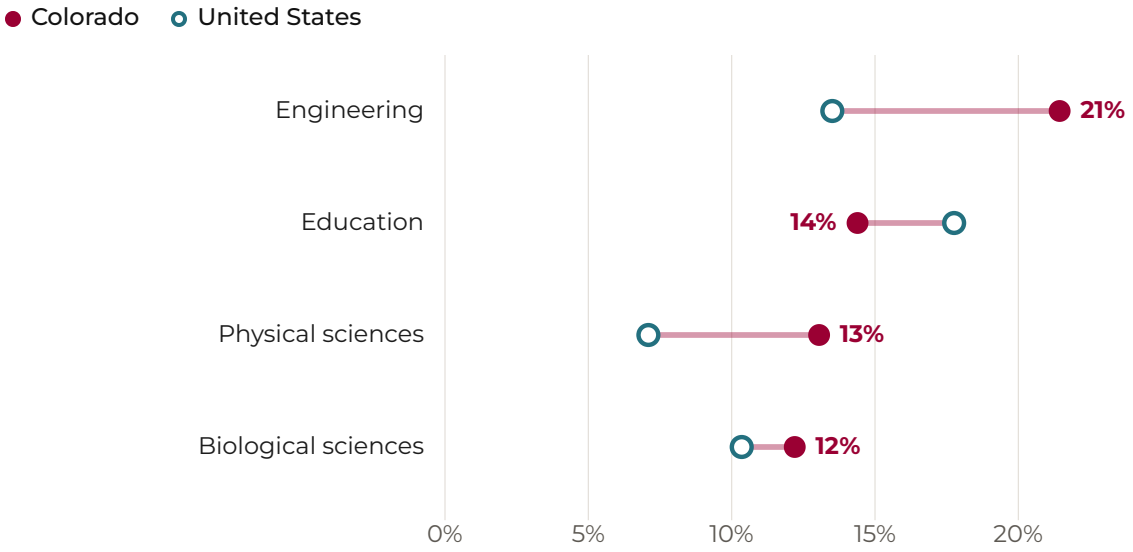
24%
Bachelor's in business, 2025
U.S. **19%** · **7th** of 51

Each row is a field's share of the research doctorates awarded in Colorado in 2025 (filled dot), against its share nationally (open dot), for the ten largest fields with at least 20 doctorates. Research doctorates exclude professional doctorates such as the M.D. and J.D.

Largest doctoral fields. Engineering 21% (U.S. 14%); education 14% (U.S. 18%); physical sciences 13% (U.S. 7.1%).

STEM share of research doctorates. 56% in 2025 (U.S. 39%; 5th of 51 states), up 0.9 points from 55% in 2024, and up 7.1 points since 2015 (49%).

Figure 31 What Do Colorado's Doctoral Graduates Study?

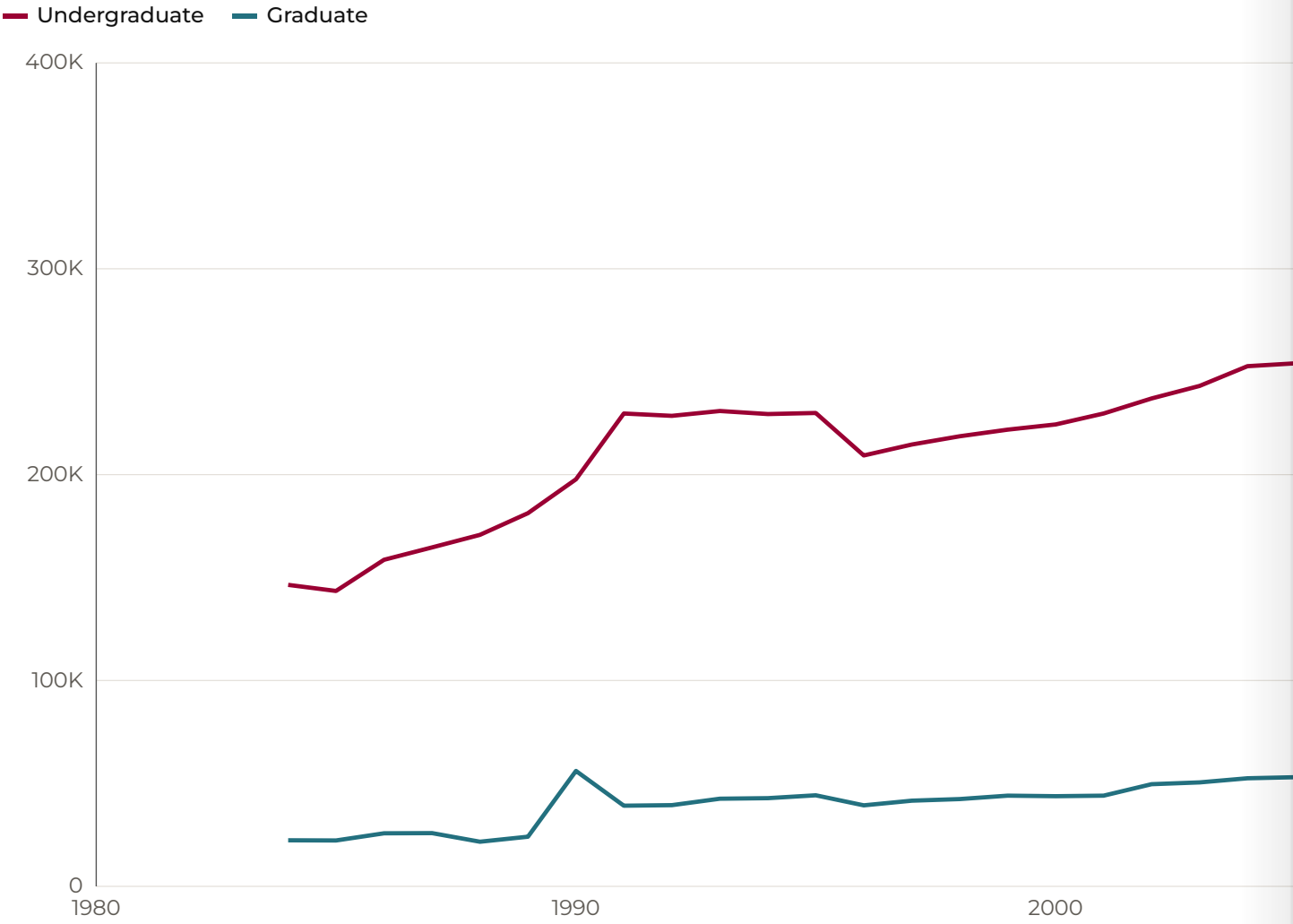


Share of research doctorates by field, 2025; fields with 20+ doctorates. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 13

Students and Money

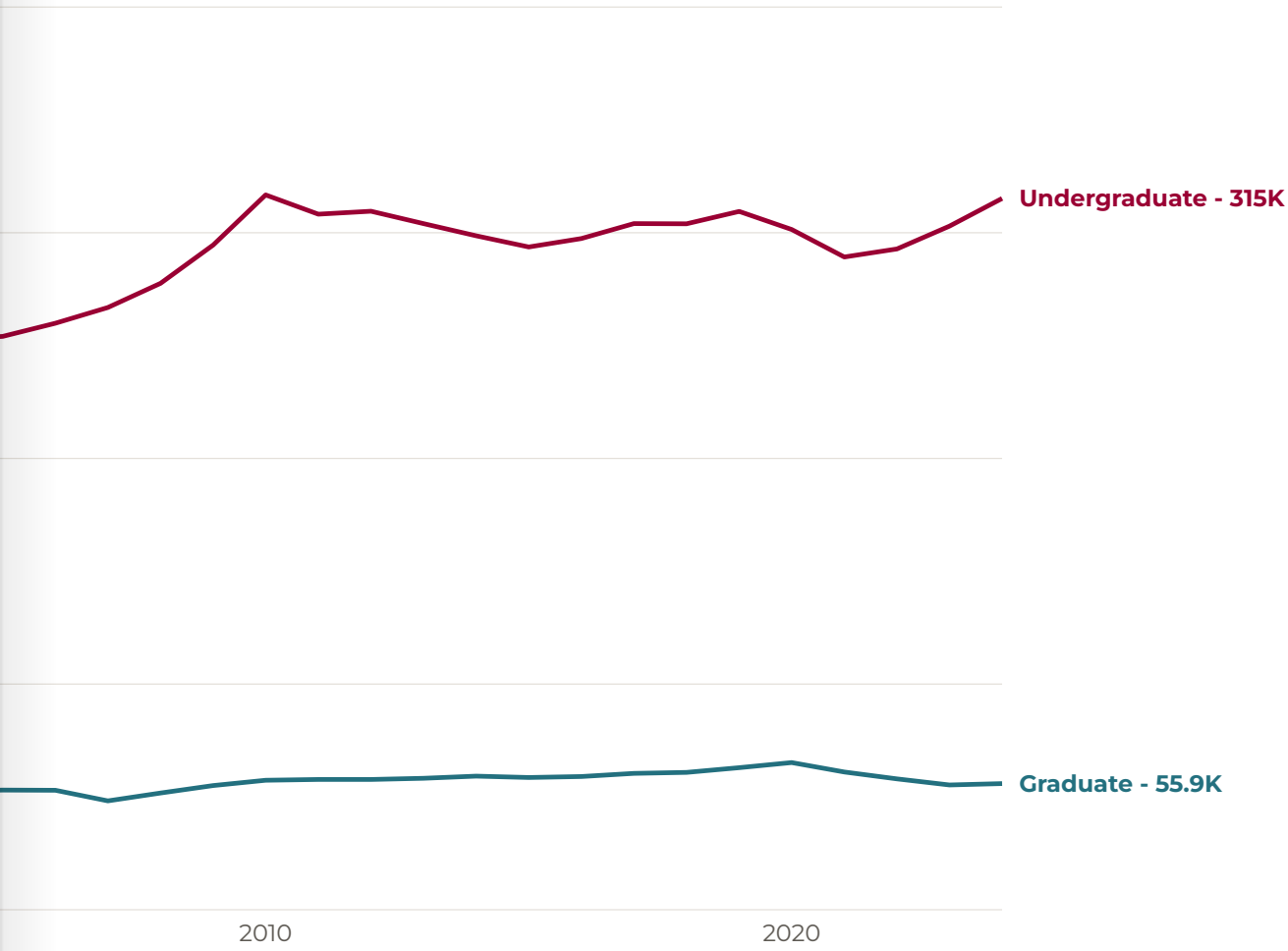
Figure 32 How Has Enrollment Changed?



Fall headcount enrollment. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

In fall 2024, Colorado enrolled 315K undergraduates and 55.9K graduate students, 371K in all (18th of 51).

Undergraduate enrollment is up 7% since 2015 and graduate enrollment down 5% since 2015. Graduate students are 15% of all students (U.S. 17%).



371K

Students enrolled, 2024

U.S. **19.7M** · **18th** of 51 · +5.3% since 2015

15%

Graduate share of students, 2024

U.S. **17%** · **30th** of 51 · −1.6 pp since 2015

44%

Students attending part-time, 2024

U.S. **39%** · **13th** of 51 · +1.6 pp since 2015

STUDENTS AND MONEY

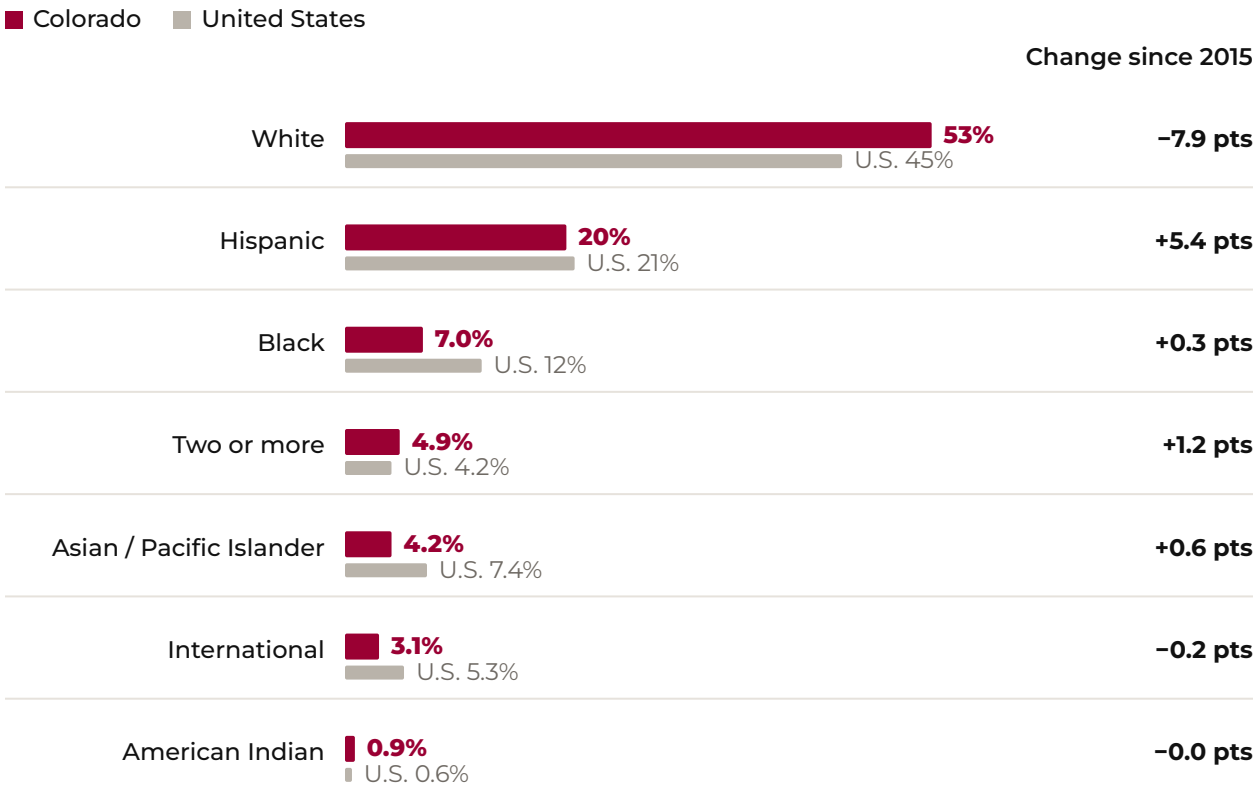
Who Enrolls in Colorado, and Where?

In fall 2024, White students were the largest group at Colorado's degree-granting institutions, **53%** of enrollment against 45% nationally, down 7.9 points since 2015.

Hispanic students were **20%** (U.S. 21%), up 5.4 points since 2015; Black students were **7.0%** (U.S. 12%), up 0.3 points since 2015.

Students of two or more races were **4.9%** (U.S. 4.2%), up 1.2 points since 2015, and Asian and Pacific Islander students were **4.2%** (U.S. 7.4%), up 0.6 points since 2015. "International" counts U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas, whatever their race.

Figure 33 Who Enrolls in Colorado?



Share of fall 2024 headcount enrollment by race and ethnicity; students of unknown race are left out of the chart. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

53%
White students
U.S. **45%** · −7.9 pp since 2015

20%
Hispanic students
U.S. **21%** · +5.4 pp since 2015

74%
At public 4-year institutions
+21.8 pp since 2015

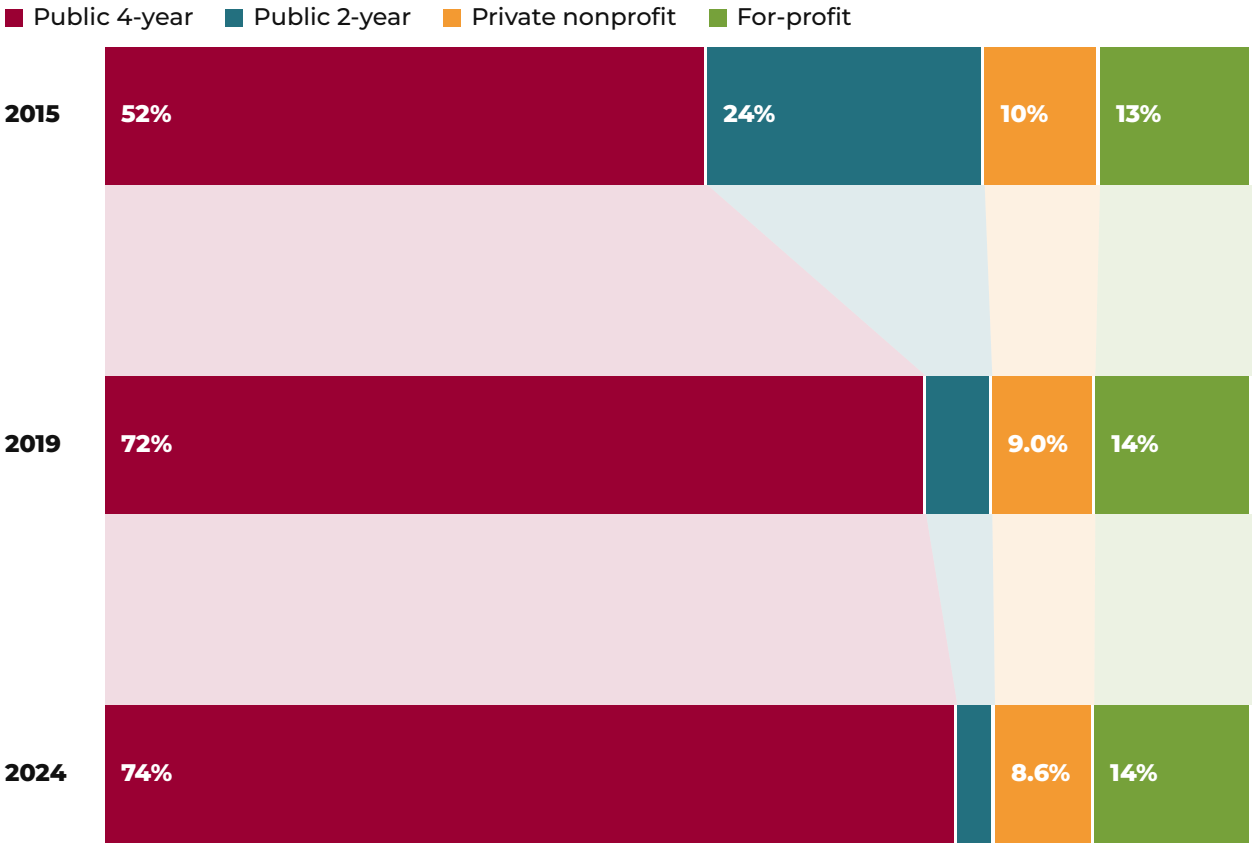
14%
At for-profit institutions
+0.5 pp since 2015

Public 4-year institutions enrolled **74%** of students, up 21.8 points from 52% in 2015 in fall 2024. For-profit institutions enrolled **14%** of students, up 0.5 points from 13% in 2015.

Private nonprofit institutions enrolled **8.6%** of students, down 1.4 points from 10% in 2015, and public 2-year institutions enrolled **3.3%** of students, down 20.9 points from 24% in 2015.

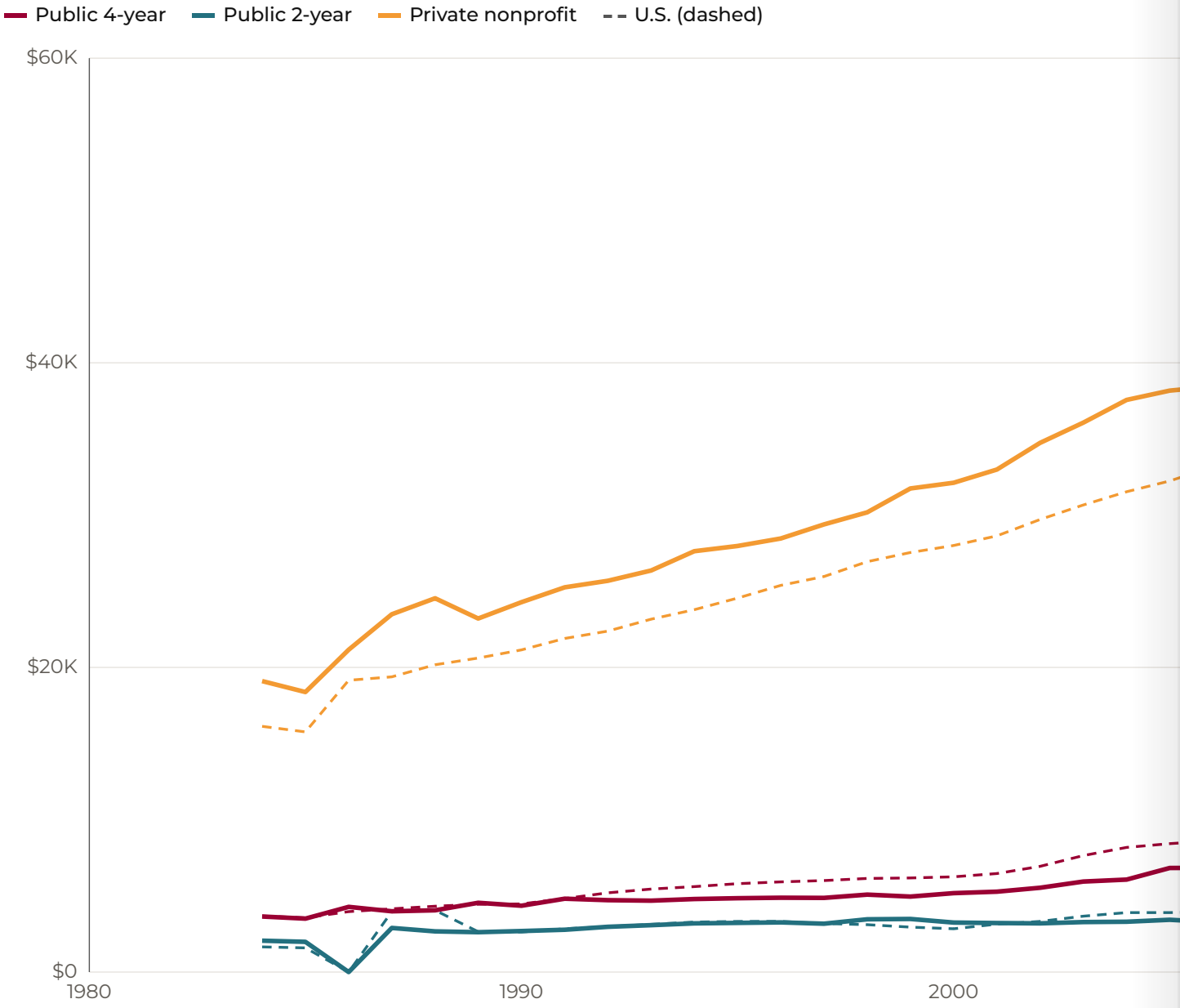
Public institutions together enrolled **78%** of students, against 73% nationally, 26th among the states.

Figure 34 Where Do Students Enroll?



Share of fall headcount enrollment by sector, 2015, 2019, 2024. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

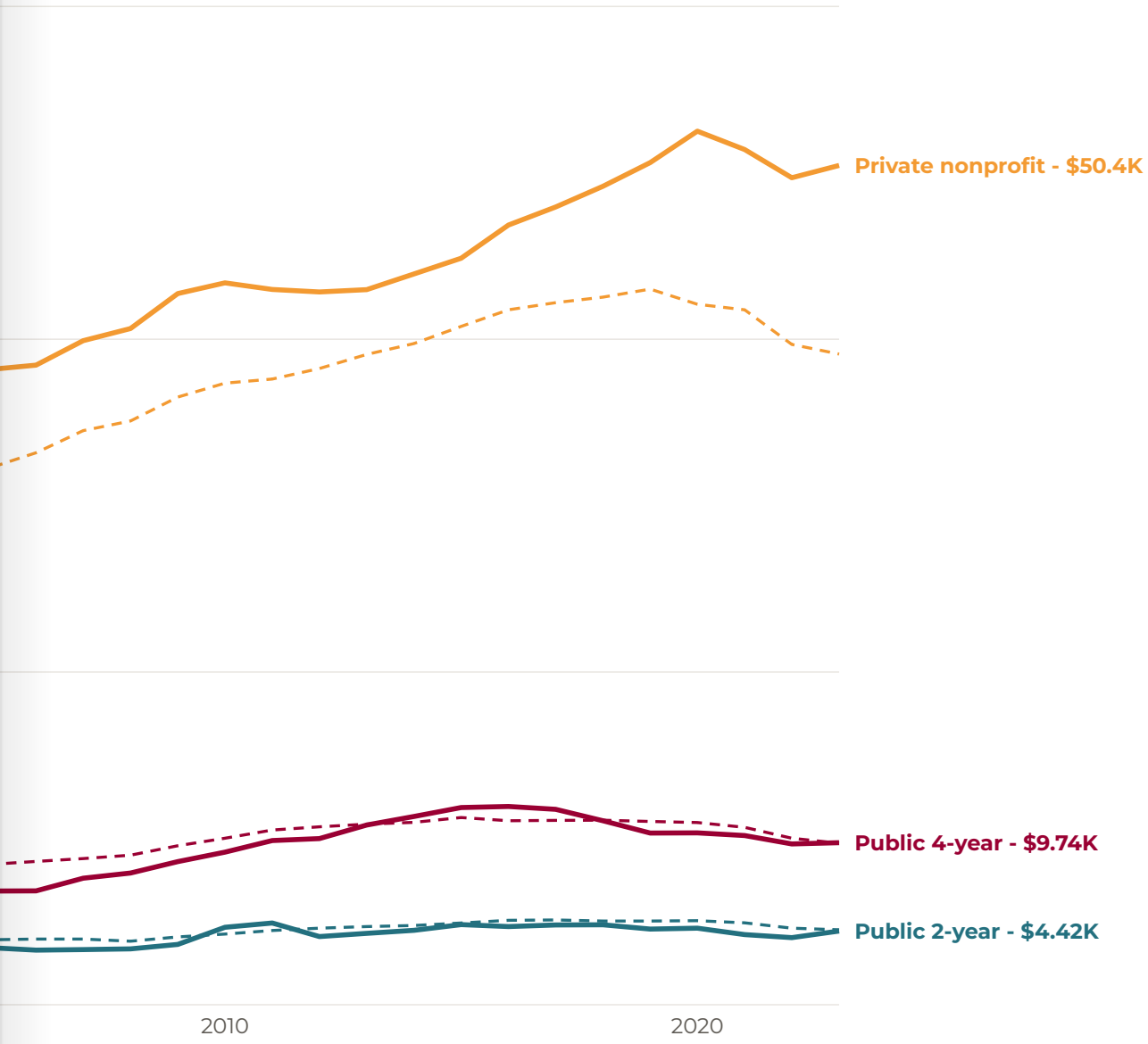
Figure 35 What Does In-State Tuition Cost?



Published in-state tuition and fees, 2024 dollars (CPI-U); state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

In-state tuition and fees at Colorado's public four-year institutions are $9.74K (2023, 2024 dollars), close to the U.S. figure ($9.71K); the state ranks 29th of 51.

State and local appropriations come to $1.51K per full-time-equivalent student at public institutions (51st of 51), and tuition makes up 91% of their core revenue (U.S. 43%).



$9.74K

In-state tuition, public 4-year, 2023

U.S. **$9.71K** · **29th** of 51 · −18% since 2015

$1.51K

Appropriations per student, 2024

U.S. **$11.4K** · **51st** of 51 · +67% since 2015

91%

Tuition share of public revenue, 2024

U.S. **43%** · **1st** of 51 · −3.3 pp since 2015

STUDENTS AND MONEY

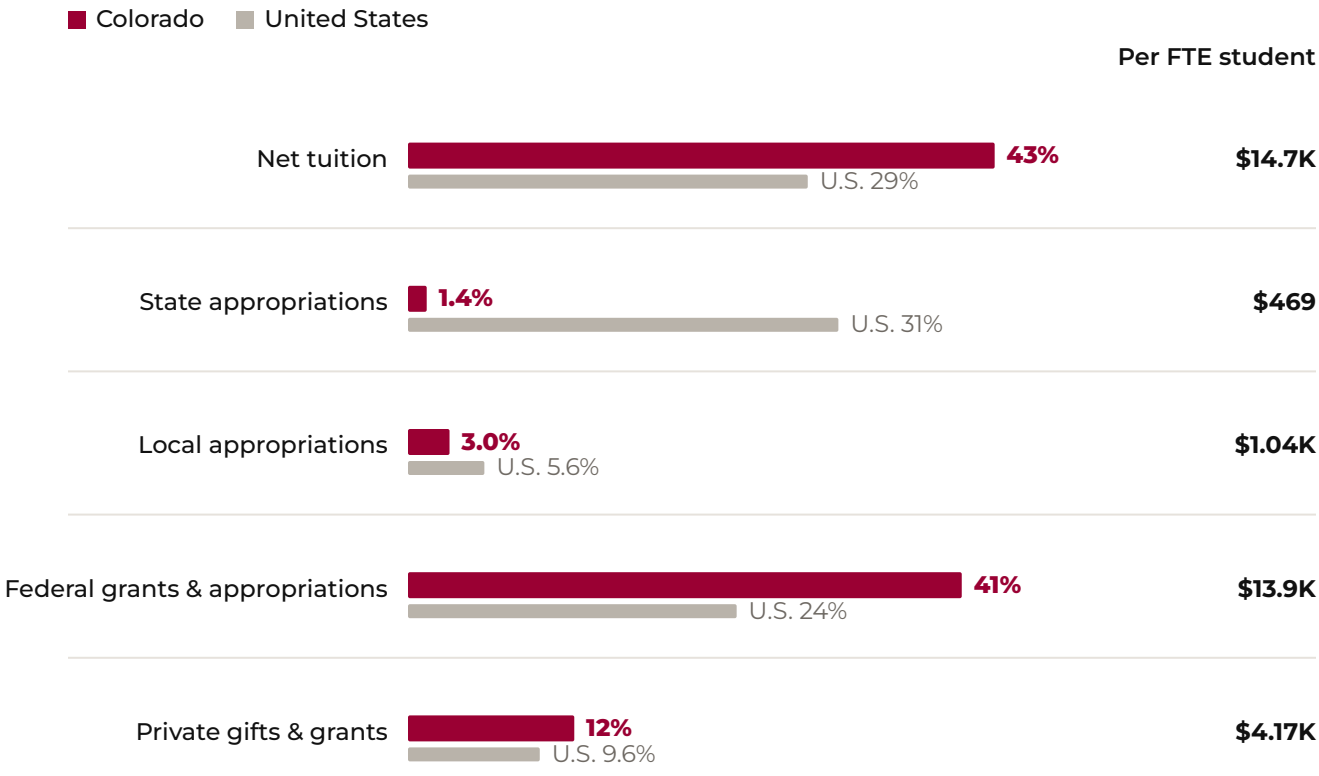
How Are Colorado's Public Institutions Funded, and What Do They Produce?

The bars give each source's share of the core revenue of Colorado's public institutions, with the nation for comparison, and at right the dollars per full-time-equivalent (FTE) student it provides. Values are in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Net tuition is tuition and fees after institutional discounts and allowances.

Net tuition per FTE student. $14.7K in FY2024 (U.S. $8.96K), up 1.8% from $14.4K in FY2023, and up 4.7% since FY2015 ($14K).

State appropriations per FTE student. $469 in FY2024 (U.S. $9.64K), up 24% from $378 in FY2023, and up 106% since FY2015 ($228).

Figure 36 How Are Public Institutions Funded?



Share of core revenue per FTE student by source, public institutions, FY2024; dollars per FTE at right, 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data from NCES, IPEDS Finance.

$9.74K
In-state tuition, public 4-year, 2023
U.S. **$9.71K** · **29th** of 51

$1.51K
Appropriations per student, 2024
U.S. **$11.4K** · **51st** of 51

91%
Tuition share of public revenue, 2024
U.S. **43%** · **1st** of 51

60%
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · **31st** of 51

The table brings together five measures of what public higher education costs and what it produces in Colorado: in-state tuition at public four-year institutions, state and local appropriations per full-time-equivalent student, tuition's share of public institutions' core revenue, the six-year bachelor's graduation rate, and the average full-time faculty salary.

In-state tuition, public 4-year. $9.74K in 2023 (U.S. $9.71K; 29th of 51 states), up 0.7% from $9.66K in 2022, and down 18% since 2015 ($11.9K).

Table 6 Money and Results

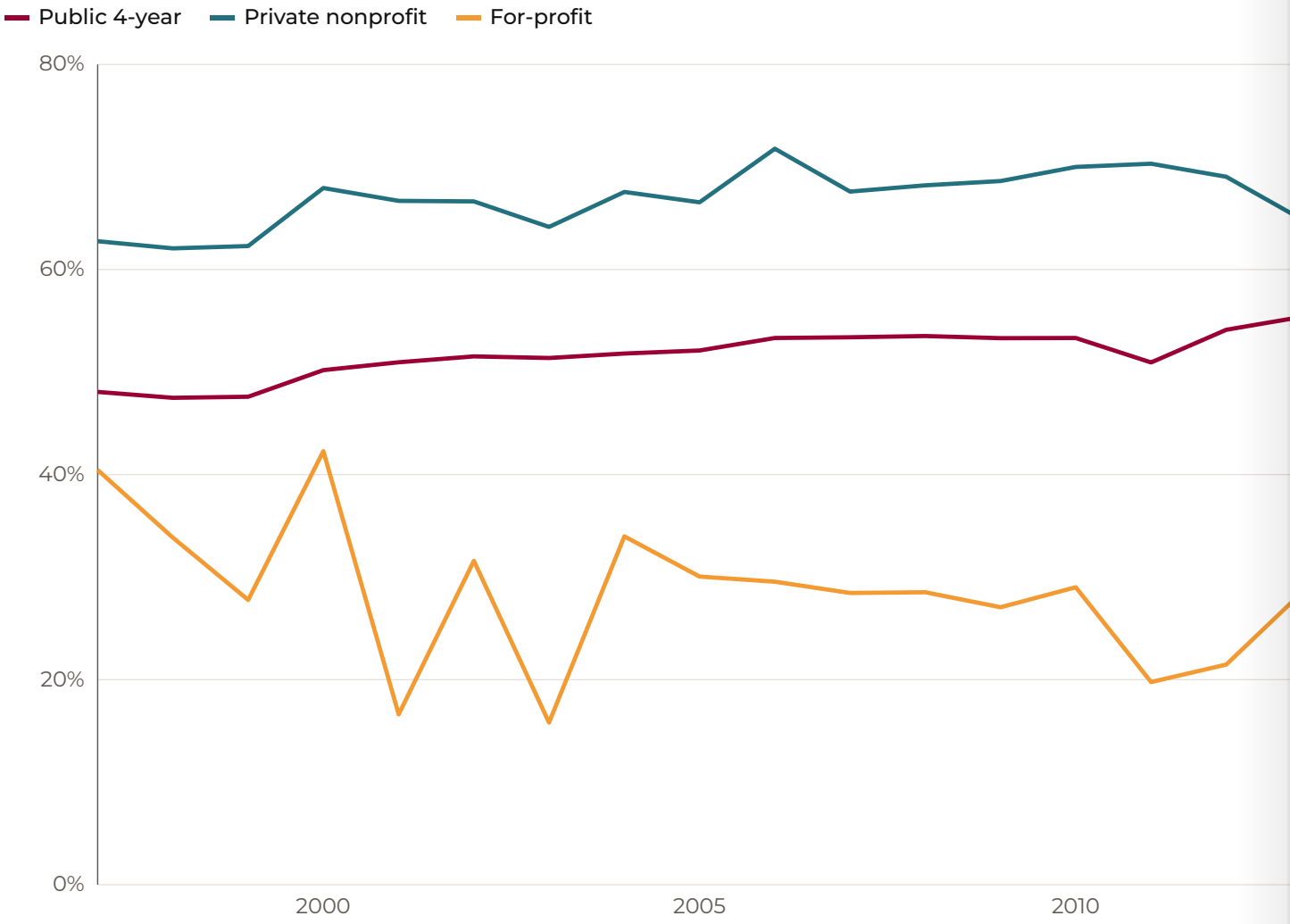
Measure	Year	Colorado	U.S.	Rank	Change since 2015
In-state tuition, public 4-year	2023	**$9.74K**	$9.71K	29th of 51	−18%
Appropriations per student	2024	**$1.51K**	$11.4K	51st of 51	+67%
Tuition share of public revenue	2024	**91%**	43%	1st of 51	−3.3 pp
Six-year graduation rate	2024	**60%**	65%	31st of 51	+4.0 pp
Average faculty salary	2024	**$98K**	$106K	21st of 51	−8.6%

Rank among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). Dollars in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 14

Student Outcomes

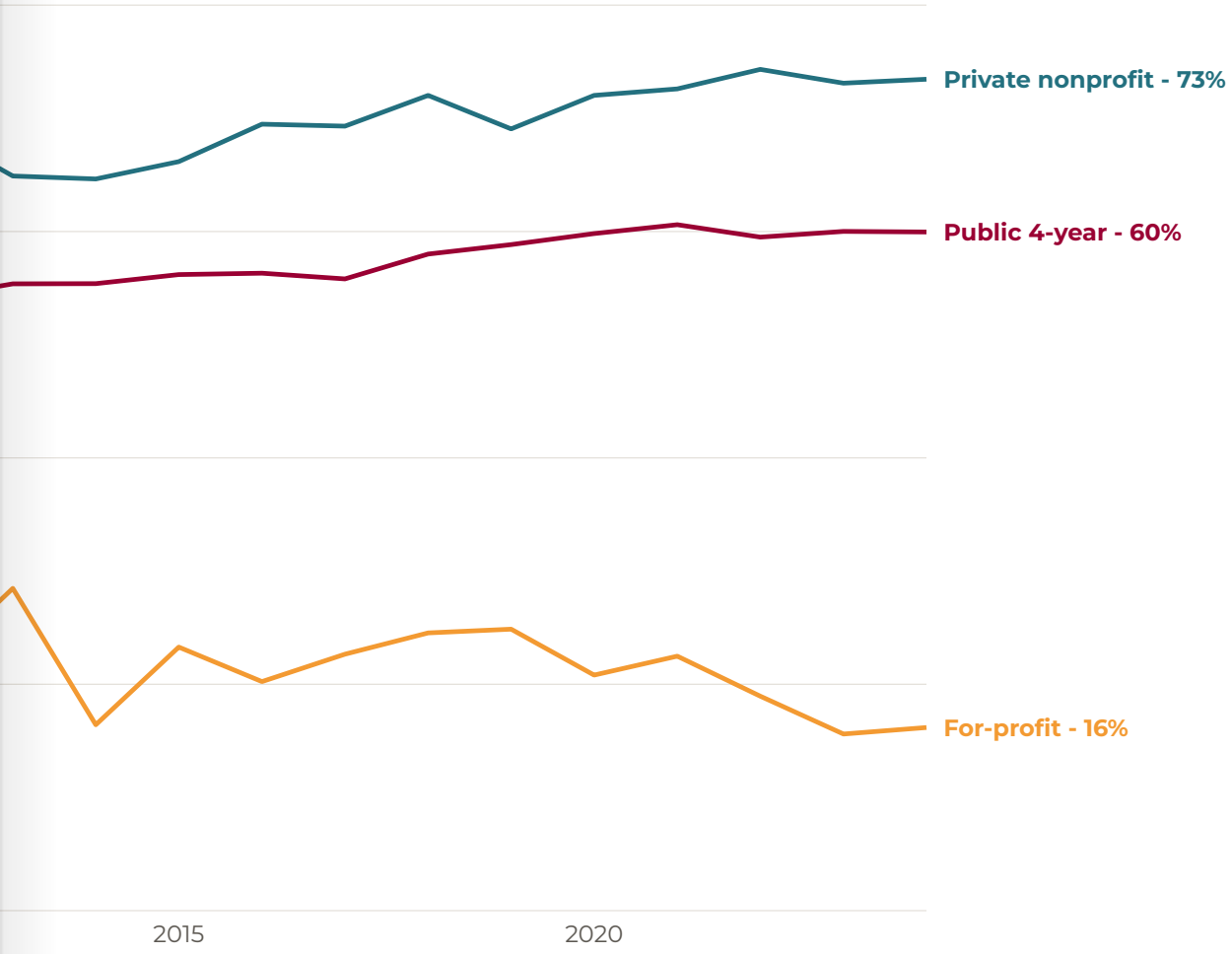
Figure 37 How Do Graduation Rates Differ by Sector?



Six-year bachelor's graduation rate by sector of institution. Data from NCES, IPEDS Graduation Rates.

60% of students who started a bachelor's degree at a four-year institution in Colorado graduated within six years (2024), 4.6 points below the U.S. (65%); the state ranks 31st of 51.

By sector: public 4-year 60%, private nonprofit 73%, for-profit 16%. At two-year institutions, 53% complete within 150% of normal time (U.S. 41%).



60%

Six-year graduation rate, 2024

U.S. **65%** · **31st** of 51 · +4.0 pp since 2015

53%

Two-year completion rate, 2024

U.S. **41%** · **8th** of 50 · +10.4 pp since 2015

11.7

Bachelor's per 100 undergraduates, 2025

U.S. **12.3** · **38th** of 51 · +0.2 since 2015

STUDENT OUTCOMES

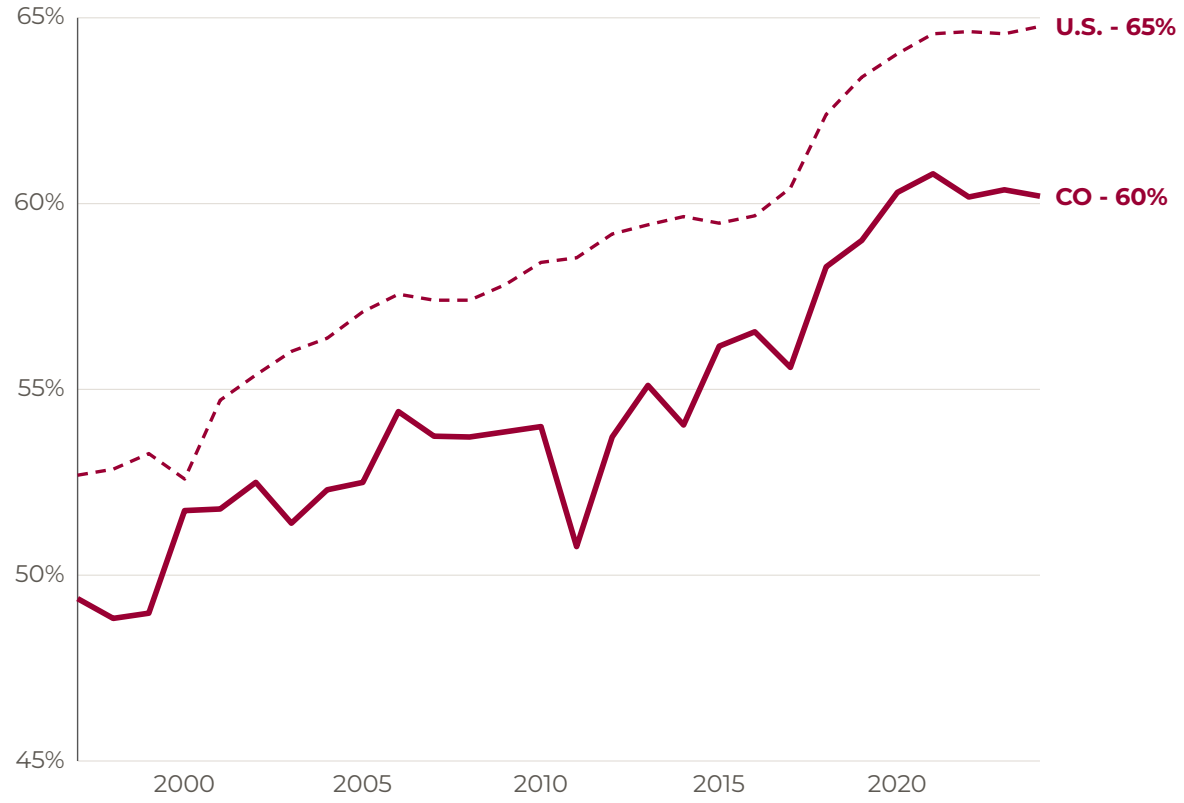
How Many of Colorado's Students Graduate?

The line follows the share of first-time, full-time bachelor's-degree students at Colorado's four-year institutions who graduated from the institution where they started within six years (150% of normal time). Each year is the cohort that entered six years earlier. The state is solid and the United States dashed.

Six-year graduation rate. 60% in 2024 (U.S. 65%), down 0.2 points from 60% in 2023, and up 4.0 points since 2015 (56%).

Public 4-year institutions. 60% in 2024, unchanged from 60% in 2023, and up 3.8 points since 2015 (56%).

Figure 38 Six-Year Bachelor's Graduation Rate



Four-year institutions; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Graduation Rates.

60%
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · **31st** of 51

53%
Two-year completion rate, 2024
U.S. **41%** · **8th** of 50

11.7
Bachelor's per 100 undergraduates, 2025
U.S. **12.3** · **38th** of 51

Each row is the six-year bachelor's graduation rate for one racial or ethnic group of students at Colorado's four-year institutions (filled dot), against the national rate for the same group (open dot). Groups with fewer than 100 students in the cohort are left out.

White. 65% in 2024 (U.S. 68%).

Hispanic. 50% in 2024 (U.S. 59%).

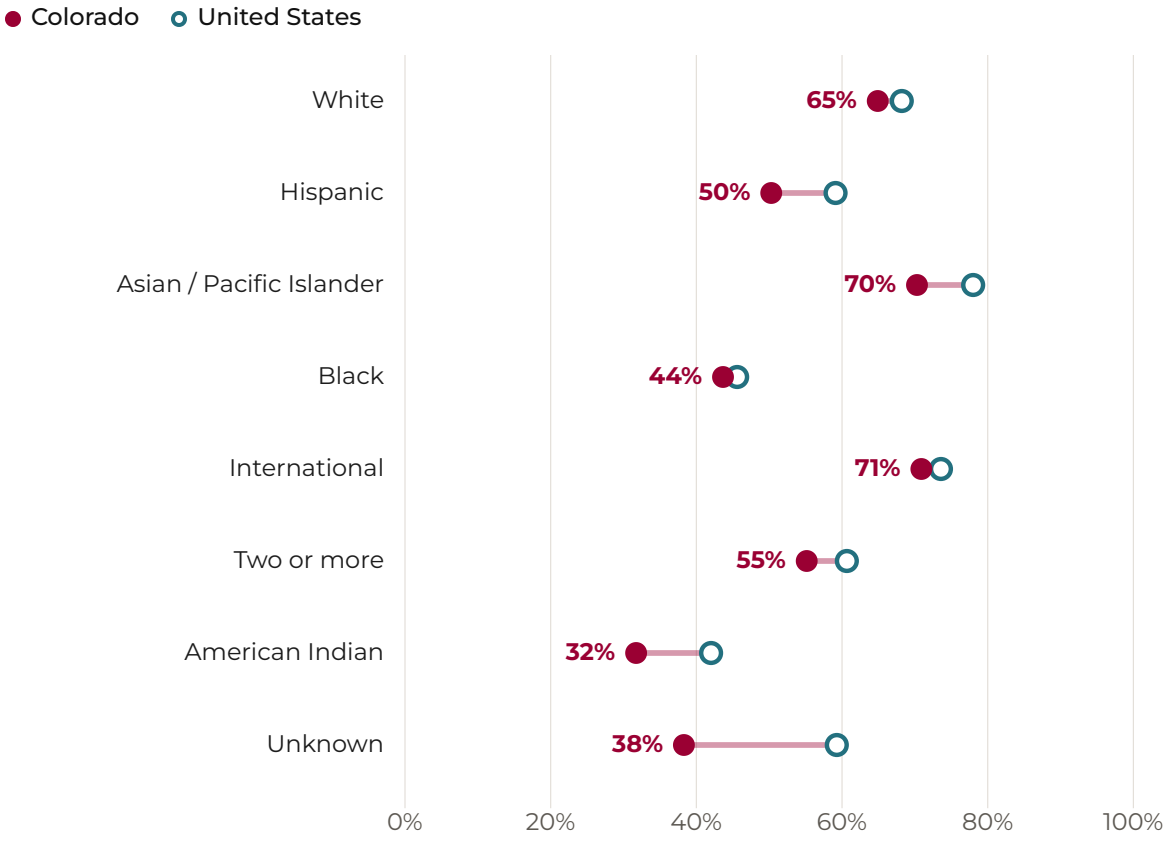
Asian / Pacific Islander. 70% in 2024 (U.S. 78%).

Black. 44% in 2024 (U.S. 46%).

International. 71% in 2024 (U.S. 74%).

Two or more. 55% in 2024 (U.S. 61%).

Figure 39 How Do Graduation Rates Differ by Race and Ethnicity?

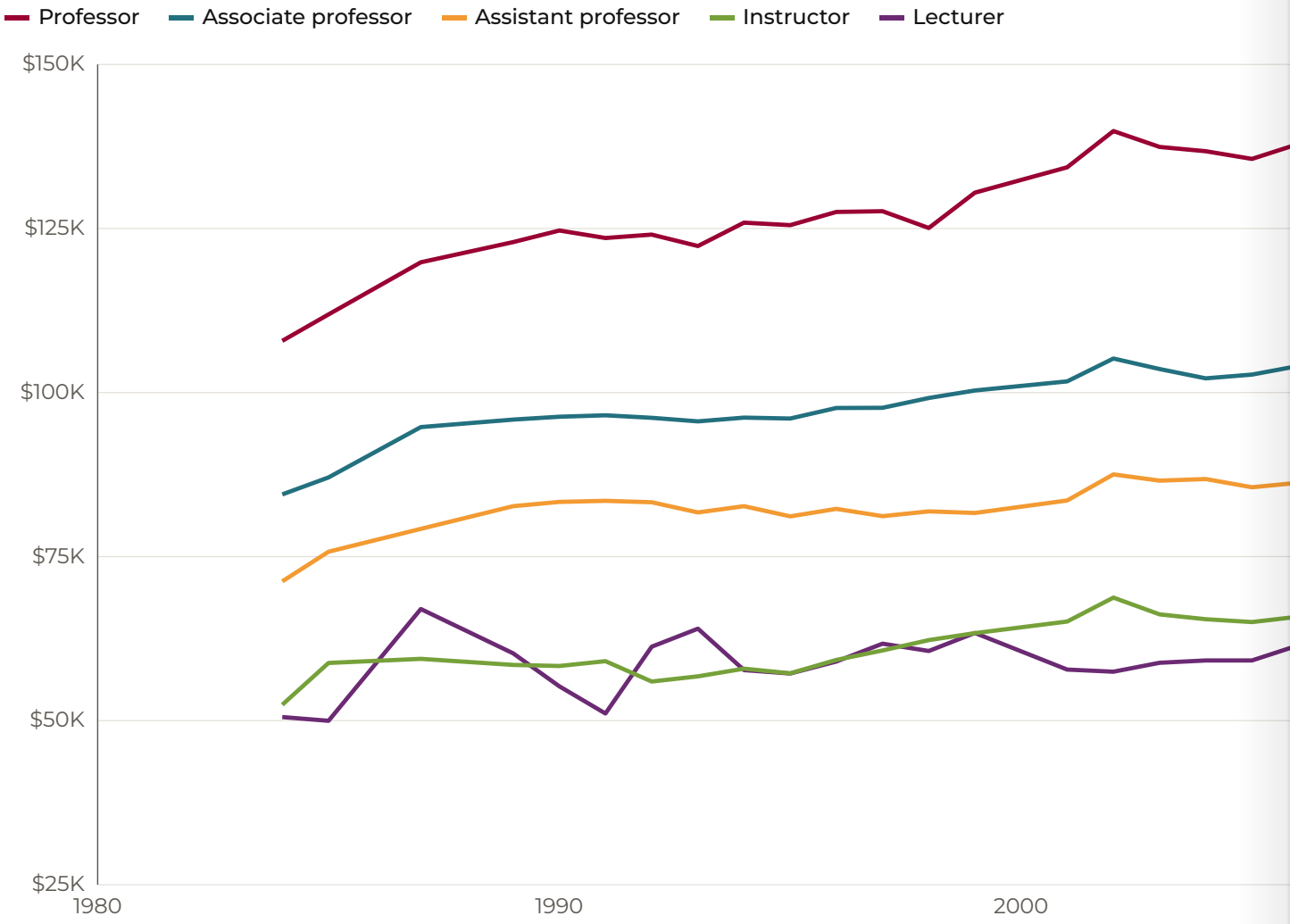


Six-year rate, 2024; groups with 100+ students. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 15

Faculty

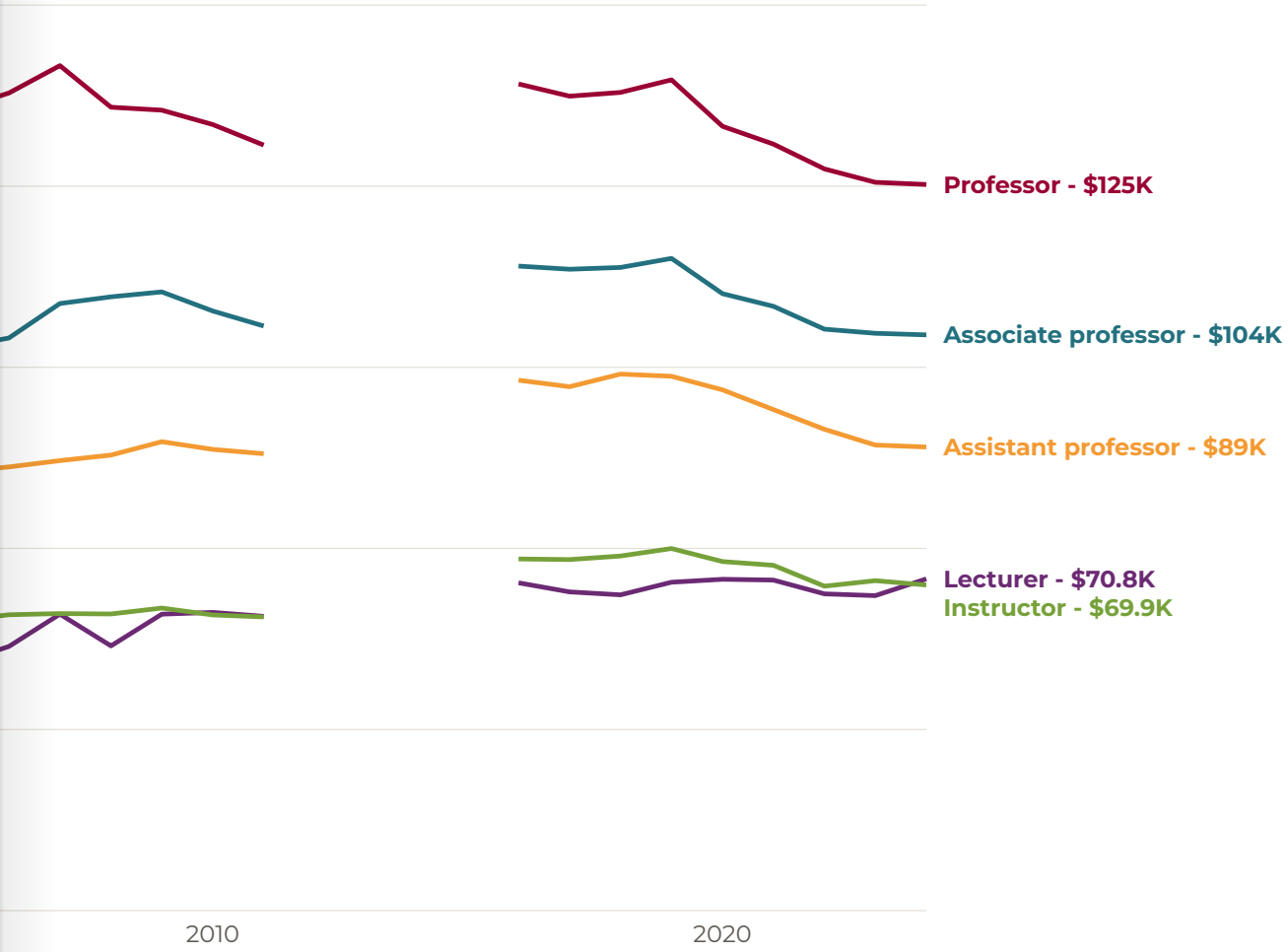
Figure 40 What Do Colorado's Faculty Earn, by Rank?



Average salary of full-time instructional faculty on 9/10-month contracts, by academic rank, 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data fro

Full-time instructional faculty on 9/10-month contracts at Colorado's institutions earned an average of $98K in 2024 (2024 dollars), 7% below the U.S. ($106K); the state ranks 21st of 51. By rank (2024): professors $125K, associate professors $104K, assistant professors $89K, instructors $69.9K, lecturers $70.8K.

Colorado's institutions had 15.6K full-time instructional staff in 2024, up 24% since 2015. Average salary across all ranks is down 9% since 2016.



m NCES, IPEDS Human Resources.

$98K

Average faculty salary, 2024

U.S. **$106K** · **21st** of 51 · −8.6% since 2016

FACULTY

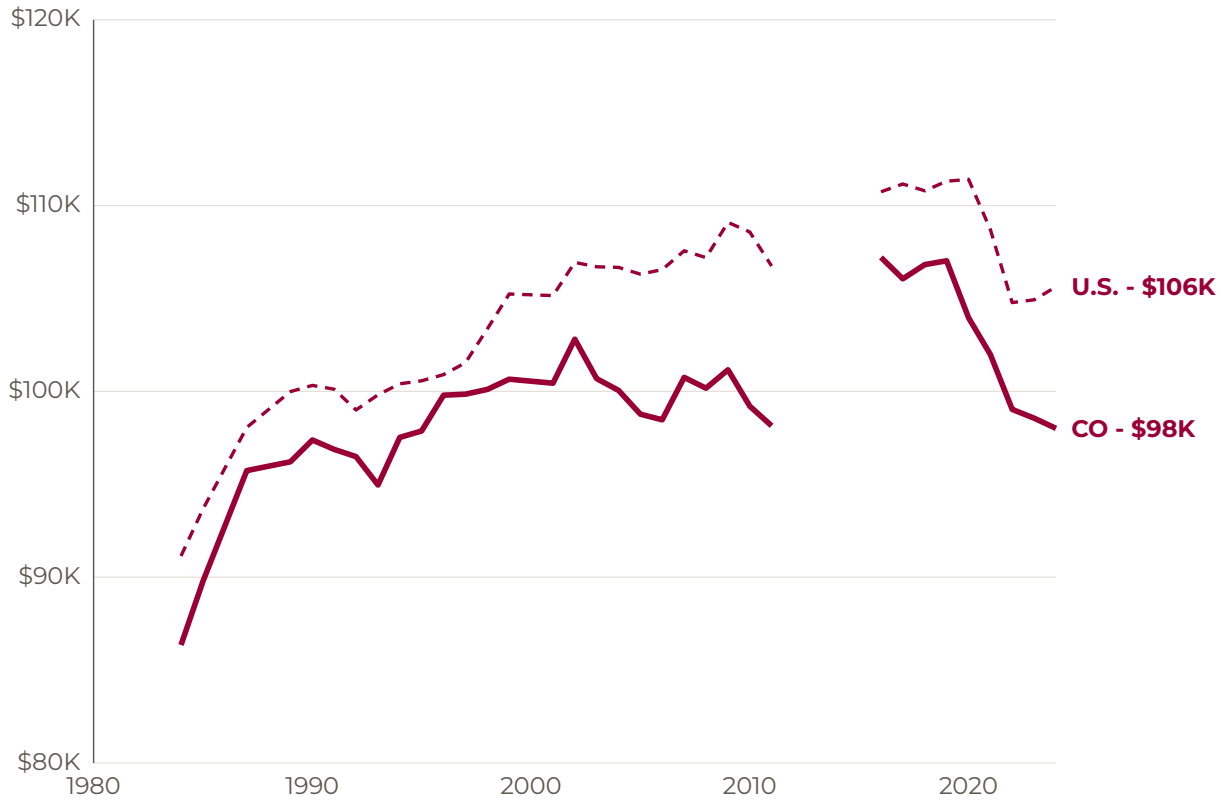
What Do Colorado's Faculty Earn, and How Many Hold Tenure?

The line follows the average salary of full-time instructional faculty on 9- or 10-month contracts at Colorado's degree-granting institutions, all ranks combined, in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). The state is solid and the United States dashed.

Average salary. $98K in 2024 (U.S. $106K), down 0.6% from $98.6K in 2023, and down 8.6% since 2016 ($107K).

State rank on average salary. $98K in 2024 (U.S. $106K; 21st of 51 states), down 0.6% from $98.6K in 2023, and down 8.6% since 2016 ($107K).

Figure 41 Average Faculty Salary



Full-time instructional faculty, 9/10-month, 2024 dollars. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

$98K
Average faculty salary, 2024
U.S. **$106K** · **21st** of 51

15.6K
Full-time instructional staff, 2024

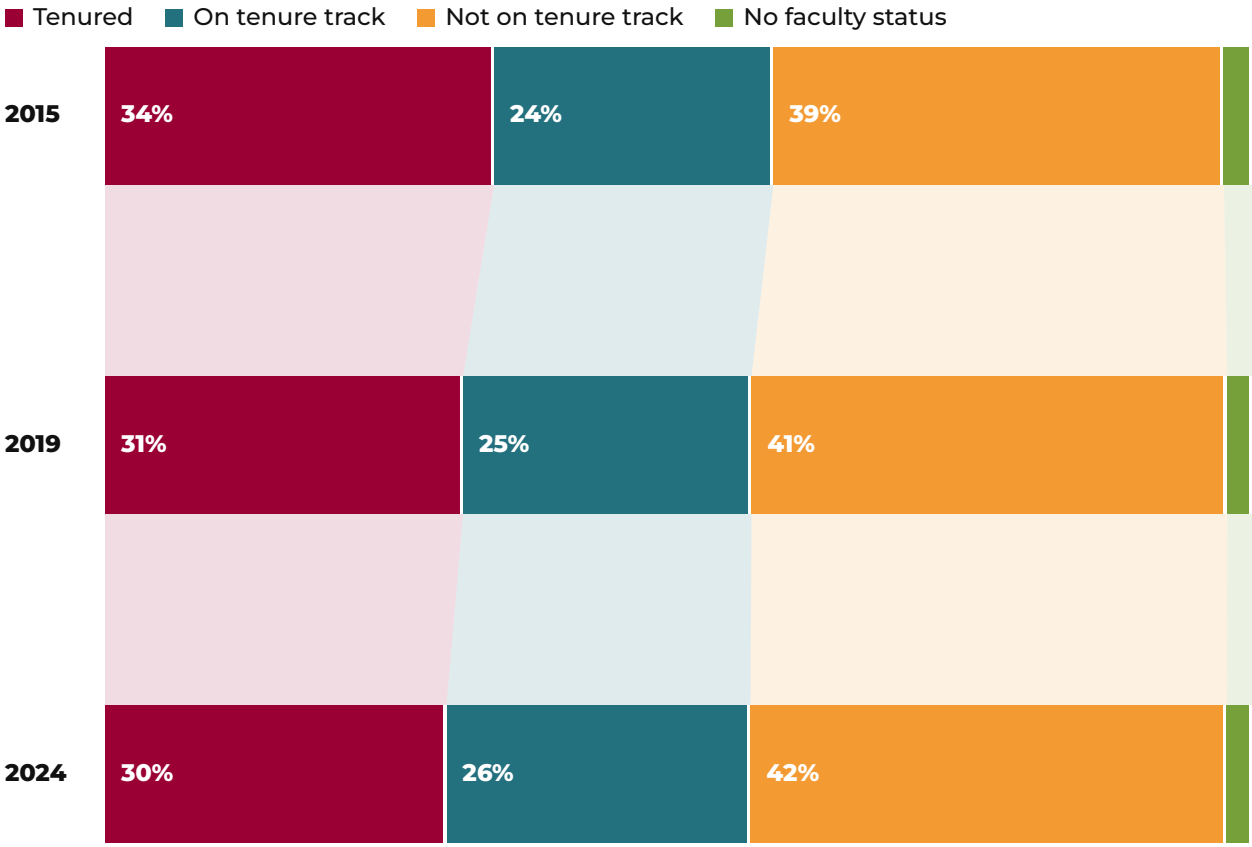
30%
Tenured, 2024

The bars divide Colorado's full-time instructional staff by tenure status in 2015, 2019 and 2024: tenured, on the tenure track, not on the tenure track (for example, lecturers on fixed-term contracts), and staff at institutions with no tenure system.

Tenured, share of full-time instructional staff. 30% in 2024, down 0.3 points from 30% in 2023, and down 4.1 points since 2015 (34%).

On tenure track, share of full-time instructional staff. 26% in 2024, up 0.3 points from 26% in 2023, and up 2.1 points since 2015 (24%).

Figure 42 Tenure Status

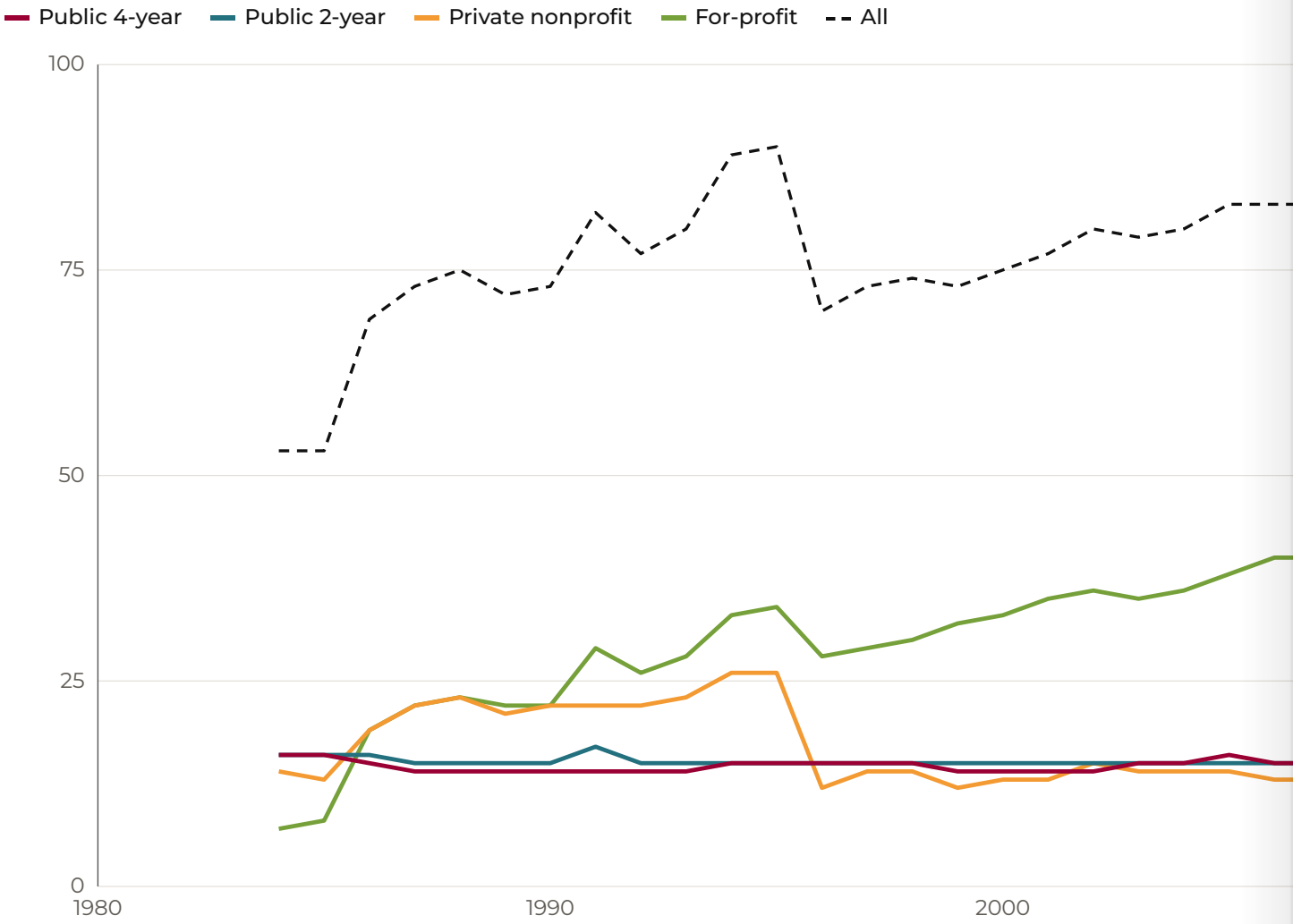


Full-time instructional staff by tenure status, 2015, 2019, 2024. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 16

Institutions

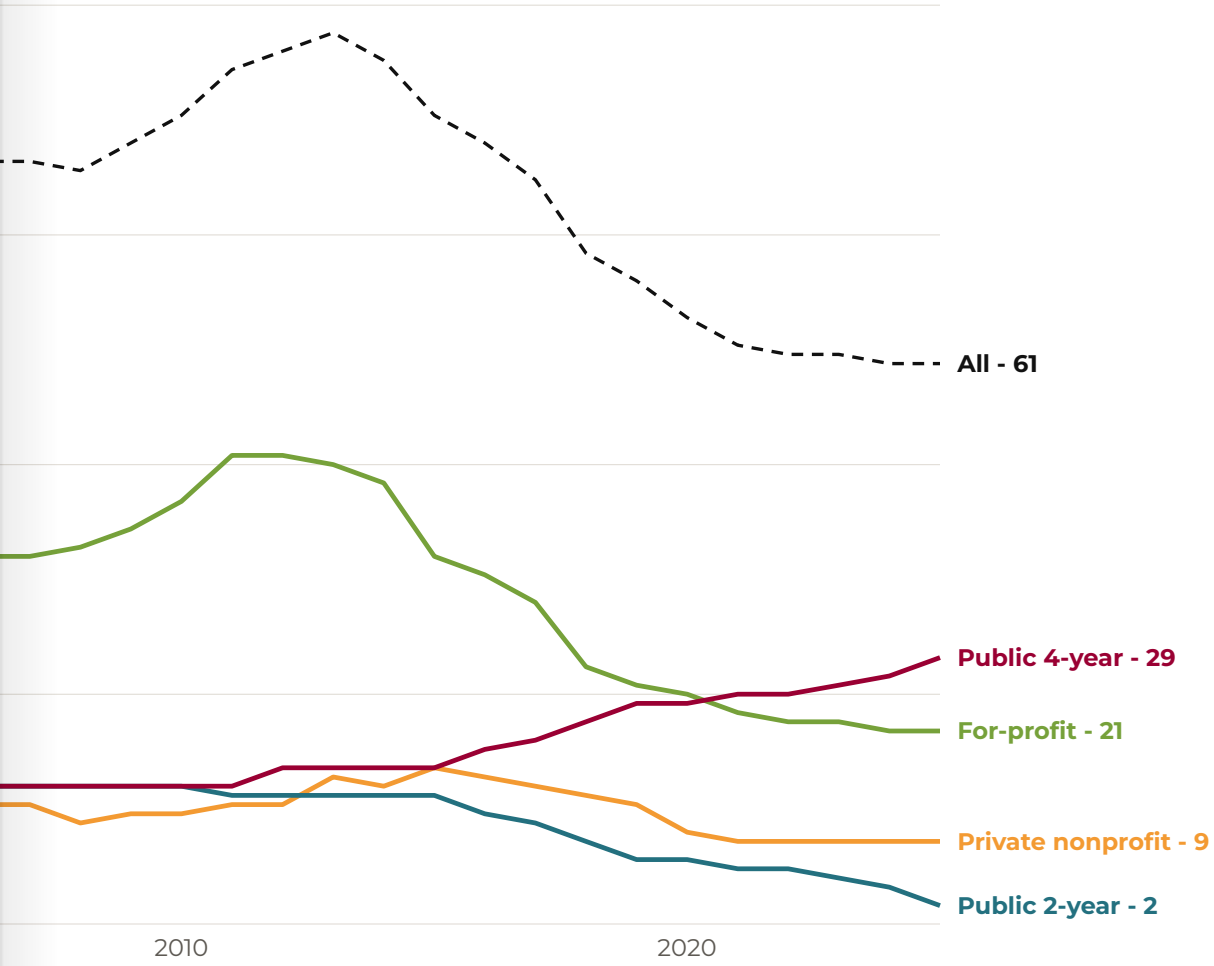
Figure 43 How Many Institutions Does Colorado Have?



Degree-granting institutions by sector. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Colorado has 61 degree-granting institutions:29 public 4-year, 2 public 2-year, 9 private nonprofit, 21 for-profit (2025).

The number of institutions is down 31% since 2015. 78% of students attend public institutions and 14% attend for-profit ones.



78%

Students at public institutions, 2024

U.S. **73%** · **26th** of 51 · +0.9 pp since 2015

14%

Students at for-profit institutions, 2024

U.S. **5.5%** · **5th** of 51 · +0.5 pp since 2015

26%

Students fully online, 2024

U.S. **27%** · **22nd** of 51 · +5.5 pp since 2015

INSTITUTIONS

Which Institutions Lead in Colorado?

Institutions in Colorado ranked by the STEM master's and research doctorates they awarded to international students in 2025. The share columns give international students' share of each institution's STEM degrees at that level.

Largest. University of Colorado Boulder (359 international STEM master's, 65 doctorates); Colorado State University-Fort Collins (283 international STEM master's, 46 doctorates); University of Colorado Denver/Anschutz Medical Campus (143 international STEM master's, 12 doctorates).

Table 7 Which Institutions Train the Most International STEM Graduates?

Institution	Intl STEM master's	Int. share	Intl STEM doctorates	Int. share
University of Colorado Boulder Boulder · Public 4-year	**359**	28%	65	19%
Colorado State University-Fort Collins Fort Collins · Public 4-year	**283**	35%	46	24%
University of Colorado Denver/Anschutz Medical Campus Denver · Public 4-year	**143**	36%	12	11%
Colorado School of Mines Golden · Public 4-year	**71**	13%	38	33%
University of Denver Denver · Private nonprofit	**87**	20%	6	32%
Colorado State University Global Denver · Public 4-year	**27**	16%	–	–
University of Colorado Colorado Springs Colorado Springs · Public 4-year	**19**	29%	1	11%
Western Colorado University Gunnison · Public 4-year	**2**	6.7%	–	–

Degrees awarded in 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

61
Degree-granting institutions, 2025

78%
Students at public institutions, 2024
U.S. **73%** · **26th** of 51

14%
Students at for-profit institutions, 2024
U.S. **5.5%** · **5th** of 51

26%
Students fully online, 2024
U.S. **27%** · **22nd** of 51

Colorado's largest degree-granting institutions by fall 2024 headcount enrollment, with the international share of graduate students, STEM bachelor's degrees awarded in 2025, the six-year graduation rate and the admission rate (a dash where the institution admits all applicants or does not report one).

Largest. University of Colorado Boulder (38.8K students); Colorado State University-Fort Collins (34.1K students); Colorado Technical University-Colorado Springs (31.8K students).

Degree-granting institutions. 61 in 2025; 58 of them reported the enrollment and degree data in these tables.

Table 8 What Are Colorado's Largest Institutions?

Institution	Enrollment	Int. share, grad	STEM bachelor's	Six-year grad rate	Admit rate
University of Colorado Boulder	**38.8K**	25%	3.03K	74%	78%
Colorado State University-Fort Collins	**34.1K**	16%	2.01K	67%	89%
Colorado Technical University-Colorado Springs	**31.8K**	–	640	14%	–
University of Colorado Denver/Anschutz Medical Campus	**23.1K**	6.9%	689	46%	75%
Front Range Community College	**22K**	–	–	–	–
Metropolitan State University of Denver	**18.5K**	3.6%	465	31%	99%
Arapahoe Community College	**15K**	–	–	–	–
University of Denver	**12.8K**	8.4%	346	76%	78%
Pikes Peak State College	**12.6K**	–	–	–	–
University of Colorado Colorado Springs	**11.4K**	5.5%	470	47%	97%

Fall 2024 enrollment; degrees 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

NOTES

About These Data

International students

U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas, as IPEDS defines them. IPEDS does not record country of citizenship. Permanent residents count with U.S. citizens.

STEM

CIP families 03, 04, 11, 14, 15, 26, 27 and 40. Doctorates are research and scholarship doctorates; professional doctorates appear only in the degree-count figure. Degrees are first majors only.

Universe

Degree-granting institutions located in the state; Title IV participants from 1996. Geography is the institution's location, not the student's home. Enrollment is fall headcount.

Migration

First-time degree-seeking undergraduates by home state, reported in even years before 2001 and every year since; odd years with incomplete reporting are omitted. Net migration is students arriving from other states minus residents leaving, per 100 resident first-time students.

Money

All dollar values are in 2024 dollars using the CPI-U. Appropriations and revenue are per full-time-equivalent student at public institutions.

Race and ethnicity

IPEDS did not collect race and ethnicity in every year before 2010, and categories changed in 2008–2010; “Two or more” exists only from then.

Countries of citizenship

From DHS SEVIS by the Numbers: active F-1 and M-1 student records in the month named, at every level from primary school to doctorate, by the state of the school. IPEDS records only whether a student is a U.S. nonresident, not where they come from. SEVIS counts are monthly snapshots and are not directly comparable with IPEDS fall enrollment or degree counts.

Peers

Comparison states are the four closest in total fall enrollment.

Source

National Center for Education Statistics, Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS): Institutional Characteristics, Fall Enrollment, Completions, Graduation Rates, Finance, Human Resources and Admissions components, 1980–2025, harmonized into a state panel. Department of Homeland Security, SEVIS by the Numbers data mapping tool, 2014–2026. Generated November 2026.

This page intentionally left blank.

Colorado – By the Numbers

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
K-12 PREPARATION							
Grade 8 mathematics, average score	286	**278**[2024]	−7.4 ▼	272	−9.0 ▼	#14	[5]
Grade 8 mathematics: at or above Proficient	37%	**32%**[2024]	−4.5 pp ▼	27%	−5.3 pp ▼	#8	[5]
Grade 4 mathematics, average score	242	**239**[2024]	−2.4 ▼	237	−2.5 ▼	#17	[5]
Grade 4 mathematics: at or above Proficient	43%	**42%**[2024]	−1.0 pp ▼	39%	0.0 pp	#17	[5]
Grade 8 reading, average score	268	**265**[2024]	−3.5 ▼	257	−7.3 ▼	#3	[5]
Grade 8 reading: at or above Proficient	38%	**35%**[2024]	−3.4 pp ▼	29%	−4.0 pp ▼	#4	[5]
Grade 4 reading, average score	224	**221**[2024]	−3.1 ▼	214	−7.1 ▼	#5	[5]
Grade 8 science, average score, 2009 framework	–	**161**[2011]	–	151	–	#9	[5]
Current spending per public-school pupil	$12.2K	**$14.4K**[2021]	+18% ▲	$16.8K	+12% ▲	#32	[3]
Public high school 4-year graduation rate, ACGR	77%	**82%**[2022]	+5.0 pp ▲	87%	+4.0 pp ▲	#40	[3]
Public high school graduates	51.8K	**61.6K**[2024]	+19% ▲	3.49M	+8.8% ▲	#21	[3]
Average public-school teacher salary	$65.2K	**$64.2K**[2022]	−1.5% ▼	$72.9K	−3.0% ▼	#29	[3]
Pupils per teacher, public schools	17.4	**16.3**[2022]	−1.1 ▼	15.4	−0.6 ▼	#15	[3]
Public elementary and secondary enrollment	899K	**865K**[2024]	−3.8% ▼	49.4M	−2.1% ▼	#21	[3]
Public-school students eligible for free or reduced-price lunch	42%	**42%**[2023]	+0.8 pp ▲	53%	+1.5 pp ▲	#33	[3]
English learners as a share of public-school students	12%	**10%**[2022]	−1.4 pp ▼	11%	+1.0 pp ▲	#13	[3]
Charter-school share of public-school enrollment	11%	**15%**[2023]	+3.7 pp ▲	7.6%	+2.2 pp ▲	#3	[3]
High schools offering calculus	53%[2016]	**49%**[2024]	−4.0 pp ▼	51%	−5.8 pp ▼	#29	[14]
High schools offering physics	74%[2016]	**75%**[2024]	+1.1 pp ▲	64%	−2.4 pp ▼	#15	[14]
High schools offering chemistry	77%[2016]	**80%**[2024]	+2.7 pp ▲	81%	+0.7 pp ▲	#30	[14]
High schools offering Algebra II	86%[2016]	**89%**[2024]	+3.2 pp ▲	87%	+1.3 pp ▲	#26	[14]
High schools offering computer science	67%[2021]	**68%**[2024]	+1.6 pp ▲	55%	+2.0 pp ▲	#17	[14]
High schools offering any AP course	53%[2016]	**56%**[2024]	+3.3 pp ▲	56%	0.0 pp	#28	[14]
High schools offering AP computer science	22%[2021]	**23%**[2024]	+0.5 pp ▲	25%	+2.6 pp ▲	#28	[14]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

COLORADO – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
K-12 PREPARATION (CONTINUED)							
High schools offering dual enrollment	74%[2016]	**70%[2024]**	−3.5 pp ▼	71%	+11.1 pp ▲	#36	[14]
AP course enrollments per 100 high-school students	18.2[2016]	**18.2[2024]**	0.0	18.4	+1.0 ▲	#19	[14]
Calculus enrollments per 100 high-school students	4.4[2016]	**3.1[2024]**	−1.3 ▼	3.3	−1.0 ▼	#24	[14]
Physics enrollments per 100 high-school students	12.4[2016]	**10.6[2024]**	−1.7 ▼	9.4	−0.4 ▼	#18	[14]
SAT or ACT takers per 100 high-school students	19.8[2016]	**19.9[2024]**	+0.1 ▲	18.1	−2.5 ▼	#24	[14]
Students in gifted and talented programs per 100 students	7.9[2016]	**8.1[2024]**	+0.2 ▲	7.0	+0.4 ▲	#16	[14]
ENROLLMENT AND INSTITUTIONS							
Pell Grant share of undergraduates	32%	**32%[2025]**	+0.5 pp ▲	36%	−0.8 pp ▼	#34	[15]
Fall enrollment	352K	**371K[2024]**	+5.3% ▲	19.7M	−1.7% ▼	#18	[4]
Share of enrollment at public institutions	77%	**78%[2024]**	+0.9 pp ▲	73%	0.0 pp	#26	[4]
Share of enrollment at for-profit institutions	13%	**14%[2024]**	+0.5 pp ▲	5.5%	−1.2 pp ▼	#5	[4]
Share of students enrolled part-time	42%	**44%[2024]**	+1.6 pp ▲	39%	+0.7 pp ▲	#13	[4]
Share of students who are graduate students	17%	**15%[2024]**	−1.6 pp ▼	17%	+2.0 pp ▲	#30	[4]
Share of students enrolled exclusively online	21%	**26%[2024]**	+5.5 pp ▲	27%	+12.1 pp ▲	#22	[4]
DEGREES AND FIELDS OF STUDY							
Research doctorates awarded	1.01K	**1.24K[2025]**	+24% ▲	59K	+7.3% ▲	#17	[7]
Science & engineering research doctorates, excluding health	762	**976[2025]**	+28% ▲	44.4K	+14% ▲	#15	[7]
Share of U.S. research doctorates	1.8%	**2.1%[2025]**	+0.3 pp ▲	–	–	#17	[7]
Engineering research doctorates	225	**275[2025]**	+22% ▲	10.9K	+9.9% ▲	#15	[7]
Mathematics & computer science research doctorates	64	**114[2025]**	+78% ▲	5.07K	+33% ▲	#15	[7]
STEM master's degrees per research doctorate	4.2	**5.3[2025]**	+1.1 ▲	6.4	+2.1 ▲	#29	[4]
STEM share of bachelor's	23%	**30%[2025]**	+7.4 pp ▲	24%	+5.3 pp ▲	#6	[4]
Share of bachelor's in computer & information sciences	3.8%	**8.3%[2025]**	+4.5 pp ▲	6.9%	+3.7 pp ▲	#8	[4]
Share of bachelor's in engineering & eng. technology	7.6%	**9.4%[2025]**	+1.9 pp ▲	6.8%	+0.7 pp ▲	#5	[4]
Share of bachelor's in mathematics & statistics	1.2%	**0.9%[2025]**	−0.3 pp ▼	1.2%	0.0 pp	#27	[4]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

COLORADO – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
DEGREES AND FIELDS OF STUDY (CONTINUED)							
Share of bachelor's in biological & biomedical sciences	6.7%	**7.9%**[2025]	+1.1 pp ▲	6.6%	+0.8 pp ▲	#9	[4]
Share of bachelor's in physical sciences	1.7%	**1.4%**[2025]	−0.3 pp ▼	1.3%	−0.3 pp ▼	#13	[4]
Share of bachelor's in health professions	11%	**8.1%**[2025]	−2.5 pp ▼	12%	+1.1 pp ▲	#49	[4]
Share of bachelor's in business	21%	**24%**[2025]	+2.7 pp ▲	19%	−0.1 pp ▼	#7	[4]
STEM share of master's	19%	**25%**[2025]	+6.6 pp ▲	23%	+6.7 pp ▲	#14	[4]
Share of master's in computer & information sciences	5.6%	**8.5%**[2025]	+2.9 pp ▲	10%	+6.3 pp ▲	#22	[4]
Share of master's in engineering & eng. technology	7.2%	**8.9%**[2025]	+1.7 pp ▲	6.7%	−0.2 pp ▼	#6	[4]
Share of master's in mathematics & statistics	0.6%	**0.9%**[2025]	+0.2 pp ▲	1.3%	+0.3 pp ▲	#30	[4]
Share of master's in biological & biomedical sciences	1.8%	**2.7%**[2025]	+0.9 pp ▲	2.5%	+0.6 pp ▲	#20	[4]
Share of master's in physical sciences	1.3%	**1.2%**[2025]	−0.1 pp ▼	0.8%	−0.1 pp ▼	#18	[4]
Share of master's in health professions	10%	**12%**[2025]	+1.9 pp ▲	15%	+1.7 pp ▲	#39	[4]
Share of master's in business	33%	**26%**[2025]	−6.3 pp ▼	21%	−3.2 pp ▼	#6	[4]
STEM share of research doctorates	49%	**56%**[2025]	+7.1 pp ▲	39%	−2.2 pp ▼	#5	[4]
Share of research doctorates in computer & information sciences	5.7%	**4.5%**[2025]	−1.2 pp ▼	4.2%	+1.4 pp ▲	#15	[4]
Share of research doctorates in engineering & eng. technology	19%	**21%**[2025]	+2.7 pp ▲	14%	−1.0 pp ▼	#3	[4]
Share of research doctorates in mathematics & statistics	2.5%	**4.1%**[2025]	+1.6 pp ▲	2.4%	−0.2 pp ▼	#1	[4]
Share of research doctorates in biological & biomedical sciences	9.8%	**12%**[2025]	+2.4 pp ▲	10%	−1.1 pp ▼	#22	[4]
Share of research doctorates in physical sciences	12%	**13%**[2025]	+1.4 pp ▲	7.1%	−1.1 pp ▼	#5	[4]
Share of research doctorates in health professions	5.8%	**4.2%**[2025]	−1.5 pp ▼	12%	+3.5 pp ▲	#43	[4]
Share of research doctorates in business	8.6%	**1.5%**[2025]	−7.1 pp ▼	5.6%	+1.3 pp ▲	#43	[4]
Bachelor's degrees per 100 undergraduates	11.5	**11.7**[2025]	+0.2 ▲	12.3	+1.4 ▲	#38	[4]
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS							
First-time students from outside the U.S.	2.0%[2016]	**0.9%**[2024]	−1.2 pp ▼	3.1%	+0.1 pp ▲	#49	[4]
STEM master's degrees earned by international students	566	**995**[2025]	+76% ▲	117K	2.18× ▲	#26	[4]
Share of all U.S. international STEM master's degrees	1.1%	**0.9%**[2025]	−0.2 pp ▼	–	–	#26	[4]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

COLORADO – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS (CONTINUED)							
International share of undergraduate enrollment	2.5%	**2.0%**[2024]	−0.5 pp ▼	3.0%	−0.3 pp ▼	#36	[4]
International share of graduate enrollment	7.2%	**9.3%**[2024]	+2.1 pp ▲	17%	+2.8 pp ▲	#37	[4]
International share of all bachelor's	2.7%	**2.5%**[2025]	−0.2 pp ▼	4.1%	+0.1 pp ▲	#39	[4]
International share of STEM bachelor's	3.3%	**3.2%**[2025]	−0.1 pp ▼	6.6%	+0.8 pp ▲	#42	[4]
International share of all master's	8.4%	**11%**[2025]	+2.7 pp ▲	22%	+6.2 pp ▲	#38	[4]
International share of STEM master's	20%	**24%**[2025]	+3.3 pp ▲	52%	+9.1 pp ▲	#43	[4]
International share of computer & information sciences master's	18%	**35%**[2025]	+16.5 pp ▲	65%	+10.1 pp ▲	#40	[4]
International share of engineering & eng. technology master's	31%	**23%**[2025]	−8.0 pp ▼	50%	+0.9 pp ▲	#43	[4]
International share of mathematics & statistics master's	13%	**9.3%**[2025]	−3.6 pp ▼	55%	+6.1 pp ▲	#38	[4]
International share of biological & biomedical sciences master's	4.5%	**4.7%**[2025]	+0.2 pp ▲	23%	+6.2 pp ▲	#46	[4]
International share of physical sciences master's	18%	**20%**[2025]	+1.5 pp ▲	33%	+3.6 pp ▲	#39	[4]
International share of all research doctorates	16%	**17%**[2025]	+1.1 pp ▲	25%	−1.0 pp ▼	#40	[4]
International share of STEM research doctorates	25%	**21%**[2025]	−3.8 pp ▼	43%	−0.5 pp ▼	#47	[4]
International share of computer & information sciences research doctorates	19%	**30%**[2025]	+10.2 pp ▲	56%	+2.0 pp ▲	#24	[4]
International share of engineering & eng. technology research doctorates	40%	**27%**[2025]	−12.6 pp ▼	55%	−1.0 pp ▼	#43	[4]
International share of mathematics & statistics research doctorates	18%	**17%**[2025]	−0.4 pp ▼	53%	+2.9 pp ▲	#25	[4]
International share of biological & biomedical sciences research doctorates	9.1%	**10%**[2025]	+1.3 pp ▲	23%	−4.3 pp ▼	#40	[4]
International share of physical sciences research doctorates	19%	**20%**[2025]	+0.9 pp ▲	38%	−1.1 pp ▼	#37	[4]
Active F-1/M-1 students, all levels	13K	**9.26K**[2026]	−29% ▼	1.19M	−0.1% ▼	#30	[20]
Share of U.S. active F-1/M-1 students	1.1%	**0.8%**[2026]	−0.3 pp ▼	–	–	#30	[20]
Share of F-1/M-1 students from India	13%	**27%**[2026]	+13.9 pp ▲	27%	+11.4 pp ▲	#19	[20]
Share of F-1/M-1 students from China	29%	**9.2%**[2026]	−19.4 pp ▼	18%	−11.7 pp ▼	#32	[20]
Share from the two largest countries of origin	42%	**36%**[2026]	−5.8 pp ▼	45%	−0.3 pp ▼	#30	[20]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). “pp” is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

COLORADO – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS (CONTINUED)							
Countries of citizenship represented	164	**160**[2026]	−2.4% ▼	219	−2.7% ▼	#30	[20]
Active STEM F-1/M-1 students	5.41K	**6.83K**[2026]	+26% ▲	749K	+61% ▲	#23	[20]
Active STEM master's students	2.01K	**3.23K**[2026]	+61% ▲	393K	+90% ▲	#23	[20]
Active STEM doctoral students	1.31K	**1.88K**[2026]	+44% ▲	158K	+61% ▲	#23	[20]
Share of STEM master's students from India	63%	**65%**[2026]	+1.8 pp ▲	58%	−1.8 pp ▼	#15	[20]
U.S. students studying abroad for credit, from the state's institutions	6.41K[2017]	**7.22K**[2024]	+13% ▲	–	–	#14	[1]
Economic contribution of international students	$471M[2018]	**$410M**[2024]	−13% ▼	$42.9B	+4.6% ▲	#23	[2]
Jobs supported by international students' spending	6.03K[2018]	**3.72K**[2024]	−38% ▼	356K	−22% ▼	#22	[2]
Share of U.S. student and exchange-visitor admissions, by destination	1.0%	**1.1%**[2024]	+0.1 pp ▲	–	–	#20	[16]
Share of U.S. F-1 student admissions, by destination	0.8%	**0.7%**[2024]	−0.1 pp ▼	–	–	#23	[16]
Share of U.S. J-1 exchange-visitor admissions, by destination	1.8%	**2.6%**[2024]	+0.8 pp ▲	–	–	#12	[16]
J-1 exchange visitors starting a program in the state	8.14K	**8.16K**[2025]	+0.2% ▲	275K	−14% ▼	#12	[18]
GRADUATE EDUCATION AND RESEARCH							
Graduate students in science & engineering	13.6K	**13.5K**[2016]	−1.0% ▼	620K	+0.4% ▲	#16	[9]
S&E graduate students on temporary visas	2.94K	**2.9K**[2016]	−1.3% ▼	241K	+2.3% ▲	#21	[9]
Temporary-visa share of S&E graduate students	22%	**22%**[2016]	−0.1 pp ▼	39%	+0.7 pp ▲	#47	[9]
Temporary-visa share of engineering graduate students	40%	**40%**[2016]	−0.3 pp ▼	57%	0.0 pp	#43	[9]
S&E postdoctoral appointees	1.27K	**1.3K**[2016]	+2.4% ▲	45.7K	+1.0% ▲	#9	[9]
Temporary-visa share of S&E postdocs	28%	**28%**[2016]	−0.6 pp ▼	56%	−0.9 pp ▼	#49	[9]
University R&D spending	$1.27B	**$2.19B**[2024]	+72% ▲	$118B	+71% ▲	#16	[6]
Share of U.S. university R&D	1.9%	**1.9%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#16	[6]
Federally funded share of university R&D	73%	**71%**[2024]	−1.9 pp ▼	55%	−0.2 pp ▼	#2	[6]
Business-funded share of university R&D	6.5%	**4.9%**[2024]	−1.6 pp ▼	5.4%	−0.4 pp ▼	#18	[6]
State- and locally funded share of university R&D	3.1%	**3.3%**[2024]	+0.2 pp ▲	5.2%	−0.4 pp ▼	#37	[6]
University R&D in mathematics and computer science	$24.2M	**$52.4M**[2024]	2.17× ▲	$5.12B	+97% ▲	#22	[6]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

COLORADO – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
GRADUATE EDUCATION AND RESEARCH (CONTINUED)							
University R&D in engineering	$218M	**$352M**[2024]	+62% ▲	$19.3B	+74% ▲	#18	[6]
University R&D personnel, headcount	16.6K	**19.5K**[2024]	+18% ▲	1.09M	+20% ▲	#20	[6]
Federal R&D obligations to the state	$3.51B	**$9.21B**[2024]	2.63× ▲	$193B	+53% ▲	#7	[8]
Federal R&D obligations to universities in the state	$562M	**$1.06B**[2024]	+89% ▲	$44.4B	+64% ▲	#13	[8]
Defense R&D obligations to the state	$655M	**$6.38B**[2024]	9.73× ▲	$97.2B	+60% ▲	#5	[8]
Health (HHS/NIH) R&D obligations to the state	$351M	**$596M**[2024]	+70% ▲	$48.5B	+62% ▲	#20	[8]
NSF, NIH, NASA and DOE Science grants performed in the state	$792M	**$1.13B**[2025]	+42% ▲	$45B	+47% ▲	#12	[19]
Federal R&D contracts performed in the state	$2.14B	**$2.86B**[2026]	+721.0 ▲	$59.3B	+22,105.9 ▲	#8	[19]
COLLEGE COSTS AND OUTCOMES							
Median earnings 10 years after entering college	$45.5K[2020]	**$48.9K**[2022]	+7.6% ▲	$47.5K	+11% ▲	#23	[15]
Median earnings 1 year after completing	–	**$48.4K**[2025]	–	$47.5K	–	#24	[15]
Median debt of completers	$20.3K	**$18.8K**[2024]	−7.4% ▼	$17.6K	−4.6% ▼	#32	[15]
STEM bachelor's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$68.6K**[2025]	–	$68.2K	–	#18	[15]
Non-STEM bachelor's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$50.3K**[2025]	–	$51.9K	–	#28	[15]
Bachelor's graduates: median earnings 5 years out	–	**$66.9K**[2025]	–	$68.1K	–	#25	[15]
STEM master's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$86.3K**[2025]	–	$91.6K	–	#33	[15]
Six-year bachelor's graduation rate, 4-year institutions	56%	**60%**[2024]	+4.0 pp ▲	65%	+5.3 pp ▲	#31	[4]
Completion within 150% of normal time, 2-year institutions	43%	**53%**[2024]	+10.4 pp ▲	41%	+12.1 pp ▲	#8	[4]
In-state tuition & fees, public 4-year	$11.9K	**$9.74K**[2023]	−18% ▼	$9.71K	−14% ▼	#29	[4]
State & local appropriations per FTE, public institutions	$902	**$1.51K**[2024]	+67% ▲	$11.4K	+22% ▲	#51	[4]
Tuition share of core revenue, public institutions	94%	**91%**[2024]	−3.3 pp ▼	43%	−5.9 pp ▼	#1	[4]
Average full-time faculty salary (9/10-month)	$107K[2016]	**$98K**[2024]	−8.6% ▼	$106K	−4.6% ▼	#21	[4]
WHERE STUDENTS AND GRADUATES GO							
International graduates on OPT working in the state where they studied	48%	**46%**[2016]	−1.6 pp ▼	44%	−1.8 pp ▼	#15	[21]
OPT retention, bachelor's graduates	61%	**66%**[2016]	+4.5 pp ▲	58%	+0.3 pp ▲	#11	[21]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

COLORADO – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WHERE STUDENTS AND GRADUATES GO (CONTINUED)							
OPT retention, master's graduates	48%	**44%**[2016]	−3.8 pp ▼	39%	−2.5 pp ▼	#12	[21]
OPT retention, STEM graduates	38%	**38%**[2016]	−0.2 pp ▼	37%	−1.9 pp ▼	#18	[21]
OPT workers employed in the state per OPT graduate of its schools	0.94	**1.01**[2016]	+0.1 ▲	1.00	0.0	#15	[21]
STEM OPT extensions approved, by state of the school	194	**320**[2016]	+65% ▲	41.2K	+51% ▲	#27	[21]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 1 year after graduating (PSEO)	73%[2016]	**72%**[2019]	−0.8 pp ▼	72%	−0.1 pp ▼	#12	[11]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 5 years after graduating (PSEO)	–	**64%**[2016]	–	65%	–	#12	[11]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 10 years after graduating (PSEO)	–	**65%**[2010]	–	64%	–	#10	[11]
STEM bachelor's graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	69%[2016]	**70%**[2019]	+0.5 pp ▲	67%	+1.5 pp ▲	#8	[11]
Master's graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	–	**64%**[2016]	–	66%	–	#17	[11]
Doctoral graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	–	**48%**[2016]	–	49%	–	#20	[11]
Bachelor's graduates' median earnings 1 year out (PSEO)	$45.6K[2016]	**$47.8K**[2019]	+4.9% ▲	$48.1K	+2.3% ▲	#18	[11]
Bachelor's graduates' median earnings 5 years out (PSEO)	–	**$67.6K**[2016]	–	$67.3K	–	#14	[11]
STEM bachelor's graduates' median earnings 1 year out (PSEO)	$57K[2016]	**$58.6K**[2019]	+2.7% ▲	$59.3K	+0.1% ▲	#16	[11]
Net domestic migration of bachelor's-plus adults, per 1,000 residents	+10.1	**+4.9**[2025]	−5.2 ▼	–	–	#14	[12]
Net domestic migration of graduate-degree holders	+5.59K	**+275**[2025]	−5,314.0 ▼	–	–	#25	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who moved in from another state	4.6%	**3.6%**[2025]	−1.0 pp ▼	–	–	#11	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who moved out to another state	3.6%	**3.1%**[2025]	−0.5 pp ▼	–	–	#17	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who arrived from abroad in the past year	10.1K	**9.18K**[2025]	−9.4% ▼	–	–	#17	[12]
First-time students who are in-state residents	72%[2016]	**70%**[2024]	−2.5 pp ▼	–	–	#30	[4]
Net student migration (per 100 resident first-time students)	+4[2016]	**+0**[2024]	−3.0 ▼	–	–	#35	[4]
Recent high school graduates who go to college out of state	26%[2016]	**36%**[2022]	+9.6 pp ▲	22%	+2.5 pp ▲	#13	[3]
WORK VISAS AND GREEN CARDS							
Certified H-1B positions, by worksite	15.7K	**8.58K**[2025]	−45% ▼	914K	−24% ▼	#20	[17]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

COLORADO – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WORK VISAS AND GREEN CARDS (CONTINUED)							
Share of U.S. certified H-1B positions	1.3%	**0.9%**^{2025}	−0.4 pp ▼	–	–	#20	[17]
STEM share of certified H-1B positions	90%	**79%**^{2025}	−11.6 pp ▼	76%	−7.8 pp ▼	#13	[17]
Median offered H-1B wage, nominal dollars	$72K	**$115K**^{2025}	+60% ▲	$119K	+66% ▲	#9	[17]
H-1B positions at H-1B-dependent employers	57%	**17%**^{2025}	−40.5 pp ▼	22%	−25.7 pp ▼	#30	[17]
Green-card labor certifications	615	**1.42K**^{2025}	2.31× ▲	138K	+75% ▲	#21	[17]
Share of PERM certifications for citizens of India	54%	**40%**^{2024}	−14.2 pp ▼	47%	−10.6 pp ▼	#23	[17]
PERM certifications for workers on F-1 student visas	2.3%	**7.9%**^{2024}	+5.6 pp ▲	8.7%	+4.9 pp ▲	#33	[17]
PERM workers with a master's or doctorate	53%	**40%**^{2024}	−13.6 pp ▼	47%	−4.9 pp ▼	#27	[17]
STEM share of PERM certifications	73%	**46%**^{2025}	−27.1 pp ▼	49%	−25.8 pp ▼	#21	[17]
Median offered PERM wage, nominal dollars	$92.6K	**$83.7K**^{2025}	−9.6% ▼	$100K	+9.9% ▲	#26	[17]
New lawful permanent residents (green cards), by state of residence	12.7K	**17.4K**^{2024}	+37% ▲	1.36M	+30% ▲	#17	[16]
Share of U.S. new green-card holders	1.2%	**1.3%**^{2024}	+0.1 pp ▲	–	–	#17	[16]
People naturalized as U.S. citizens, by state of residence	9.42K	**9.26K**^{2024}	−1.7% ▼	819K	+12% ▲	#19	[16]
Share of U.S. naturalizations	1.3%	**1.1%**^{2024}	−0.2 pp ▼	–	–	#19	[16]
Share of U.S. temporary-worker admissions, by destination	0.9%	**0.9%**^{2024}	0.0 pp	–	–	#16	[16]
Share of U.S. H-1B worker admissions, by destination	0.9%	**0.8%**^{2024}	−0.1 pp ▼	–	–	#17	[16]
Share of U.S. L-1 intracompany-transferee admissions, by destination	0.9%	**1.0%**^{2024}	+0.2 pp ▲	–	–	#17	[16]
Share of U.S. O-1 extraordinary-ability worker admissions, by destination	0.6%	**1.0%**^{2024}	+0.4 pp ▲	–	–	#14	[16]
New H-1B approvals (initial), by employer state	710	**1.02K**^{2026}	+44% ▲	127K	+14% ▲	#22	[13]
Continuing H-1B approvals, by employer state	1.08K	**1.73K**^{2026}	+60% ▲	268K	+52% ▲	#24	[13]
Share of U.S. new H-1B approvals	0.6%	**0.8%**^{2026}	+0.2 pp ▲	–	–	#22	[13]
Denial rate, new H-1B petitions	5.0%	**3.0%**^{2026}	−1.9 pp ▼	3.4%	−3.0 pp ▼	#35	[13]
New H-1B approvals at colleges and schools (NAICS 61)	25%	**22%**^{2026}	−3.1 pp ▼	8.6%	−1.7 pp ▼	#22	[13]
New H-1B approvals in professional, scientific & technical services	39%	**36%**^{2026}	−3.7 pp ▼	44%	−12.5 pp ▼	#19	[13]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). “pp” is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

COLORADO – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WORK VISAS AND GREEN CARDS (CONTINUED)							
Five largest employers' share of new H-1B approvals	32%	**25%**^{2026}	−6.8 pp ▼	9.1%	−6.7 pp ▼	#37	[13]
STEM WORKFORCE AND INNOVATION							
Workers in STEM occupations	224K	**357K**^{2024}	+59% ▲	13.7M	+51% ▲	#16	[12]
STEM workers as a share of all workers	8.0%	**11%**^{2024}	+3.0 pp ▲	8.1%	+2.1 pp ▲	#5	[12]
Foreign-born share of STEM workers	11%	**12%**^{2024}	+0.6 pp ▲	24%	+1.6 pp ▲	#34	[12]
Foreign-born share of STEM workers with a graduate degree	17%	**20%**^{2024}	+2.7 pp ▲	41%	+2.2 pp ▲	#40	[12]
Foreign-born share of STEM workers with a doctorate	19%	**26%**^{2024}	+6.9 pp ▲	47%	+0.9 pp ▲	#20	[12]
Noncitizen share of STEM workers	6.0%	**5.4%**^{2024}	−0.6 pp ▼	11%	+0.7 pp ▲	#37	[12]
STEM workers born abroad who arrived in the last 10 years	3.9%	**3.4%**^{2024}	−0.5 pp ▼	7.5%	+0.3 pp ▲	#40	[12]
Share of foreign-born STEM workers born in India	28%	**22%**^{2024}	−5.8 pp ▼	28%	+0.7 pp ▲	#23	[12]
Foreign-born share of residents	9.8%	**10%**^{2025}	+0.5 pp ▲	15%	+1.3 pp ▲	#19	[12]
Foreign-born share of graduate-degree holders, 25+	9.6%	**12%**^{2025}	+2.5 pp ▲	21%	+2.8 pp ▲	#28	[12]
STEM jobs, employer survey	200K	**263K**^{2025}	+32% ▲	10.4M	+26% ▲	#16	[10]
STEM jobs concentration vs the U.S., location quotient	1.37	**1.37**^{2025}	0.0	1.00	0.0	#6	[10]
Mean annual STEM wage, nominal	$91.3K	**$125K**^{2025}	+37% ▲	$120K	+38% ▲	#9	[10]
Median software developer wage, nominal	$110K^{2019}	**$138K**^{2025}	+26% ▲	$136K	+26% ▲	#8	[10]
Software developer jobs	36.5K	**43.3K**^{2025}	+19% ▲	1.69M	+48% ▲	#15	[10]
Mean annual wage, all occupations, nominal	$51.2K	**$77.2K**^{2025}	+51% ▲	$69.8K	+44% ▲	#9	[10]
Patents granted to assignees in the state	1.63K	**2.08K**^{2025}	+28% ▲	135K	−0.6% ▼	#16	[22]
Share of U.S.-assignee patents	1.2%	**1.5%**^{2025}	+0.3 pp ▲	–	–	#16	[22]
Share of the state's patents in digital technologies	38%	**42%**^{2025}	+4.3 pp ▲	43%	+1.6 pp ▲	#12	[22]
Share of the state's patents in life sciences	17%	**17%**^{2025}	−0.7 pp ▼	17%	+0.4 pp ▲	#27	[22]
Share of the state's patents in semiconductors	2.0%	**0.9%**^{2025}	−1.1 pp ▼	2.9%	−1.7 pp ▼	#21	[22]
Women's share of inventors on the state's patents	8.5%	**11%**^{2025}	+2.7 pp ▲	14%	+3.4 pp ▲	#30	[22]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

Sources

[1] Institute of International Education. *Open Doors Report on International Educational Exchange: State Fact Sheets*. Editions 2020–2026. New York: Institute of International Education. https://opendoorsdata.org/. Accessed November 2026.

[2] NAFSA: Association of International Educators. *NAFSA International Student Economic Value Tool*. Academic years 2018–19 to 2024–25. Washington, DC: NAFSA. https://www.nafsa.org/isev. Accessed November 2026.

[3] National Center for Education Statistics. *Digest of Education Statistics*. Editions 1995–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education, Institute of Education Sciences. https://nces.ed.gov/programs/digest/. Accessed November 2026.

[4] National Center for Education Statistics. *Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS)*. Survey files, 1980–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education, Institute of Education Sciences. https://nces.ed.gov/ipeds/. Accessed November 2026.

[5] National Center for Education Statistics. *National Assessment of Educational Progress (NAEP)*. NAEP Data Service, 1990–2024. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education, Institute of Education Sciences. https://www.nationsreportcard.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[6] National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics. *Higher Education Research and Development Survey*. Data tables, FY2003–2024. Alexandria, VA: National Science Foundation. https://ncses.nsf.gov/surveys/higher-education-research-development. Accessed November 2026.

[7] National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics. *Survey of Earned Doctorates*. Data tables, 1994–2025. Alexandria, VA: National Science Foundation. https://ncses.nsf.gov/surveys/earned-doctorates. Accessed November 2026.

[8] National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics. *Survey of Federal Funds for Research and Development*. Data tables, FY1985–2024. Alexandria, VA: National Science Foundation. https://ncses.nsf.gov/surveys/federal-funds-research-development. Accessed November 2026.

[9] National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics. *Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates in Science and Engineering*. Data tables, 1994–2024. Alexandria, VA: National Science Foundation. https://ncses.nsf.gov/surveys/graduate-students-postdoctorates-s-e. Accessed November 2026.

[10] U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics. *Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics*. State estimates, 1999–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Labor. https://www.bls.gov/oes/. Accessed November 2026.

[11] U.S. Census Bureau, Center for Economic Studies. *Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes (PSEO)*. Release R2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Commerce. https://lehd.ces.census.gov/data/pseo_experimental.html. Accessed November 2026.

[12] U.S. Census Bureau. *American Community Survey*. 1-year estimates and Public Use Microdata Sample, 2010–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Commerce. https://data.census.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[13] U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services. *H-1B Employer Data Hub*. Fiscal years 2009–2026. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Homeland Security. https://www.uscis.gov/tools/reports-and-studies/h-1b-employer-data-hub. Accessed November 2026.

[14] U.S. Department of Education, Office for Civil Rights. *Civil Rights Data Collection*. School years 1980–81 to 2023–24. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education. https://civilrightsdata.ed.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[15] U.S. Department of Education. *College Scorecard*. Institution and field-of-study data, 1996–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education. https://collegescorecard.ed.gov/data/. Accessed November 2026.

[16] U.S. Department of Homeland Security, Office of Homeland Security Statistics. *Yearbook of Immigration Statistics*. Fiscal years 1996–2024. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Homeland Security. https://ohss.dhs.gov/topics/immigration/yearbook. Accessed November 2026.

[17] U.S. Department of Labor, Employment and Training Administration, Office of Foreign Labor Certification. *LCA and PERM Disclosure Data*. Fiscal years 2008–2026. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Labor. https://www.dol.gov/agencies/eta/foreign-labor/performance. Accessed November 2026.

[18] U.S. Department of State, Bureau of Educational and Cultural Affairs. *BridgeUSA: Exchange Visitor Program Participants by State*. 2015–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of State. https://j1visa.state.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[19] U.S. Department of the Treasury, Bureau of the Fiscal Service. *USAspending.gov*. Award data, FY2008–2026. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of the Treasury. https://www.usaspending.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[20] U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement, Student and Exchange Visitor Program. *SEVIS by the Numbers: Data Mapping Tool*. Monthly data, 2014–2026. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Homeland Security. https://studyinthestates.dhs.gov/sevis-data-mapping-tool. Accessed November 2026.

[21] U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement. *Student and Exchange Visitor Information System (SEVIS) Data*. Freedom of Information Act releases, 2008–2016. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Homeland Security. https://www.ice.gov/foia/library. Accessed November 2026.

[22] U.S. Patent and Trademark Office. *PatentsView*. Annualized patent data, grant years 1976–2025. Alexandria, VA: U.S. Patent and Trademark Office. https://patentsview.org/. Accessed November 2026.